

Impact Assessment & Evaluation of NSAP

Final Report

Submitted to:



ग्रामीण विकास विभाग - Ministry of Rural Development
कृषि विभाग - GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
NSAP
National Social Assistance Programme
Pension Processing System (NSAP-PFS) - State Scheme enabled

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Ministry of Rural Development,
Core 5A, 2nd Floor, India Habitat Centre,
Lodhi Road, New Delhi-03.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP), launched in August 1995, was designed to provide a safety net for the most disadvantaged and vulnerable sections of Indian society. Currently, NSAP has five major schemes under its ambit: Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS), Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS), Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS), National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS), and the Annapurna Scheme. Over the years, NSAP has evolved into a key pillar of India's social protection architecture, with substantial financial outlays aimed at ensuring basic income security for the poorest households. However, the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India's 2023 performance audit revealed wide state-level disparities and several systemic gaps in planning, financial management, and monitoring. The audit found instances of both exclusions where eligible beneficiaries were left out and inclusion errors where ineligible persons received benefits due to weaknesses in verification, data maintenance, and authentication systems. Additionally, irregularities in payment schedules and partial non-compliance with Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) mechanisms were noted, prompting a series of corrective recommendations from the CAG. Against this backdrop, a regular independent evaluation of NSAP was critical to gauge its effectiveness, assess progress toward its objectives, and identify measures to enhance delivery and accountability. In this context, the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) commissioned Academy of Management Studies (AMS) to undertake an Impact Assessment and Evaluation of NSAP to assess the programme's achievements and recommend actionable strategies for its strengthening and continuation.

The broad objectives of the study were to:

- Analyze the achievements of NSAP objectives,
- Assess scheme-level implementation, and
- Recommend measures to enhance scheme delivery and accountability.

The study employed a mixed-methods approach across ten sample states representing different pension categories, such as Haryana, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh (high), Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh (moderate), and Assam, Chhattisgarh and Bihar (low). Data collection combined structured surveys with 6,000 beneficiaries across 600 Gram Panchayats (GPs), semi-structured interviews with local elected representatives, focus group discussions with community members, and in-depth interviews with district and state level officials to capture both implementation realities and administrative perspectives.

Key findings of the study, mapped against the broad objectives, have been depicted below –

I. Analysis of the achievements of the objectives of NSAP

Reducing financial dependency - About 75.1% of beneficiaries reported that the pension has somewhat reduced their dependence on other earning members of the household, while **16.5% said it has significantly lowered their financial dependency**. These findings highlight that even modest financial support under NSAP enhances beneficiaries' financial autonomy and household stability. In states such as Andhra Pradesh and Haryana, where higher state top-ups ranging from ₹1,000 to ₹3,000 per month are provided, the scheme has led to notable improvements in beneficiary satisfaction.

Improvement in Socio-economic status- NSAP pensions have contributed to increased household consumption, improved healthcare access, and enhanced food adequacy, as the study finds that **81-84% of beneficiaries spent the pension amount for food and medicine**. A majority of beneficiaries reported **better access to food (63%)**, an **increased capacity to purchase daily commodities (68%)**, and **improved access to medical care (65%)**. The scheme has also **reduced the need to borrow for subsistence** among half of the respondents. States such as Jammu & Kashmir, Telangana, and Tamil Nadu recorded particularly strong outcomes, with over 70-90% of beneficiaries reporting improvement in these areas.

Ensuring Dignity, Social Security and Safety- Across states, around **67-69% of beneficiaries reported an improvement in their social acceptance, treatment within the family, and self-esteem**, reflecting how the pension contributes to restoring self-worth and social security. States such as Jammu & Kashmir, and Telangana showed widespread positive changes, indicating strong social recognition and empowerment among beneficiaries. However, **13.3% of beneficiaries reported being able to save any portion of their pension**, indicating that while the scheme supports basic sustenance, the amount remains largely inadequate.

II. Scheme level Analysis

Beneficiary Awareness - Awareness level about NSAP schemes is moderate but uneven across states. **31.6% of beneficiaries were aware of the scheme implementing department**, and only about half knew about the central and state contribution components. **Awareness levels were high in Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Tamil Nadu**, where active community engagement and outreach through local institutions and digital campaigns have helped strengthen information flow. In contrast, **limited awareness was observed in states like Bihar, Chhattisgarh, and Gujarat**.

Implementation framework and eligibility- The NSAP framework is found to be effectively implemented across most states, with clear administrative responsibilities at state, district, and Gram Panchayat levels. However, the study observed inconsistencies in beneficiary identification due to reliance on outdated Below Poverty Line (BPL) lists. **Almost all the states covered in this study follows**

the BPL criteria. Though a very few instances of exclusion of eligible and inclusion of ineligible beneficiaries were reported, states such as **Haryana, which use a Family ID database for automatic verification, have shown higher accuracy and transparency in targeting.**

Disbursement, DBT and Beneficiary Convenience - The implementation of **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)** across all states (except Andhra Pradesh) has improved transparency and accountability in pension delivery, with **97% of beneficiaries reporting that their Aadhaar is linked to their bank or post office accounts.** However, delays in pension disbursement were observed in some states due to connectivity issues, biometric authentication failures, and administrative bottlenecks. **Andhra Pradesh and Haryana** stood out for ensuring timely and predictable payments, including **doorstep delivery** of pensions for the elderly and persons with disabilities. In contrast, states such as **Jammu & Kashmir and Assam** continue to face challenges related to accessibility of financial institutions. **Long-distance travel to collect pensions remains a major challenge in Gujarat, Telangana, and Tamil Nadu,** affecting over 60% of beneficiaries and adding to their financial and physical hardship.

Satisfaction and Adequacy - **73% of the beneficiaries surveyed were satisfied with the overall process of the pension scheme.** However, the majority also reported that the pension amount is insufficient to meet essential needs such as food, healthcare, and utilities. **89% of the beneficiaries believed that the government should contribute more funds to increase the pension amount** and improve related services. Beneficiaries in **states with higher state top-ups** (Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu) **showed significantly greater satisfaction** and improved well-being compared to those in low-top-up states (Assam, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh).

Social Audit- The study also found that social audits are not conducted regularly across many states, limiting community oversight and accountability. Overall, **53.5% of gram panchayat and ward officials confirmed that a social audit had been conducted,** while 30.7% reported none, and 15.8% were unaware. The highest incidence of social audits was recorded in Assam (86.7%), Uttar Pradesh (80%), and Andhra Pradesh (76.7%), **indicating a relatively strong monitoring and transparency in these states.**

Grievance Redressal- **377 out of 600 panchayat and ward officials reported having a grievance redressal system in place.** Mechanisms were most prevalent in Assam (95%), Andhra Pradesh (90%), and Telangana (90%), while Jammu & Kashmir (0%) and Tamil Nadu (46.7%) lagged significantly. **Gram Sabha meetings emerged as the most common platform for raising grievances** (reported by 80.1% of officials), with delays in pension disbursement being the most common concern among beneficiaries.

Best Practices- In Jammu & Kashmir, **awareness about the scheme is widely promoted through print, electronic, and community-based platforms** such as Anganwadi and ASHA workers. Haryana has introduced a transparent **Family ID system** that automatically updates beneficiary information with minimum interference from gram panchayat and ward officials, ensuring fair and efficient delivery.

In Andhra Pradesh and Haryana, pension disbursement mechanisms are highly efficient, with **doorstep delivery of benefits for elderly and disabled persons who cannot travel**.

III. Recommendations & Way Forward

Justification for the continuation of the scheme: Despite India's rapid economic growth, the central pension component has remained unchanged since 2012, leading to **significant decline in its real value due to inflation and rising living costs**. Strengthening and expanding NSAP is therefore critical to ensuring dignity and social security for vulnerable citizens. Moreover, **aligning pension levels with inflation, poverty benchmarks, and international norms will make the scheme more adequate and equitable**.

Recommendations on improving the scheme implementation: The **Below Poverty Line (BPL) criteria should be replaced with a more reliable and integrated beneficiary identification system** based on verified databases such as Aadhaar, social registries, or state Family ID systems to ensure accurate targeting and reduce duplication. The **criteria and verification process may be left to the discretion of individual states**. To ensure last-mile efficiency, **beneficiary facilitation centres at village or ward levels could be established to assist** the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities in registration, documentation, and grievance redressal. The **pension amount should be suitably revised by introducing a National Floor Pension, linked to the Consumer Price Index (CPI) and periodically adjusted to reflect the cost of living**, thereby ensuring a decent standard of life. Mechanisms for doorstep pension delivery, as practiced in Haryana and Andhra Pradesh, should be adopted by other states to support beneficiaries with mobility challenges. Further, **convergence with other welfare schemes** such as PMAY, NFSA, health insurance, and other livelihood programmes should be established to enhance social and economic resilience. The **grievance redressal system should be made more accessible** through toll-free helplines, Panchayat-level complaint cells, and escalation protocols integrated with the NSAP-PPS portal. **Regular social audits, data-driven monitoring dashboards, and periodic third-party evaluations should be institutionalized** to ensure transparency, accountability, and continuous improvement in scheme delivery.

In conclusion, the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) continues to play a significant role in India's social protection framework, contributing to poverty reduction and providing social security to the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities. However, the study highlights the need to strengthen key areas such as beneficiary identification, timely disbursement of pensions, and proper maintenance of records to improve efficiency and transparency. Enhancing convergence with state schemes, ensuring regular indexation of pension amounts to inflation, and adopting a robust monitoring and grievance redressal system will be crucial to achieving the scheme's goal of ensuring a life of dignity and security for all vulnerable citizens.



Context – Background Study

1.1 INTRODUCTION

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) derives its mandate from Article 41 of the Constitution, as part of the Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP)¹, which states that “the State shall, within the limits of its economic capacity and development, make effective provision for securing the right to...public assistance in case of unemployment, old age, sickness and disablement, and in other cases of undeserved want.” Although not enforceable in the court of law as a Fundamental Right, Prabhat Patnaik (2018)² argues that “adequate pension to the elderly is an economic right”, which is “not codified as such in the Constitution”, but “implicit and as fundamental as the explicitly-codified fundamental rights”. To fulfil the constitutional obligation, Government of India introduced NSAP in 1995 as a welfare programme aimed at providing basic financial support to the destitutes and BPL households. The scheme is being implemented by the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD). It includes 3 pension schemes targeting old aged (above 60 years), widows, and disabled persons living below poverty line. In addition, a family benefit scheme offering one-time assistance to the bereaved family in the event of death of the breadwinner is also included under the ambit of NSAP.

As per the CAG report of 2023, during 2017-21, Government of India allocated ₹ 34,432 crore for NSAP. In addition to this ₹ 1,09,573 crore was allocated by States and UTs to offer additional assistance for pension and for covering beneficiaries that were left out from the coverage of NSAP. A total of 2.83 crore beneficiaries were covered annually through funds allocated by central government, and additional 1.82 crore beneficiaries were covered through States/UTs funds. The coverage of the scheme spans across both, urban and rural areas across all states and UTs in the country. The beneficiaries for the scheme are identified on the basis of BPL list prepared by the states and UTs as per guidelines issued by the MoRD for rural areas and by the Ministry of Urban Housing & Poverty Alleviation for urban areas. In addition, the states also have the power to identify additional eligible beneficiaries in case they identify cases where the person’s name is not included in the BPL list, but he or she satisfies the given eligibility criteria.

¹ The DPSP are a set of guidelines in Part IV of the Indian Constitution (Art. 36 – 51) that aim to create a welfare state by promoting socio-economic justice.

² Patnaik, P. (2018). The great pension scandal: A laughable pittance of Rs. 200 a month!. *News click*. Accessed at <https://www.newsclick.in/great-pension-scandal-laughable-pittance-rs-200-month>

The Ministry releases scheme-wise funds to all states/UTs as per the estimated number of beneficiaries under each scheme on an annual basis. According to NSAP guidelines, the States/UTs are encouraged to provide an additional amount at least equivalent to the assistance provided by the Central Government so that the beneficiaries can get a decent level of assistance. The Programme aims to achieve universal coverage of eligible persons through proactive identification. The Programme also seeks to have automatic convergence with other schemes to provide maximum benefit to the beneficiaries.

1.1.1 Components of NSAP

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) comprises five major sub-schemes aimed at providing financial and food security support to vulnerable sections of the population. These include:

- **Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS):** Offers financial assistance of ₹200 per month to individuals aged 60–79 years and ₹500 per month to those aged 80 and above. Currently, more than 221 lakh beneficiaries are covered.
- **Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS):** Provides ₹300 per month to widows aged 40–79 years and ₹500 to those 80 and above. Currently, more than 67 lakh beneficiaries are covered.
- **Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS):** Financial assistance of ₹300 per month to individuals with severe or multiple disabilities aged 18–79 and ₹500 to those aged 80 years and above. Currently, more than 8.8 lakh beneficiaries are covered.
- **National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS):** Grants one-time financial assistance of ₹20,000 to bereaved families upon the death of the primary breadwinner aged between 18 and 59 years. The upper limit of households is 3.58 lakh.
- **Annapurna Scheme:** Provided 10 kg of food grains per month free of cost to those senior citizens who, though eligible, were not receiving old age pension. It was a demand-based scheme with an upper limit of 8.32 lakh beneficiaries.

However, there has been no uptake of the scheme since 2019. This may be attributed to the fact that most households now receive food grains under the National Food Security Act (NFSA), which, while not part of NSAP, effectively addresses their food security needs.

Initially launched as a centrally sponsored scheme, NSAP underwent several changes, including the transfer of the National Maternity Benefit Scheme to the Department of Family Welfare, the introduction of Annapurna in 2000, and its devolution to state plans in 2002–03. In 2007, coverage was expanded to all BPL persons, and in 2009, pensions for widows and persons with disabilities were introduced. The scheme specifically targets Below Poverty Line (BPL) individuals and continues to evolve to address the needs of India's most vulnerable populations.³

³ <https://nsap.gov.in>

1.1.2 Funding & Coverage

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) has undergone significant changes in its funding and coverage since its inception. Initially transferred to the State Plan in 2002, funds were routed through the Ministry of Finance for States and the Ministry of Home Affairs for Union Territories until 2013–14. However, from 1st April 2014, NSAP was converted into a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS), and since then, the Ministry of Rural Development has been directly releasing funds to States and UTs. Notably, in December 2016, NSAP was designated as a “Core of the Core” scheme by NITI Aayog. Currently, the allocation of central assistance is based on either the State Cap or the digitized number of beneficiaries on the NSAP-Pension Payment System (PPS), whichever is lower. The State Cap, i.e., the number of beneficiaries under each scheme for each State/UT is derived using the 2001 Census population and the poverty ratio as estimated by the erstwhile Planning Commission. Currently, NSAP provides pensions to approximately 3 crores Below Poverty Line (BPL) beneficiaries, and States determine the estimated number of beneficiaries for the following year based on reports from the previous year. In addition to the central support, States supplement the pension amount, ranging from ₹50 to ₹5700 per month, and extend coverage to additional beneficiaries using their own resources. This has enabled around 5.87 crore additional pensioners to be covered under various State-run schemes, bringing the total number of beneficiaries receiving pension support under NSAP and State schemes to nearly 9 crores. The three pension schemes namely, IGNOAPS, IGNDPS and IGNWPS are 100% saturated. However, National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS) is demand based. To improve transparency and ensure faster transactions, the NSAP pension schemes were brought under the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) schemes in December 2014.⁴ Many state governments have their own social pension schemes for vulnerable groups. Hence, there remains significant variation across States in eligibility criteria, assistance norms, and benefit amounts, reflecting diverse policy approaches to social assistance.

Budget Allocation

The budget allocation for the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) has remained largely stagnant between FY 2021-22 and FY 2024-25, reflecting limited fiscal expansion in social pensions. Under IGNOAPS, allocations stabilized around ₹6,600–₹7,000 crore in subsequent years, constituting nearly 70% of the total NSAP budget.

Similar stability is observed under IGNWPS and IGNDPS, with allocations around ₹2,000 crore and ₹290 crore, respectively, indicating no major enhancement in benefit size or coverage. In contrast, the National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS) shows fluctuating allocations, with a notable reduction in 2024-25 (RE) to ₹300 crore, suggesting lower uptake or delayed disbursement, while the Annapurna Scheme has become almost nominal at ₹10 crore, signaling its near phase-out.

⁴ NSAP Social Audit Guidelines 2023, <https://nsap.nic.in/>

Overall, total NSAP allocation has remained around ₹9,000-₹9,650 crore over the last four years, with minimal variation between Budget and Revised Estimates. When adjusted for inflation, this stagnation translates into a real-term decline in social protection spending. The trend underscores that while the programme continues to provide a safety net for elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities, its fiscal prioritization has weakened over time, highlighting the need for enhanced budgetary support, periodic indexation of pension amounts, and expansion of beneficiary coverage to sustain its impact.

Scheme / FY (₹ crore)	2021-22 BE	2021-22 RE	2022-23 BE	2022-23 RE	2023-24 BE	2023-24 RE	2024-25 BE	2024-25 RE
IGNOAPS (Old Age)	6,259.08.	5,944.71.	6,564.31.	6,602.09.	6,634.32.	6,634.32.	6,645.90.	7014.90
IGNWPS (Widow)	1,938.80.	1,844.51.	2,027.00.	2,027.00.	2,026.99.	2,026.99.	2,026.99.	2026.99
IGNDPS (Disability)	297.37	284.84	290.00	290.00	290.00.	290.00	290.00	290.00
NFBS (Family Benefit, lump sum)	622.69.	582.74.	675.01.	674.69.	659.00.	644.69	659.00	300.00
Annapurna (Foodgrains for elderly)	62.84	53.98	95.99	95.99	10.01	10.01	10.00	-
Total NSAP (central)	9,200.00	8,730.00	9,652.31	9,652.00 .	9,636.32	9,652.00	9,652.00	9652.00

Source: <https://www.indiabudget.gov.in/>

Scheme Coverage

From FY 2021–22 onwards, the Ministry of Rural Development has made separate budgetary provisions for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) from FY 2021-22 under the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP). In FY 2023–24, an amount of ₹1,733.19 crore was released for SC beneficiaries and ₹1,003.20 crore for ST beneficiaries (as on 31 March 2024). Similarly, in FY 2024-25, up to 31 December 2024, ₹1,386.98 crore and ₹730.58 crore have been released for SC and ST beneficiaries respectively.

Proportion of SC beneficiaries has remained consistent at around 19%, while ST beneficiaries account for about 10% of the total NSAP coverage from FY 2021–22 to FY 2024–25. This steady representation aligns closely with the national demographic share of these groups (SCs: 16.6%, STs: 8.6% as per Census 2011), indicating equitable inclusion in programme coverage. The stable year-on-year increase in absolute numbers of SC and ST beneficiaries also reflects sustained outreach and effective targeting of vulnerable social groups. However, to maintain inclusiveness, continued monitoring of beneficiary identification and fund utilization is necessary to ensure timely disbursement and equitable benefit adequacy across states. The focus should move beyond numeric inclusion to equity in adequacy ensuring SC/ST beneficiaries, who often face multidimensional poverty, receive timely and sufficient payments without procedural delays.

Table 1.2 : Number of beneficiaries (Coverage) since last four years					
Year	Total Beneficiaries	SC Beneficiaries	% of SC	ST Beneficiaries	% of ST
2021–22	29,866,826	5,662,755	18.96%	2,989,377	10.00%
2022–23	30,109,434	5,696,683	18.91%	3,009,052	9.99%
2023–24	30,669,885	5,817,385	18.96%	3,067,788	10.00%
2024–25*	30,229,677	5,739,620	19.00%	3,028,678	10.00%

*As on 31st Decemeber, 2024

Source: Ministry of Rural Development, Annual Report 2024–25, Government of India

1.1.3 Implementing Agencies

The department responsible for implementing the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) varies across states, reflecting differences in their administrative structures for delivering social security. Although the institutional anchor differs, each state aligns the programme with its governance systems to ensure effective outreach and timely pension disbursement to eligible beneficiaries. The state-wise implementing agencies have been presented in the table below:

Table 1.3 : State-wise Implementing Agencies	
States	Name of the department
Society for Elimination of Rural Poverty (SERP) under Rural Development Department	Andhra Pradesh, Telangana
Panchayat & Rural Development	Assam
Revenue Department	Tamil Nadu
Director, Social Defence, SJED	Gujarat
Social Justice, Empowerment, Welfare of SC and Backward Classes and Antyodaya Department	Haryana
Social Welfare Department	Jammu & Kashmir, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh

1.2 RATIONALE OF THE STUDY

NSAP has made significant financial outlays, and is vital for strengthening the social protection system in the country. In 2023, an All-India performance audit of the NSAP was undertaken by CAG, which reflected that although centrally financed, the NSAP's implementation and the amount of benefits, as well as its impact, varies from state to state. The report revealed several irregularities and lapses in the planning, financial management, implementation, and monitoring of the welfare scheme NSAP. It highlighted that as the scheme is being implemented in demand-driven mode, there are chances that many of the eligible beneficiaries are left-out of the

coverage of scheme. On the other hand, it was also noted that many of the ineligible beneficiaries were also drawing benefits from the scheme owing to deficiencies in the verification mechanism, maintenance of requisite data and authentication systems. The evaluation also highlighted lapses in payment mechanism including untimely and irregular payments as well as the system being non-DBT compliant in some states. Based on their observations, the CAG offered multiple recommendations to improve the performance of the scheme.

Regular independent evaluation of the scheme at this juncture therefore assumes great importance to assess the status of scheme performance and identify the key enablers and barriers influencing scheme implementation. It is also important from the perspective of vitality of the scheme to help meet the sustainable development goals which is a prime agenda for the Government. In view of the aforementioned factors, and with the objective of strengthening the monitoring and evaluation systems for scheme implementation, AMS (Academy of Management Studies) was commissioned by the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) through its Department of Rural Development (DoRD) to conduct the “Impact Assessment & Evaluation of NSAP”.

1.3 OBJECTIVES OF THE EVALUATION STUDY

The primary objective of the study was to assess the extent to which the National Social Assistance Programme has achieved its objectives and to suggest solutions that need to be employed to improve the implementation processes/road map for the continuation of the intervention.

The specific objectives of the study are highlighted below:

Specific Objectives:

Specific Objective 1: Analysis of the achievements of the objectives of NSAP

To assess the impact of NSAP in:

- Addressing *poverty alleviation* in the country
- Improving the *socio-economic status* of the rural population
- Ensuring a life of *dignity, social security and safety* of the targeted beneficiaries
- Enabling the beneficiaries to actively participate in economic development

Specific Objective 2: Scheme Level Analysis

ASSESS	ASSESS	EVALUATE	COMPILE
• 1) <i>Implementation framework of NSAP</i> and status of implementation to ascertain the progress made under the scheme vis-à-vis the targets & objectives; • 2) Whether the beneficiaries meet the eligibility criteria mentioned in NSAP guidelines i.e. to assess as to whether any ineligible person(s) are also getting benefits of the NSAP schemes or whether any eligible ones are being left out; • 3) Proactive identification of new beneficiaries, annual verification of existing beneficiaries is being done and database is being maintained and updated regularly by the State/UT; • 4) Whether beneficiaries are getting benefits as per central norm /share • 5) Whether States/UTs are contributing amount equal to or more than the central share. • 6) The socio-economic impact of lower strata (i.e. coverage of SC/ST/OBC beneficiaries) and gender sensitivity (including the third gender) in the various processes of implementation of the programme • 7) The level of convenience for the beneficiaries to collect pension every month. To assess the difficulty / hardship being faced by the beneficiary in receiving benefits viz. remoteness/inaccessibility of banks/ post office from beneficiary's locality and to assess the facilities being provided to old age and disabled persons for withdrawing pension amount/ money from the bank/post office/ Common Service Centres (CSCs)/ Banking Correspondents (BCs)/door step delivery;	• 8) <i>Progress and effectiveness of the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)</i> processes and Aadhaar Payment Bridge (APB). Issues and problems encountered by the implementing agencies and beneficiaries including suggesting solutions to resolve the problems (if any). Also assess the processes in States/Districts where still Cash disbursement is being made and suggesting solutions for improvement; • 9) Level of awareness and clarity about the schemes amongst the beneficiaries and to assess as to whether the beneficiary is aware of the amount being paid by Central Govt. and the State Govt. under the schemes. • 10) To assess the level of satisfaction of beneficiary with regard to the overall process (i.e. identification, sanction & disbursement of benefits and amount disbursed); • 11) The existing information management system (NSAP-PPS) with a view to evaluate the issues related to data integrity • 12) Whether there is any instance of change of name of the programme in any State/UT; • 13) Whether Social Audit of NSAP is being conducted as per NSAP & Social Audit Guidelines and to assess its effectiveness; • 14) Existing Monitoring & Evaluation systems adopted by the States and their effectiveness; • 15) The grievance redressal mechanism at various levels and their effectiveness.	• 16) The disbursement processes, mode of disbursement (in Bank through DBT/APB or in Post office or through money order or in cash) periodicity (monthly, quarterly, or other periodicity) and timely receipts of benefits, reasons for delay and issues thereof; • 17) The status of seeding of authenticated Aadhaar data of beneficiaries as well as their mobile numbers, progress made by the States and issues being faced by them; • 18) Adequacy of the amount, its impact on wellbeing of the beneficiaries/ households and the pattern of utilization of the same	• 19) Details of other pension schemes being implemented by the State/ UT (including amount of pension, eligibility criteria & coverage, etc.) as well as schemes similar to NFBS for giving financial assistance to the bereaved families in case of death of the prime breadwinner. • 20) The best practices being followed by States/ UTs in implementation of the programme and make recommendations. • 21) To identify the constraints in data entry and record updation at district/sub-division level and suggestions to remedy them. Also to identify the gap and difficulties faced by users at various levels, in using the NSAP-PPS

Specific objective 3: Recommendation and way forward

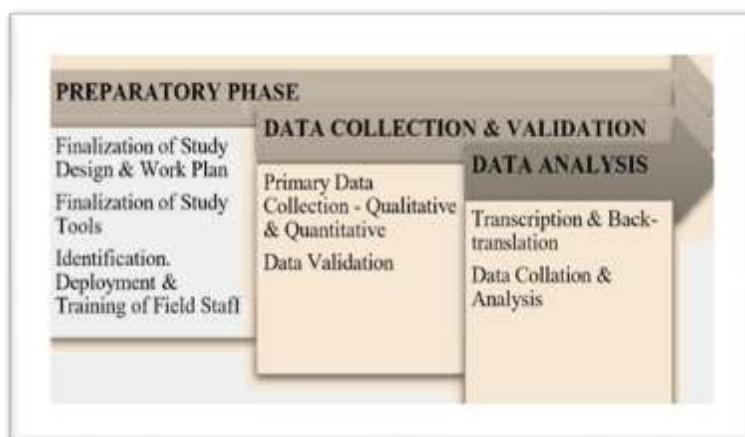
- To suggest comprehensive measures and make recommendations on improving the scheme implementation in the current tenure.
- To recommend justification for continuation of the social security scheme, if any, and suggest the contours of the successor scheme, like components, eligibility criteria, criteria for identifying coverage, fund sharing pattern with Central States/UTs, amount of assistance, possibility of convergence with other government schemes, mode of disbursement of benefits, implementation framework, use of IT and other technology interventions in the implementation etc. so as to provide social assistance to the marginal and vulnerable sections of the country.

Reference period for this Evaluation Study FY 2021-22, 2022-23, 2023-24 & Current year

Study Approach and Methodology

2.1 METHODOLOGICAL APPROACH

As illustrated in the figure alongside, the assignment was undertaken in **3 phases**. In the **first phase**, in close consultation with the project officials of the department of rural development, **the study design and work plan was finalized. Then the study/ data collection tools** that were used to gather information for benchmarking the indicators were developed.



The finalized tools were then translated into the local language for each of the states and converted into **soft format** on **ODK platform** for capturing the primary data in **computer assisted personal interviewing (CAPI)** mode using handheld android **tablets**.

The **identification, deployment and training of the field staff** on the data collection tools was the final activity under this phase. Orientation training was provided to our field teams on the data collection tools and methodologies that they would be required to adopt for the primary survey. Immediately after the orientation training, the field teams were deployed on the field for carrying out primary survey with the targeted respondents. In the **second phase**, the activity for the **collection of both qualitative and quantitative information** was undertaken. **Data validation** was an integral activity under this phase and was undertaken along with the data collection. Quality checks were carried out to detect any errors or gaps. In the **third & final phase**, of the assignment, the **analysis of the data** was undertaken after translating the enumerated data into English. Based on the information collected, the datasets were duly collated and analyzed to develop the required indicators and the findings were accordingly documented into a draft report. After incorporating the feedbacks from the client in the draft report, the agency shall submit the final report for the study to the client. Subsequently, a PowerPoint Presentation will be made for presenting and sharing the findings.

2.2 STUDY DESIGN AND EVALUATION APPROACH

A **cross-sectional** study design was adopted to assess the extent to which the programme has achieved its objectives and to identify the key enablers and barriers that influence the implementation processes. The planned design helped generate reliable measures of the changes that can be attributable to the project.

Additionally, a **mixed methods approach** for data collection was adopted. Both primary and secondary data were collected for the purpose of this study through appropriate quantitative and qualitative study tools. While secondary information was collected from MoRD and other line Departments at the State, District, and sub-District levels, project documents, MIS information, and relevant information available in the public domain; primary data was collected by administering both quantitative and qualitative study tools to the target respondents. All the survey tools were bilingual in English and in the required local language. The tools were finalized after pre-testing and discussions with the DoRD officials.

2.3 DATA COLLECTION METHODOLOGY

The following methodology was adopted for the primary data collection:

➤ **Face-to-Face Interviews (F2F)**

were conducted with beneficiaries from the sampled GPs using the structured questionnaire survey (SQS) method to understand the extent to which eligible beneficiaries are included in the scheme, including their level of awareness, application process and the adequacy of benefit disbursement. Additionally, a semi-structured interview (SSI) was conducted with the sarpanch/PRI member/Ward member at the Gram Panchayat/Ward level.

Method of Data Collection	Level	Respondents
Face-to-Face Survey	Individual	Beneficiaries of NSAP from the sampled GPs
Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)		Community Members
Semi-structured Interviews (SSIs)	Gram Panchayat	Sarpanch/PRI/ Ward Members
In-depth Interviews (IDIs)	District	Officials from the District-level Implementing Agency
	State	Officials from the State-level Implementing Agency

- **Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)** with the community members was carried out. For conducting Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) with community members, participants included beneficiaries of the IGNOAPS, IGNWPS, IGNDPS, and NFBS schemes. The socio- demographic composition of the participants ensured representation from Scheduled Castes (SC),

Scheduled Tribes (ST), General category, women, and beneficiaries above 80 years of age. The FGDs provided a deeper understanding of the impact of the NSAP scheme on the GPs.

- **In-depth Interviews (IDIs)** with the officials from the state-level implementing agency, policy makers and district-level implementing agency was conducted to capture the Administrative-perspective on NSAP, the process followed in each state, state-specific pension schemes, barriers to various measures, future pathways, etc.

2.4 SAMPLING APPROACH

2.4.1 Sampling Universe

As per the Terms of Reference (ToR), all the states of India were grouped into three categories as per the amount of pension provided. Thereafter, three states from high amount of pension, four states from moderate amount of pension and three states from low amount were selected. The reference period for this study has been taken as 2021- 22, 2022-23, 2023-24, and 2024-25. Out of these, 600 GPs and 6000 beneficiaries of NSAP spread across these 10 States were sampled for the study.

2.4.2 Estimation of Sample Size

For selecting a representative sample of the targeted households from their sampling universe, the following formula was used:

The objective of the survey was to assess the impact of the NSAP scheme. Accordingly, it was planned to arrive at a reliable sample size to generate valid inferences about the prod study. In order to generate a reliable assessment of the scheme the following formula has been used to calculate the required sample size (n) for the survey.

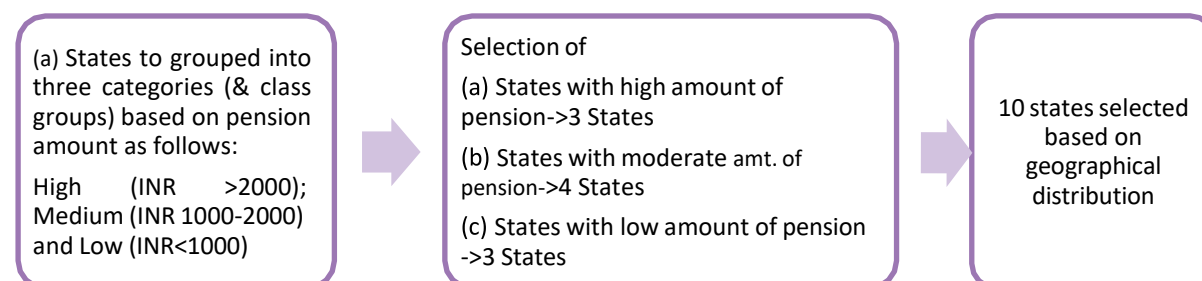
$$n = \left[\frac{Z^2 * p * (1-p)}{e^2} \right] \times DE \times Nr$$

The value of the indicator (p) was assumed as 50% to get a conservative estimate of the required sample size as multiple indicators are planned to be measured. Further in order to be able to measure the required estimates at a 95% level of confidence and 5% margin of error (e), with a design effect (DE) of 3.1 and a non-response rate of 2%, the sample size worked out to 6000. This sample was equally distributed across five zones.

2.4.3 Sampling Methodology

A multi-stage stratified random sampling approach was adopted for the selection of required sample. The sample selection approach being presented here closely aligns with the terms of reference laid out in the RFP document.

Stage 1 (State Section): As per ToR, this study was conducted across 10 states. All the states were stratified into three groups on the basis of pension amount. Post stratification, 3 states each from high pension and low pension strata, and 4 states from the moderate pension strata were sampled. The states were selected in each of these strata ensuring representation of all geographical regions in the country. In all, a total of 10 States were covered.



The following 10 States were selected –

S.No.	State	Pension Classification
1	Haryana	HIGH PENSION AMOUNT
2	Telangana	
3	Andhra Pradesh	
4	Gujarat	MEDIUM PENSION AMOUNT
5	Jammu & Kashmir	
6	Tamil Nadu	
7	U.P.	LOW PENSION AMOUNT
8	Assam	
9	Chhattisgarh	
10	Bihar	

As per the data received from NIC, the distribution of beneficiaries across rural and urban areas and the four types of schemes in the 10 selected states is as follows:

Scheme	Rural	Urban	Total	Proportion of Schemes
IGNOAPS	11773875	770585	12544460	75.8%
IGNWPS	3258339	237459	3495798	21.1%
IGNDPS	462050	40208	502258	3.0%
NFBS	14198	1677	15875	0.1%
Total	15508462	1049929	16558391	
<i>Proportion of Rural/Urban</i>	94%	6%		

Given the extremely low proportion of NFBS beneficiaries (0.1%) in the selected states, the sampling methodology for NFBS—specifically the selection of districts, blocks, and Gram Panchayats (GPs)—was conducted purposively to ensure the required 600 NFBS respondents are adequately covered in the study.

The sampling methodology for selection of the respondents under the remaining 3 schemes is detailed below –

Stage 2 (District Selection): In the next stage, 2 districts per State (overall sample of 20 districts) were sampled. Two districts were selected from each of the 10 states using Probability Proportional to Size (PPS) sampling. The size measure was based on the total number of scheme beneficiaries in each district. This ensured districts with higher beneficiary counts have a higher probability of selection.

Stage 3 (Block Selection): In each of the sampled districts, 3 blocks were sampled using the following approach:

- In each district, the proportion of rural and urban beneficiaries was computed using program records.
- If there is a significant proportion of urban beneficiaries (e.g., $\geq 25\%$), then two rural blocks and one urban municipal ward will be selected using PPS.
- If the district is predominantly rural, three rural blocks were selected using PPS.

Stage 4 (GP Selection): As outlined in the Terms of Reference, the study covered an overall sample of 600 GPs (10 GPs per block*60 blocks). The block-wise list of GPs along with the total number and types of beneficiaries being covered under each, from NIC was obtained. Within each selected rural block or municipal ward:

- Villages (or urban localities) were stratified into three strata based on the total number of beneficiaries:
 - Low-beneficiary villages
 - Medium-beneficiary villages
 - High-beneficiary villages
- From these strata, 3 villages from the low, 4 from the medium, and 3 from the high strata were selected using Simple Random Sampling (SRS). This stratified approach ensured variation in program saturation and community dynamics.

Stage 5 (Beneficiary Selection): The list of beneficiaries being covered under different schemes within the ambit of NSAP along with the basic details regarding age, gender and social

category to which the beneficiaries belong, shall be obtained from NIC. Thereafter, 10 beneficiaries were selected from each sampled village/urban locality. Next, the sample size of '10' was proportionately distributed to *ensure due representation* of (i) all beneficiary schemes and (ii) all social groups in the GP as outlined in the terms of reference.

Step 1: A total of 10 beneficiaries was selected in each sample GP/village on the following distribution:

(i) Five Beneficiaries of Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (ii) Two beneficiaries of Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (iii) Two beneficiaries of Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme and (iv) One beneficiary of National Family Benefit Scheme

Note: In accordance with ToR, In case of less number of beneficiaries of any scheme in the GP/village, the number will be substituted from other pension scheme so as to cover at least 10 beneficiaries per GP

Step 2: After distributing the beneficiaries as per the schemes, the distribution was **purposively distributed** from the following categories also: (i) 8 beneficiaries from General caste category (ii) 1 beneficiary from SC (iii) 1 beneficiary from ST (iv) At least 2 old age pension women beneficiaries (iv) At least 1 old age pension beneficiary of age ≥ 80 years

Note: It was difficult to maintain caste quota at the GP/village level, in such circumstances the quota was attempted first at block level then district level and then at State level. Even after this, in cases where the agency failed to maintain quota from any one caste category, the selection was substituted from the other category depending upon the prevalence of that category in the State.

2.4.4 Sample Distribution

The sample distribution for assignment by data collection tool and by target groups/ respondents is shown in the table below:

Level of Data Collection	Respondent Group	Data Collection Tool	Sampling Criteria	Sample size per GP	Sample Size per State	Overall Sample Size
Individual	Beneficiaries of NSAP from the sampled GPs	Structured Questionnaire	10 per sampled GP X 60 GPs per State X 10 States [From each State, 2 districts, 3 blocks from each district, and 10 GP per block will be sampled]	10	600	6000

Level of Data Collection	Respondent Group	Data Collection Tool	Sampling Criteria	Sample size per GP	Sample Size per State	Overall Sample Size
Gram Panchayat	Sarpanch / PRI Member	Semi-Structured Interviews (SSIs)	1 per sampled GP X 60 GPs per State X 10 States [From each State, 2 districts, 3 blocks from each district, and 10 GP per block will be sampled]	1	60	600
	Community Members	Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)	1 per sampled GP X 60 GPs per State X 10 States [From each State, 2 districts, 3 blocks from each district, and 10 GP per block will be sampled]	1	60	600
District	Officials from the District- level Implementing Agency	In-depth Interviews (IDIs)	1 per sampled District X 2 districts per State X 10 States	-	2	20
State	Officials from the State- level Implementing Agency & Policy Makers	Semi-Structured Interviews (SSIs)	2 per State X 10 States	-	2	20

3.1 ACHIEVEMENTS OF THE SCHEME

Launched in 1995, the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) has emerged as one of India's largest and longest-running social protection frameworks, fulfilling the constitutional vision under Article 41 to support citizens facing old age, widowhood, disability, or the loss of a breadwinner. Over nearly three decades, NSAP has grown into a nationwide safety net covering nearly 3 crore beneficiaries. Its expansion, institutionalization, and direct impact on improving the quality of life among the poorest households make NSAP one of the most significant pillars of India's social protection ecosystem.

1. Strengthening Household Security and Reducing Financial Vulnerability

- 75.1% of beneficiaries reported that the pension somewhat reduced their dependence on other earning members in their household; 16.5% said it significantly reduced dependence.
- States with higher top-ups like Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Haryana, showed stronger improvements in household stability and income security, demonstrating the stabilizing role of NSAP in low-income households.
- The scheme provides predictable, regular support for elderly persons, widows, and persons with disabilities who are traditionally excluded from the labour market.



2. Improvements in Socio-Economic Well-Being

- 81-84% beneficiaries use pensions primarily for food and medicine.
- 63% reported improved food access, 68% improved ability to purchase personal essentials, and 65% improved medical access.
- Nearly half the respondents borrow less for subsistence, indicating reduced distress borrowing and better resilience.

- Strongest improvements recorded in Jammu & Kashmir, Telangana, and Tamil Nadu, where 70-90% of respondents reported positive changes across key well-being indicators.

3. Enhancing Dignity, Social Acceptance, and Self-Worth

- 67-68% beneficiaries reported improved treatment and respect within their families and communities.
- Elderly persons, widows, and persons with disabilities noted greater social acceptance, enhanced independence, and a renewed sense of self-worth.
- These findings resonate with global evidence showing that predictable social pensions enhance dignity and strengthen social roles for older persons.

4. Improved Transparency Through DBT and Digital Systems

- 97% of beneficiaries have Aadhaar-linked bank accounts.
- Doorstep payments in states like Haryana and Andhra Pradesh ensure safe access for immobile beneficiaries.
- The NSAP-PPS system digitizes beneficiary records and disbursement histories, improving monitoring, reducing leakages, and strengthening programme governance.

5. Progress in Timely Disbursement and Beneficiary Convenience

- States such as Andhra Pradesh and Haryana consistently ensure timely and predictable payments.
- Doorstep delivery, mobile banking, and simplified procedures have reduced travel time and transaction burdens.
- 73% of beneficiaries expressed satisfaction with the overall scheme process, an improvement over previous years when delays were widespread.

"After receiving the pension, we feel more independent because we can spend the money according to our own wishes. Our family members treat us better now, and our access to food and medicines has improved. We are able to meet our basic needs, which was not possible earlier. We are satisfied with the overall process—from selection and sanction to the disbursement of the pension. We feel a change in our confidence and self-esteem"

-Focus Group Discussions with Beneficiaries, Jammu & Kashmir

For nearly 30 years, the National Social Assistance Programme has anchored India's commitment to social justice, poverty alleviation, and dignity for vulnerable citizens. It has strengthened household stability, reduced dependence and vulnerability, improved consumption, food security, and medical access, enhanced dignity and social acceptance, expanded coverage to millions, improved transparency through DBT and built a foundation for future social protection reforms. NSAP stands today not only as a safety net, but as a central pillar of India's social protection system that continues to evolve, adapt, and uphold the constitutional promise of dignity and security for all.

3.2 PROFILE OF THE BENEFICIARIES

3.2.1 Socio-Economic Profile

Region:

The majority of the beneficiaries covered in the survey were from rural areas, accounting for 90% of the total sample. NSAP continues to have its largest reach and impact in rural areas, where the need for social security support is higher.

Gender:

A total of 55.2% women and 44.7% men were covered in the survey. State-wise, the highest proportion of female respondents was recorded in Tamil Nadu (70.8%), Assam (60.3%), and Chhattisgarh (58.7%), while a slightly higher proportion of male respondents was covered from Uttar Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir (51%). Overall, the sample presents a **balanced gender representation across states**, with a marginally higher participation of women, consistent with the scheme's overall beneficiary profile.

The state-wise gender profile of the beneficiaries has been presented in Table 3.1.

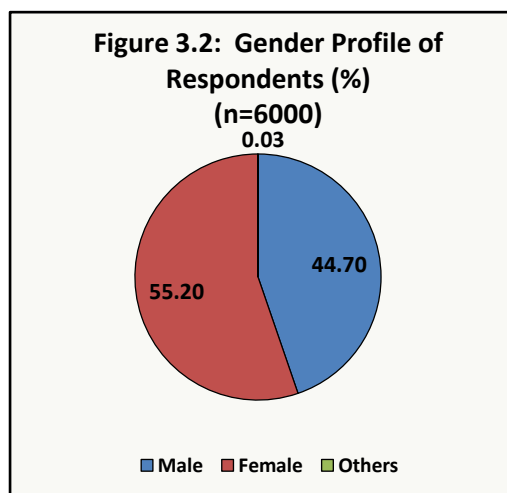
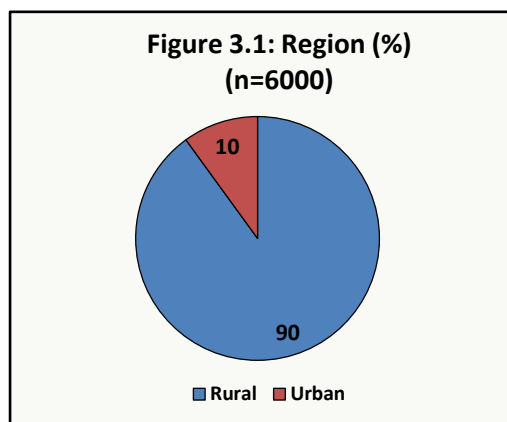
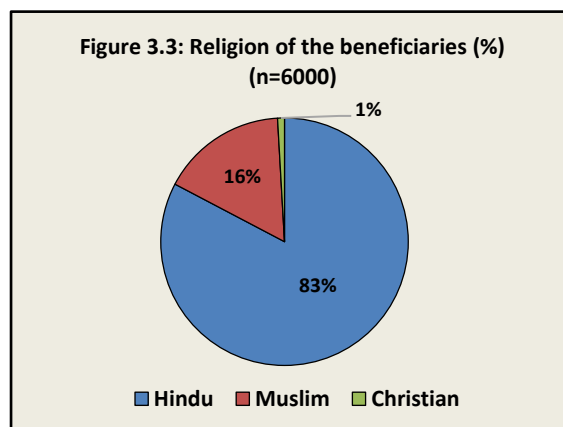


Table 3.1: Gender Profile of Respondents (n=6000) (%)			
State	Male	Female	Others
Bihar (n=600)	41.7	58.3	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	41.2	58.7	0.2
Gujarat (n=600)	47.8	52.2	0.0
Haryana (n=600)	50.0	50.0	0.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	51.0	49.0	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	51.0	49.0	0.0
Assam (n=600)	39.7	60.3	0.0
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	48.7	51.3	0.0
Telangana (n=600)	47.2	52.7	0.2
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	29.2	70.8	0.0

Religion:

As depicted in Figure 3.3, the majority of beneficiaries covered were Hindus (82.7%), followed by Muslims (16.4%). Across all states, more than 80% of the respondents were Hindus, except in Jammu & Kashmir, where 99% of the beneficiaries were Muslims. The sample broadly reflects the religious composition of India, with **Hindus forming the predominant group among the beneficiaries.**



Social Category:

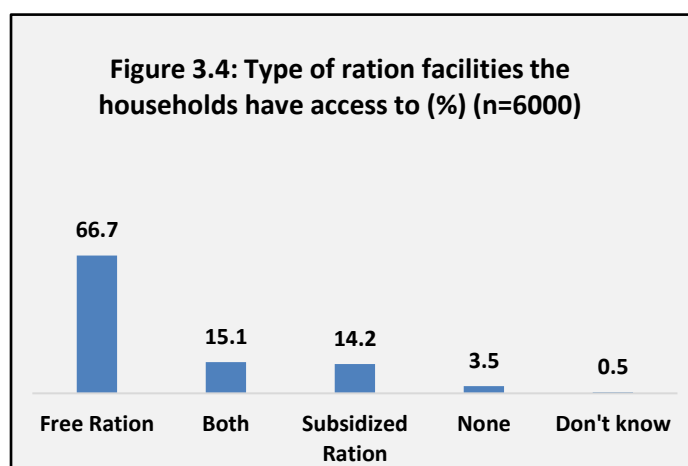
Across all states, the largest proportion of beneficiaries belonged to the Other Backward Classes (OBC) category (45.6%), followed by the General category (30.8%) and Scheduled Castes (17.2%). Scheduled Tribes accounted for 6.4% of the total sample. OBC beneficiaries formed the majority in most states such as Tamil Nadu, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, and Telangana, whereas General category beneficiaries dominated in Andhra Pradesh (51.8%) and Jammu & Kashmir (79.5%). Overall, the distribution reflected diverse social representation among beneficiaries, with **OBCs emerging as the largest group covered under the scheme.**

Table 3.2: Social Category of beneficiaries (n=6000) (%)				
State	Scheduled Caste	Scheduled Tribe	Other Backward Castes	General
Bihar (n=600)	29.3	0.3	49.5	20.8
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	17.7	10.3	54.5	17.5
Gujarat (n=600)	21.7	6.2	52.3	19.8
Haryana (n=600)	24.0	0.0	47.0	29.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.0	7.0	13.5	79.5
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	30.7	1.8	43.2	24.3
Assam (n=600)	6.5	10.2	40.8	42.5
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	12.2	8.8	27.2	51.8
Telangana (n=600)	11.8	17.5	52.5	18.2
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	18.5	1.3	75.7	4.5
Total	17.2	6.4	45.6	30.8

3.2.2 Access to the Public Distribution System

Majority of the surveyed households (66.7%) reported receiving free ration under Public Distribution System (PDS), while 14.2% accessed subsidized ration, and 15.1% had access to both types of ration facilities. State-wise patterns show significant variation. In Bihar (96.5%), Chhattisgarh (97.5%), and Assam (96.7%), nearly all households reported receiving free ration, indicating strong implementation of the public distribution system.

In contrast, Jammu & Kashmir stands out, where almost all respondents (99.8%) accessed only subsidized ration, and none reported receiving free ration. States such as Andhra Pradesh (47.2%), Tamil Nadu (60.5%), and Gujarat (21.7%) reported a substantial share of households accessing both free and subsidized ration, reflecting diverse state-specific distribution models. Overall, the data indicates that access to



ration facilities is nearly universal across most states, with the free ration model being predominant.

State	Free Ration	Subsidized Ration	Both	None	Don't know
Bihar (n=600)	96.5	1.0	1.0	1.5	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	97.5	2.0	0.2	0.2	0.2
Gujarat (n=600)	56.7	17.5	21.7	3.7	0.5
Haryana (n=600)	87.2	7.0	0.7	5.0	0.2
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.0	99.8	0.2	0.0	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	80.2	7.5	0.0	11.8	0.5
Assam (n=600)	96.7	1.2	0.0	1.8	0.3
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	47.3	4.3	47.2	0.3	0.8
Telangana (n=600)	80.2	0.0	19.5	0.3	0.0
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	24.5	1.7	60.5	9.8	3.5

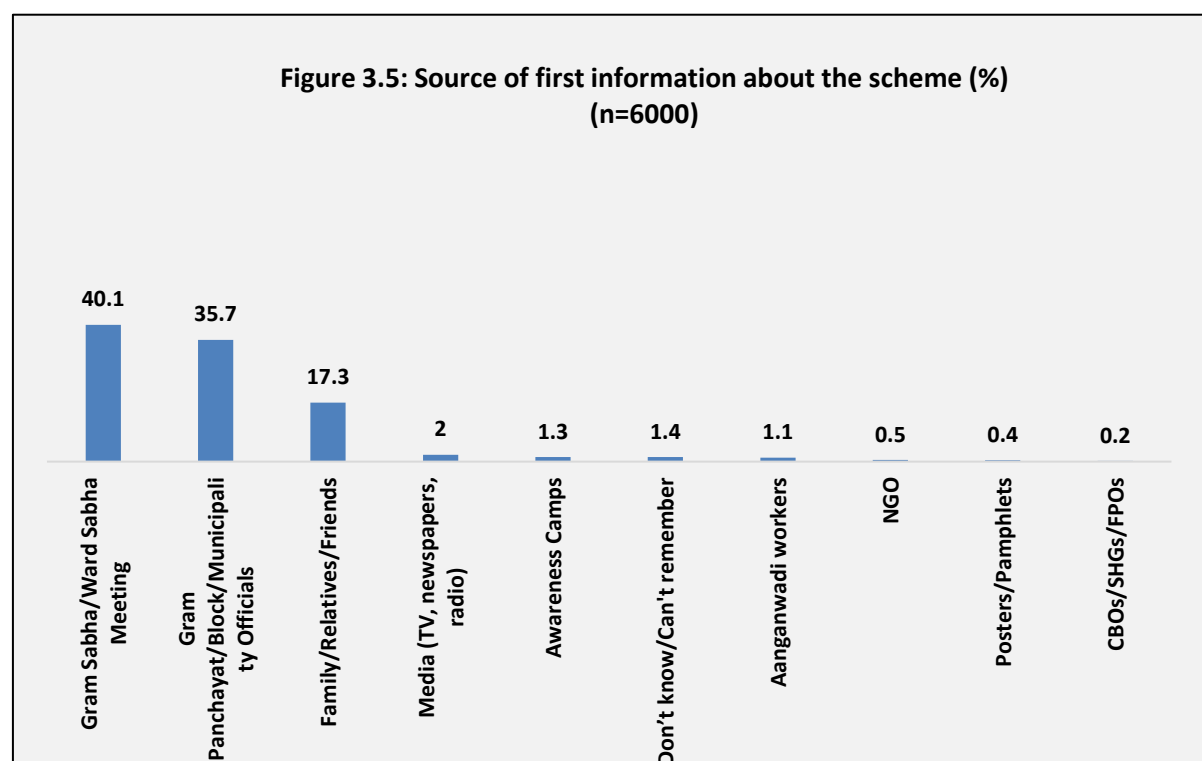
The findings indicate that **households across the surveyed states have extensive access to free or subsidized food grains through the Public Distribution System (PDS)**, which is effectively reaching the majority of vulnerable groups. **The overlap between PDS entitlements and the Annapurna Scheme suggests that its continuation may no longer be necessary**, except perhaps in areas or populations where PDS coverage remains limited or irregular. Additionally, discussions with state and district-level officials revealed that all eligible BPL households receive food grains under the Public Distribution System (PDS). Consequently, the Annapurna Scheme has become largely redundant in its current form.

3.3 AWARENESS ABOUT THE SCHEME

The NSAP guidelines have conferred a great deal of importance on awareness generation and for the same purpose directed officials at various levels of administration to play a critical role. The guidelines also mentioned self-help groups (SHGs), posters, brochures, media and other means to create awareness. With this view the study tried to evaluate the major sources of information used for generating awareness.

3.3.1 Sources of Information

The survey revealed that beneficiaries primarily learn about the scheme through Gram Sabha/Ward Sabha meetings (40.1%) and Gram Panchayat or Block/Municipality officials (35.7%), indicating that **local institutions play a key role in awareness generation**. States like Bihar, and Chhattisgarh relied heavily on Gram Sabha and Ward Sabha meetings, while Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Tamil Nadu depended more on officials. However, in Jammu & Kashmir, most beneficiaries were informed through family, friends, or media, reflecting weak institutional outreach.



“Awareness is created mainly through Self-Help Groups. They inform eligible people about pensions and guide them on applications. No posters or social media are used; information is shared directly with villagers who approach or during house visits. At the district level, families registering a death are informed about NFBS benefits. Officials guide families to apply using death certificates and heir details”

-Gram Panchayat representatives, Andikkadu, Tamil Nadu

3.3.2 Awareness on Key Aspects of Scheme

Awareness of Beneficiaries:

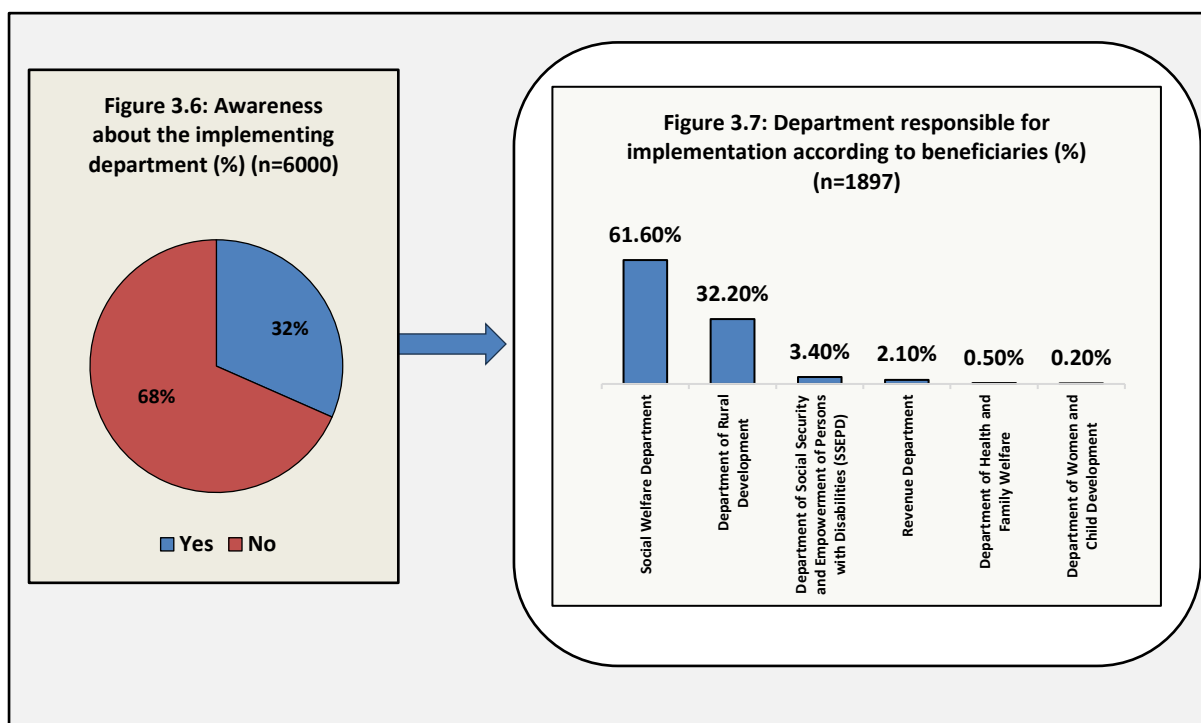
The main purpose of awareness generation is to make people conscious about key features of scheme especially the eligibility criteria and scale of assistance. Awareness levels among beneficiaries about who is eligible for different NSAP schemes vary across the four schemes and between rural and urban areas.

For IGNOAPS (Old Age Pension), awareness is moderate, with 48% of IGNOAPS beneficiaries knowing which beneficiaries can receive the pension. Rural areas report slightly higher awareness (49%) than urban areas (39%). Awareness is lower for IGNWPS (Widow Pension), where only 42% of IGNWPS beneficiaries were aware of the eligibility criteria. For IGNDPS (Disability Pension), overall awareness is 43%, with a clear gap between urban (50%) and rural (42%) respondents. This suggests that rural households may need more targeted information on widow and disability-related entitlements. Awareness of NFBS (National Family Benefit Scheme) is comparatively high at 63%, with almost similar levels across rural and urban areas. Overall, awareness of key beneficiary categories remains limited for most schemes, especially in rural areas, highlighting the need for improved information dissemination at the community level.

Table 3.4: Awareness on the types of beneficiaries under different schemes (n=6000) (%)				
		Type of Area		
		Urban	Rural	Total
Awareness of the types of beneficiaries who can receive benefits under IGNOAPS	Yes	39	49	48
	No	61	51	52
Awareness of the types of beneficiaries who can receive benefits under IGNWPS	Yes	46	41	42
	No	54	59	58
	Yes	50	42	43

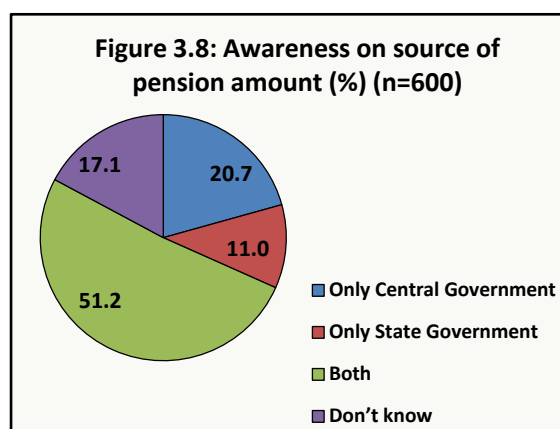
Table 3.4: Awareness on the types of beneficiaries under different schemes (n=6000) (%)				
		Type of Area		
		Urban	Rural	Total
Awareness of the types of beneficiaries who can receive benefits under IGNDPS	No	50	58	57
Awareness of the types of beneficiaries who can receive benefits under NFBS	Yes	61	63	63
	No	39	37	38

Overall, out of 6000 respondents, only 1897 (31.6%) had an idea of which government department is responsible for implementing the scheme. Out of the total 1897 beneficiary respondents, 61.6% believe that the Social Welfare Department is responsible for disbursing their pension followed by Department of Rural Development (32%). Additionally, 55% of beneficiaries did not know whether the pension amount comes from the central or state government, while only 19.6% were aware that both the central and state governments contribute to the pension amount. Overall, the findings highlight a significant communication **gap in conveying essential information about scheme implementation, eligibility, and financial structure, underscoring the need for stronger IEC efforts for beneficiaries** to enhance transparency and informed access.



Awareness of Gram Panchayat/Ward Officials:

Gram Panchayat and ward officials were also asked about their awareness of the eligibility criteria for availing benefits under various social security schemes implemented in their areas. About 91% of Gram Panchayat and ward officials were aware of the eligible age criteria, indicating a strong level of understanding among local functionaries. In Jammu & Kashmir and Tamil Nadu, all officials were aware of the eligibility criteria, whereas the **highest proportion of officials lacking awareness was observed in Bihar (27%)**.



Overall, awareness among Gram Panchayat and ward officials about the source of pension funds under NSAP was limited and inconsistent across states. 51.2% of respondents correctly identified that the pension amount is jointly contributed by both the central and state governments, while about 20.7% believed it comes only from the central government, and 17.1% said they did not know the source. **Awareness was notably high in Telangana (100%), Tamil Nadu (95%), and Andhra Pradesh (96.7%), where most respondents recognized the joint funding structure.** In contrast, Jammu & Kashmir, Bihar, and Gujarat recorded lower awareness levels, with a significant share of officials either attributing the funds solely to one government or remaining unaware. This suggests that **while overall awareness is high, state-specific training and capacity building efforts are needed in states with lower awareness levels to strengthen implementation at the grassroots.**

Table 3.5: Awareness on source of pension amount (n=600) (%)				
States	Only Central Government	Only State Government	Both Central and State Govt.	Don't know
Andhra Pradesh (n=60)	0.0	0.0	96.7	3.3
Assam (n=60)	50.0	1.7	36.7	11.7
Bihar (n=60)	26.7	30.0	11.7	31.7
Chhattisgarh (n=60)	33.3	0.0	60.0	6.7
Gujarat (n=60)	26.7	23.3	21.7	28.3
Haryana (n=60)	31.7	31.7	20.0	16.7
Jammu Kashmir (n=60)	0.0	0.0	43.3	56.7
Tamil Nadu (n=60)	5.0	0.0	95.0	0.0
Telangana (n=60)	0.0	0.0	100.0	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=60)	33.3	23.3	26.7	16.7

Additionally, around 78% of Gram Panchayat officials and ward members reported that they had undertaken efforts at the Panchayat or Municipality level to raise awareness among beneficiaries about these schemes through various means such as Gram Sabha meetings, awareness camps, social media, and public board notices or posters. The highest levels of such initiatives were reported in Jammu & Kashmir (98%) and Telangana (93%).

3.4 SCHEME IMPLEMENTATION

3.4.1 Primary Eligibility Criteria for Pension

Across most states, Below Poverty Line (BPL) status remains the key eligibility criteria for accessing pension benefits under the scheme. However, income thresholds and specific criteria vary across states. States like Telangana and Andhra Pradesh have higher income limits while Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh set relatively lower thresholds. Haryana uses



a Family ID system instead of BPL, reflecting a different targeting approach. According to state and district officials, as well as beneficiaries, this criterion has been very effective in identifying genuine beneficiaries and has helped reduce instances of corruption or bias in the selection process.

Table 3.6: State-wise primary eligibility criteria

Sl. No.	State	Primary eligibility criteria	Income criteria
1	Assam	BPL	Annual Income should be less than Rs. 27,000.
2	Gujarat	BPL	BPL score should be between 0-20 to be eligible for pensions. Annual income of household should be between Rs.1,00,000-Rs2,00,000
3	Uttar Pradesh	BPL	For rural areas, annual income limit is Rs. 46,080 and for urban areas, annual income limit is Rs. 56,460.
4	Bihar	BPL	Annual Income should be less than Rs. 27,000.
5	Haryana	Family ID	Annual Income should be less than 3 lacs.
6	Chhattisgarh	BPL	Annual Income should be less than Rs. 24,200.
7	Andhra Pradesh	BPL	For rural areas, the annual household income limit is ₹1,00,000, and for urban areas, it is ₹1,20,000.

Table 3.6: State-wise primary eligibility criteria			
Sl. No.	State	Primary eligibility criteria	Income criteria
8	Telangana	BPL	For rural areas, the annual household income limit is Rs. 1,50,000, and for urban areas, it Rs. ₹2,00,000.
9	Tamil Nadu	BPL	Annual Income should be less than Rs. 60,000.
10	Jammu and Kashmir	BPL; Quarterly and Annual Survey data conducted by Department of Social welfare through Anganwadi workers	Annual Income should be less than Rs. 1,20,000.

3.4.2 Identification of Beneficiaries

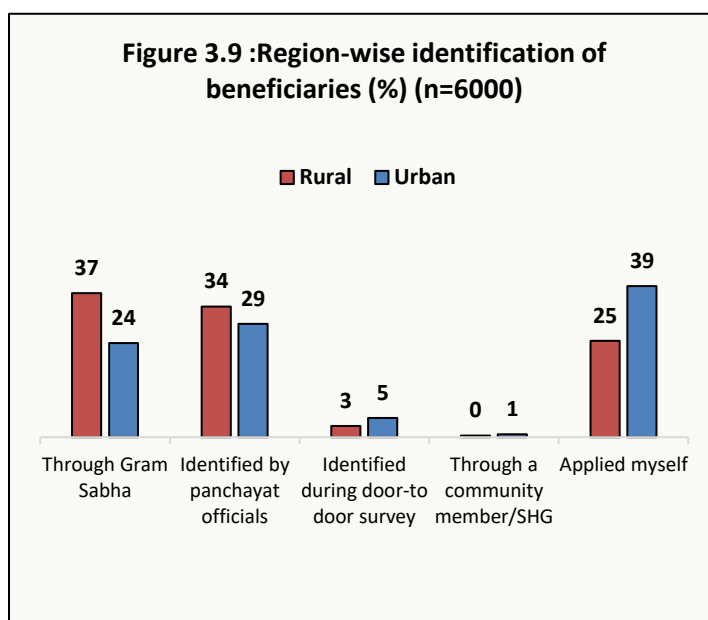
Beneficiary identification processes vary significantly across states, reflecting differences in local implementation practices. Overall, Gram Sabha meetings (36.3%) and panchayat officials (33.5%) were the most common means of identifying beneficiaries, **indicating the crucial role of local governance institutions in the identification and selection process**. States like Bihar (66.5%), Chhattisgarh (55.5%), and Haryana (52%) relied heavily on the Gram Sabha, reflecting participatory approaches. In contrast, Andhra Pradesh (63.8%), Telangana (56.7%), and Assam (54.3%) primarily depended on panchayat officials. Jammu & Kashmir stood out, with 99.8% of beneficiaries reporting self-application, indicating limited institutional involvement in identification. Identification through door-to-door surveys (3.1%) and community or SHG involvement (0.43%) was minimal, highlighting underutilization of proactive outreach methods. Some beneficiaries were also identified through ‘other’ local functionaries, such as the Village Administrative Officer and the Village Assistant.

Overall, while community-based and official identification remain dominant, there is a need to strengthen inclusive and participatory mechanisms, particularly in states where self-identification dominates or community outreach is limited.

Table 3.7: Identification of beneficiaries (n=6000) (%)						
State	Through Gram Sabha	Identified by panchayat officials	Identified during door-to door survey	Through a community member/ SHG	Applied myself	Others
Bihar (n=600)	66.5	6.8	0.3	0.0	26.3	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	55.5	25.3	2.2	0.3	16.0	0.7
Gujarat (n=600)	47.7	33.0	2.8	0.2	16.0	0.3
Haryana (n=600)	52.0	16.8	0.2	0.0	31.0	0.0
Jammu & Kashmir (n=600)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.2	99.8	0.0

Table 3.7: Identification of beneficiaries (n=6000) (%)						
State	Through Gram Sabha	Identified by panchayat officials	Identified during door-to door survey	Through a community member/ SHG	Applied myself	Others
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	49.2	35.0	1.0	2.2	12.5	0.2
Assam (n=600)	39.7	54.3	2.5	0.5	2.8	0.2
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	23.8	63.8	6.2	0.0	6.2	0.0
Telangana (n=600)	19.2	56.7	7.3	0.5	16.2	0.2
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	9.2	43.2	8.0	0.5	34.3	4.8
Total	36.3	33.5	3.1	0.4	26.1	0.6

The data also revealed significant regional variations in the modes of beneficiary identification. In rural areas, Gram Sabha (37%) and panchayat officials (34%) were the main channels for identification, reflecting the stronger role of local governance structures. In contrast, in urban areas, only 24% were identified through Ward Sabha and 29% through ward officials, while a higher share 39% reported that they applied themselves, compared to 25% in rural regions. This suggests greater individual initiative and awareness in urban areas, whereas rural identification remains largely institution-driven.



“We identify the needy through Gram Sabha meetings where names are proposed and verified by the community. ASHA workers and Anganwadi staff also help us in identifying elderly, widows, and disabled persons. If someone cannot come to the office, volunteers or panchayat staff visit them to collect documents and assist with applications.”

-Secretary, Repaka GP, Telangana

“AI can be used to analyze socio-economic and demographic data from reliable sources to identify eligible beneficiaries. It can detect irregularities in beneficiary database, report any suspicious disbursement and support Facial Recognition/ Finger print authentication”

-Consultant, Social Security Unit, Telangana

3.4.3 Application Process:

The 1,567 beneficiaries who applied for the scheme themselves were further asked about the mode of application. **Among them, 1,041 beneficiaries (66.4%) applied online, while 526 beneficiaries (33.6%) applied offline.** Most of those who applied offline stated that the application form was free of cost and that they did not face major difficulties during the process. Around 83% of offline applicants obtained the form from Gram Panchayat, Block, or Municipality officials or during Gram Sabha/Ward Sabha meetings.

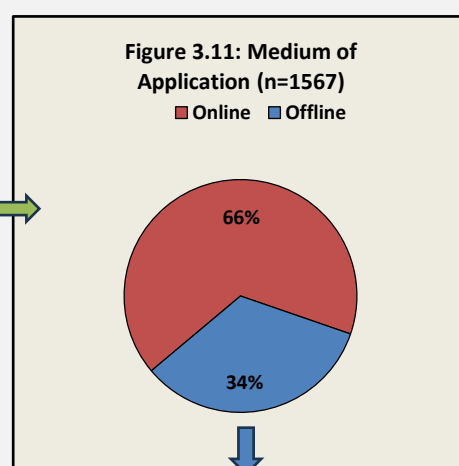
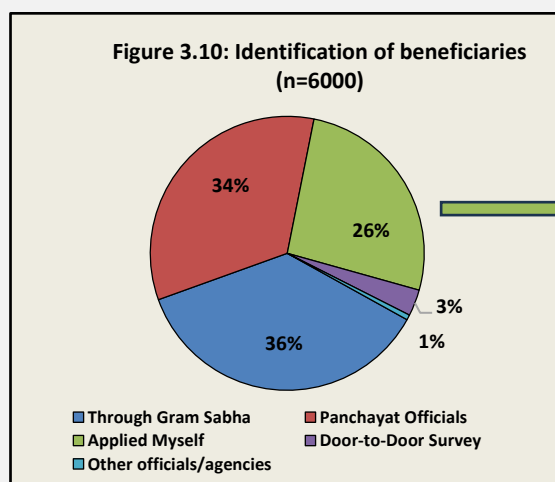
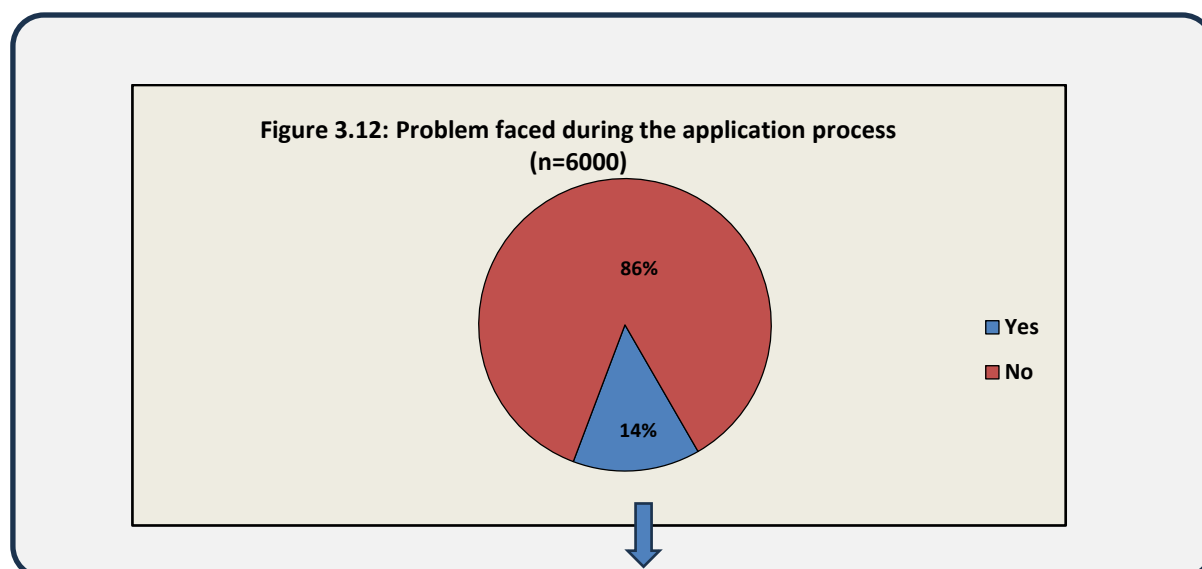


Table 3.8: Offline modes of obtaining the application form (n=526) (%)

State	Gram Sabha/Ward Sabha Meeting	Gram Panchayat/Block/Municipality Officials	NGO	SHGs	Bank	Awareness camps
Bihar (n=56)	51.8	48.2	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=95)	21.1	38.9	0.0	4.2	13.7	22.1
Gujarat (n=64)	3.1	53.1	6.3	4.7	0.0	31.3
Haryana (n=38)	23.7	71.1	0.0	0.0	0.0	2.6
Uttar Pradesh (n=7)	14.3	71.4	0.0	14.3	0.0	0.0
Assam (n=17)	5.9	76.5	11.8	0.0	5.9	0.0
Andhra Pradesh (n=27)	22.2	70.4	0.0	0.0	0.0	7.4
Telangana (n=81)	3.6	93.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	3.7
Tamil Nadu (n=141)	0.0	91.5	0.7	0.0	1.4	5.7
Total	13.5	70.2	1.3	1.5	3.0	10.5

Out of the total 6,000 beneficiaries surveyed, 843 reported facing challenges during the application process. The most common issue, reported by 86.6% of those who faced difficulties, was a lack of information on where to obtain the forms, particularly in Bihar, Jammu & Kashmir, and Uttar Pradesh, where over 90% cited this problem. Logistical barriers such as long distances and the need for multiple visits were more prevalent in Assam, Gujarat, and Chhattisgarh. In contrast, Andhra Pradesh showed a different trend, where the primary issue was rejection of applications by officials reported by 50% of beneficiaries.

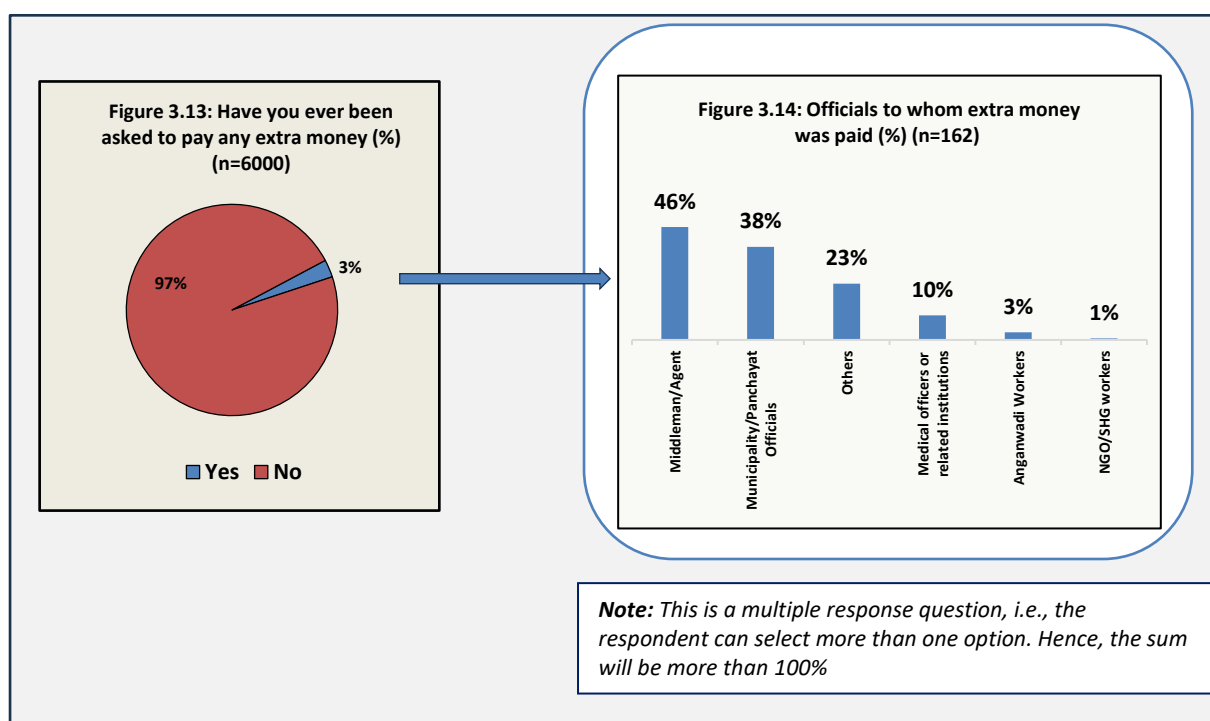


State	No information about place of availability of forms	The place is situated far away	Had to visit many times to acquire the form	Faced rejection from officials
Bihar (n=14)	92.9	14.3	21.4	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=76)	72.4	60.5	48.7	7.9
Gujarat (n=37)	73.0	64.9	54.1	16.2
Haryana (n=28)	89.3	14.3	10.7	0.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=544)	93.6	32.4	13.4	0.2
Uttar Pradesh (n=65)	93.8	41.5	35.4	7.7
Assam (n=10)	60.0	80.0	60.0	10.0
Andhra Pradesh (n=10)	30.0	40.0	10.0	50.0
Telangana (n=8)	12.5	25.0	62.5	37.5
Tamil Nadu (n=51)	58.8	78.4	19.6	11.8
Total	86.6	39.5	21.5	3.9

⁵**Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%.

Additionally, 162 beneficiaries mentioned having to pay extra money to government officials or middlemen to get their pension approved or initiated, **indicating instances of informal payments and procedural inefficiencies** in some areas. The majority (46%) reported having to pay extra to a middleman or agent. The respondents who affirmed to have paid any money were further asked about the amount of money they paid for the purpose.

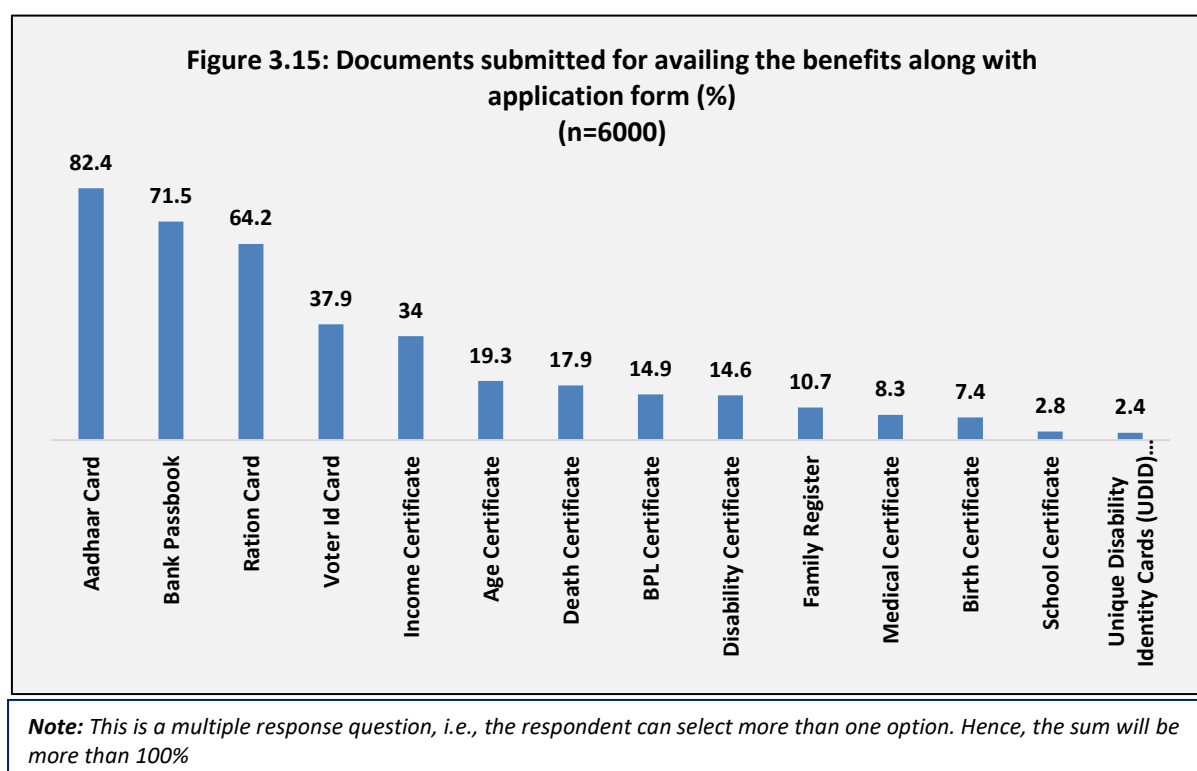
The average amount reported by such beneficiaries for facilitating approval or initiation of pension benefits was approximately ₹1,400, though the amount varied across states. In certain states, such as Tamil Nadu, beneficiaries reported significantly higher payments, with some indicating payments of up to ₹5,000 to intermediaries or local-level functionaries. Discussions with beneficiaries further highlighted the prevalence of informal arrangements, where beneficiaries pay intermediaries either the entire pension amount for the initial six months or approximately ten per cent of the monthly pension for a period of up to one year. This suggests that there might be instances of some fraudulent practices that need to be checked and curbed by the concerned authorities in the interest of poor beneficiaries.



3.4.4 Submission and Verification of Applications

The analysis of the document submission process shows that beneficiaries are required to provide multiple documents to avail the benefits of the pension. Discussions with beneficiaries across states revealed that, although applicants often submit several documents along with the application form, the Aadhaar card and bank passbook are universally mandatory, while the husband's death certificate is an essential requirement for widow pension applicants and the disability certificate is required for disability pension applicants.

The survey findings further validate these insights. As depicted in Figure 3.15, the most commonly submitted documents are the Aadhaar card (82.4%), bank passbook (71.5%), and ration card (64.2%), indicating that these serve as the core identity, financial, and household proof for pension eligibility. States like Jammu & Kashmir (99.8%), Haryana (96.8%), and Gujarat (96%) show near-universal Aadhaar card submission, suggesting high linkage of social security benefits with digital identity systems. The Income Certificate is crucial in Bihar (70.8%) and Gujarat (61.0%) but less so in southern and northeastern states. Disability-related documents such as medical or disability certificates and UDID cards are required by smaller proportions, and are largely concentrated among disability pension applicants.



Overall, while Aadhaar and bank linkage have become the foundation of pension disbursement, the variation in documentary requirements across states highlights the need to streamline documentation norms to simplify the application process.

A total of 1896 beneficiaries who confirmed that verification was carried out were asked as well on who has verified the documents. 31.6% of beneficiaries reported that someone had verified the documents they submitted physically. **Most physical checks were done by municipality/panchayat officials (87.1%)**, reflecting their central role in scheme implementation. However, there are some differences across states.

In Assam (66.4%), the reliance on municipal or panchayat staff was lower, with a greater dependence on Anganwadi workers (35.5%) and other government or community staff like NGOs and SHG workers (28.2%) for physical verification. These variations suggest that verification mechanisms are adapted to local administrative capacities, community structures, and program design, indicating flexibility in implementation.

Table 3.10: Documents submitted for availing the benefits along with application form⁶ (n=6000) (%)

State	Birth Certificate	School certificate	BPL Certificate	Aadhaar Card	Ration Card	Voter ID Card	Age certificate	Death certificate	Medical certificate	Disability Certificate	Unique Disability Identity	Income certificate	Bank Passbook	Family Register
Bihar (n=600)	0.0	0.0	2.2	95.2	15.0	10.7	3.5	24.2	3.2	19.7	2.5	70.8	99.2	18.8
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	6.3	2.2	36.7	75.3	88.0	46.7	28.0	19.2	5.5	15.7	0.8	41.5	88.3	39.2
Gujarat (n=600)	32.0	21.5	69.7	96.0	87.0	42.0	54.8	13.3	14.7	9.2	1.3	61.0	75.8	4.8
Haryana (n=600)	0.2	0.3	0.8	96.8	13.5	9.8	6.7	25.5	3.5	21.8	2.0	58.8	99.5	20.3
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	23.5	1.5	0.0	99.8	99.8	22.8	15.7	0.2	0.0	2.8	2.7	23.7	99.5	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	2.7	0.2	2.3	90.5	11.8	14.3	12.0	23.2	2.7	18.2	3.5	48.2	92.3	18.0
Assam (n=600)	1.3	0.8	19.5	60.2	39.7	79.5	12.5	6.2	13.0	10.0	5.7	2.0	78.2	3.5
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	3.2	0.7	15.3	77.0	94.5	31.0	27.2	23.7	9.3	12.8	2.2	13.0	7.7	0.5
Telangana (n=600)	1.3	0.2	2.0	67.5	96.8	52.8	19.3	21.5	12.8	19.5	0.8	6.2	10.2	0.5
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	3.8	1.0	0.5	65.7	95.8	69.2	13.5	22.5	18.2	16.5	2.7	14.3	64.7	1.7

⁶ **Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%

Figure 3.16: Did physical verification take place at your house?
(n=6000)

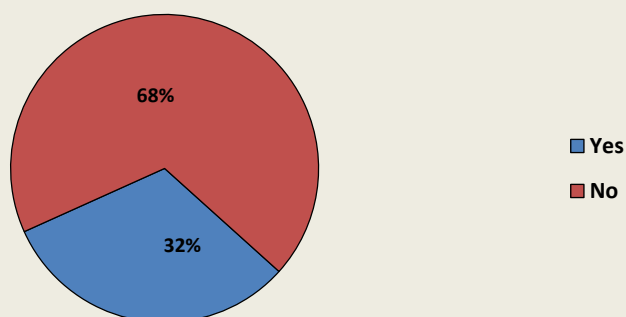


Table 3.11: People who visited for physical verification⁷ (n=1896) (%)

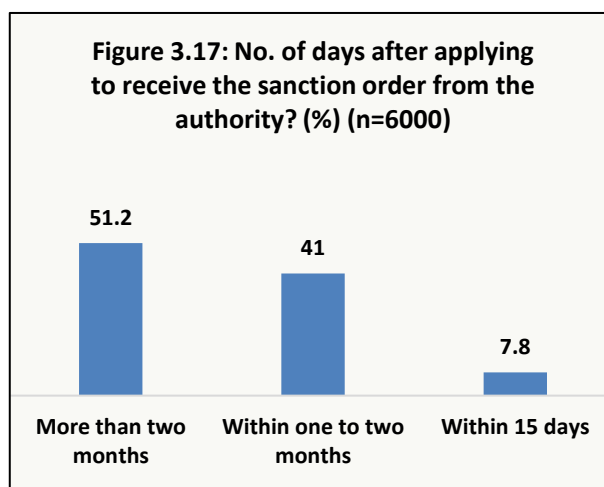
State	Municipality/ Panchayat Officials	Anganwadi/ Workers	NGO/SHG workers	Other Government Official
Bihar (n=89)	98.9	4.5	3.4	34.8
Chhattisgarh (n=190)	98.4	2.1	0.0	2.1
Gujarat (n=143)	79.7	16.1	6.3	23.8
Haryana (n=136)	95.6	2.9	1.5	10.3
Uttar Pradesh (n=195)	87.2	1.5	0.0	18.5
Assam (n=110)	66.4	35.5	28.2	5.5
Andhra Pradesh (n=352)	96.3	2.3	0.0	8.8
Telangana (n=382)	91.4	23.6	7.1	25.4
Tamil Nadu (299)	67.6	13.4	0.3	33.1
Total	87.1	11.3	3.9	18.6

The study further revealed that during physical verification, officials primarily focused on identity and financial documents, thus emphasizing on authenticity and eligibility confirmation. Across all states, the Aadhaar card (78.9%), bank passbook (46.5%), and ration card (72.5%) were the most frequently checked documents. The name and address of beneficiaries were verified in nearly 40% of cases, reinforcing the importance of identity validation in the process.

⁷ **Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%.

3.4.5 Sanctioning of Applications

As per the guidelines laid out for NSAP, the time for processing of application from the time of receipt till sanction or rejection should not exceed sixty days. However, out of the 6000 beneficiaries surveyed, over half of them (51.2%) reported that it took more than 2 months to receive the sanction order from the authority after applying for their respective pension amount. 41% respondents reported that this time was within two months. Among the states surveyed, in Jammu & Kashmir, almost all the sanction orders were received within one to two months. For most of the other states, it took more than two months.



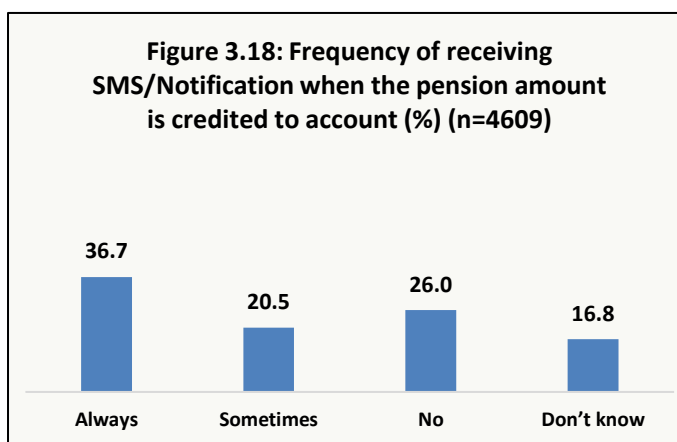
3.4.6 Procedure of Fund Transfer:

Across all the states, pensions are disbursed through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) into beneficiaries' bank or post office accounts on a monthly basis, ensuring transparency and timely delivery. Andhra Pradesh remains an exception, where pensions are still disbursed in cash, while Uttar Pradesh follows a quarterly payment cycle.

State	Primary mode of disbursement	Frequency of Payment
Assam	DBT (Through Bank account)	Monthly
Gujarat	DBT (Through Bank and Post Office account)	Monthly
Uttar Pradesh	DBT (Through Bank account)	Quarterly
Bihar	DBT (Through Bank account)	Monthly
Haryana	DBT (Through Bank account)	Monthly
Chhattisgarh	DBT (Through Bank account)	Monthly
Andhra Pradesh	Cash disbursement	Monthly
Telangana	DBT (Through Post office account)	Monthly
Tamil Nadu	DBT (Through Bank account)	Monthly
Jammu and Kashmir	DBT (Through Bank account)	Monthly

The beneficiaries receiving money through DBT via bank or post office were further asked whether their Aadhaar and mobile numbers were linked to their respective accounts. **Overall, 97% of beneficiaries reported that their Aadhaar card is linked to their bank or post office account for receiving the pension.** However, 8% of beneficiaries from Chhattisgarh reported that their accounts were not linked which suggests potential exclusion risks or administrative delays in Aadhaar seeding.

On the other hand, 4609 (87%) of beneficiaries stated that their mobile number is linked to their account. Among those, 37% reported always receiving an SMS or notification when the pension amount is credited to their account, whereas 26% mentioned never receiving any such message or notification. This inconsistency in receiving SMS notifications highlights gaps in last-mile communication and system reliability.



“Previously everything was offline, and the beneficiary had to come to the local government office and submit all the documents which are relevant to SSS, but now everything is online; they can directly go to the eSeva centre and apply for the scheme”
-Superintendent, NSAP, Tamil Nadu

3.4.7 Implementation of NSAP: As per Key Stakeholders

Discussions and interviews with state and district officials were conducted to understand the implementation of the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) in detail. The processes, especially those related to beneficiary identification, verification, and fund disbursement vary across states. Some state-specific processes have been provided below:

Gujarat

Gujarat follows a fully digital, portal-based application and verification system for NSAP pensions.

Application Process: Beneficiaries apply either through Digital Gujarat Portal (state platform) or UMANG App (national platform)

Steps Involved:

- Online registration on Digital Gujarat/UMANG.
- Selection of the relevant NSAP pension scheme (IGNOAPS/IGNWPS/IGNDPS).
- Uploading mandatory documents (age proof, BPL/income proof, Aadhaar, bank details).
- Forwarding of the application to verification authorities.
- Verification by district or block officials and approval by the Social Defence Department.
- Integration with DBT for regular pension disbursement.

Further discussions with state officials revealed several challenges associated with receiving applications through the UMANG app. Officials noted that the app allows only data entry, with no option for applicants to upload supporting documents, making it difficult to verify eligibility. As a result, officials are required to re-enter these applications into the state portal, where Aadhaar authentication and document uploads take place. This duplication of effort increases workload, causes delays, and reduces the overall efficiency of the application process.

Additionally, the UMANG app can be accessed only through mobile phones and not via laptops or desktops, which creates operational constraints for staff who typically work on computer-based systems. Officials also highlighted that many elderly and persons with disabilities are unable to use mobile applications, limiting their ability to apply through UMANG and reducing its effectiveness as an inclusive service delivery platform.

Disbursement: The state follows a structured fund flow mechanism for NSAP pensions. Funds from the Central Government are routed to the State Treasury through the Single Nodal Agency (SNA). The State oversees the actual disbursement of pensions to beneficiaries' bank accounts via DBT.

Assam

In Assam, the identification of NSAP beneficiaries follows a community-based, application-driven process led by the Panchayat and Rural Development Department. A key eligibility requirement is that applicants must belong to a Below Poverty Line (BPL) household.

Application Process: Local officials and volunteers collect applications from eligible households at the village level. Applications are verified to confirm age, BPL status, and other required criteria. Verified beneficiary lists are presented in the Gram Sabha for discussion and community validation. The approved list is then forwarded to the designated sanctioning authority for processing.

Disbursement: NSAP payments in Assam are largely made through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). Monthly pensions are deposited directly into beneficiaries' bank or post office accounts, reflecting a strong preference for digital and transparent payments.

Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu follows a hybrid application system, combining e-Seva centres with rigorous field verification by revenue officials.

Application Process: Individuals unfamiliar with the process typically visit the Taluk Office, where they are guided to the e-Seva Centre. After submission, the application is sent to the Village Administrative Officer (VAO) for field verification. The VAO forwards verified applications to the Revenue Inspector (RI), who reviews both the VAO report and field findings. The RI submits the application to the Tahsildar through district website, who gives final approval. Final sanction depends on the availability of funds

depending on the number of beneficiaries fixed for the CRA (treasury authority). Most applications are now submitted online through e-Seva centres, improving accessibility. Applicants receive SMS notifications on their registered mobile numbers for tracking application status. Field verification continues to be carried out by VAOs and RIs to maintain accuracy.

Disbursement: DBT is the primary mode of disbursement, with payments made between the 5th and 6th of every month. About 94% of payments are DBT, and the remaining 6-8% are through electronic money orders (EMO). No payments are made in cash; all transfers are routed through formal banking or postal systems.

Telangana

In Telangana, NSAP schemes are implemented in coordination with Panchayat Secretaries, Mandal-level staff, and the District Rural Development Agency.

Application Process: Applications are collected at the Panchayat level, verified at the Mandal level, and approved at the district level.

- Gram Panchayat: Receives applications and assists citizens with documentation
- Mandal Development Office: Verifies and forwards applications.
- District Rural Development Agency and District Collector: Provides the final approval.
- Post Office: Handles DBT-based payments.

Village Secretaries, SHG Leaders, and GP assist in awareness generation. Mandal-level staff conduct field verification of documents including ration cards, Aadhaar, and death certificates.

Disbursement: Funds are directly transferred from the State Finance Department to the District Treasury. After Aadhaar seeding, funds are credited to beneficiaries' bank accounts through DBT/APB systems. Many elderly and disabled beneficiaries face difficulty in biometric authentication or operating bank accounts, which makes DBT transactions difficult. In such cases, the bank staff or field functionaries withdraw the DBT amount and disburse it in cash after proper verification.

Andhra Pradesh

Andhra Pradesh follows a highly structured, technology-enabled system through the Gram/Ward Secretariat framework.

Application Process: Beneficiary identification and selection is led by Welfare Assistants at the Gram/Ward Secretariat level. The entire process, including scrutiny and sanction of eligible beneficiaries, are supervised and approved by the Mandal Parishad Development Officers (MPDOs)

in rural areas and the Municipal Commissioners (MCs) in urban areas, serving as the sanctioning authorities at the Mandal / Municipality level. The sanctioning authority for pensions at the Block Level is the Mandal Parishad Development Officer (MPDO), who processes the sanctions through Welfare Assistants after verification.

The verification of applications is carried out in a systematic manner to ensure transparency and accuracy in beneficiary selection. The procedure generally involves the following steps:

- **Field Verification:** Welfare Assistants and Secretariat staff conduct field visits to the applicant's residence to verify the details submitted in the application. During these visits, socio-economic conditions and eligibility criteria are cross-checked.
- **Record Verification:** Relevant records such as Aadhaar card, ration card, death certificate (in case of NFBS), income certificate, and other supporting documents are verified to confirm eligibility.
- **Cross-Checking at Secretariat Level:** Verified applications are reviewed at the Secretariat level by the concerned functionaries and approved by the Welfare and Revenue officials.
- **Supervisory Verification:** MPDOs, Tahsildars, and other supervisory officers conduct random checks and field inspections to ensure accuracy and prevent any irregularities.
- **Frequency of Verification:** Field verification is done for every new application, and periodic reviews are conducted during monthly meetings or whenever special verification drives are instructed by higher authorities.

This multi-layered verification system ensures transparency, accountability, and accurate targeting of eligible beneficiaries.

Disbursement: Funds reach Secretariat-level accounts by the 29th or 30th each month who then transfer it to the District Secretariat bank accounts. The respective Panchayat Secretaries or Welfare Secretaries withdraw the funds and disburse them to the concerned pension disbursement functionaries by the 30th of every month. On the 1st of each month, all disbursement functionaries distribute pensions door-to-door using the biometric system, ensuring timely and accurate delivery to beneficiaries.

Haryana

Application Process: Haryana implements old-age, disability, and widow pensions through Pro-Active Pension Mode, enabled by the state's digital Family ID and CRID systems. Instead of relying on the traditional Below Poverty Line (BPL) list, the state automatically identifies eligible individuals such as senior citizens, persons with disabilities, widows, widowers, unmarried persons above a specified age, and destitute individuals using demographic and socio-economic details like age, income, Aadhaar, mobile number, and residence history verified by the CRID Department. Once an individual meets the

eligibility criteria, their information becomes available on the Pro-Active platform and is shared with the Social Justice, Empowerment, Welfare of SC & BC and Antyodaya Department (SEWA Department). Officials from the District Social Welfare Department then contact or visit beneficiaries to collect applications, obtain consent, verify documents such as Aadhaar and Family ID, capture photographs, and generate a Pension Identification Number, ensuring that even those who do not apply themselves are covered. Beneficiaries also have the option to apply online from anywhere, after which district officials call them to the block or district office for verification before forwarding the application for processing. Approvals are granted at the district level, and pensions are subsequently sanctioned and credited directly to the beneficiary's bank account.

Disbursement: Funds are transferred from the Centre to the State through the Finance Department, after which the State disburses pensions to beneficiaries every month through the PFMS (DBT) mode. Aadhaar seeding has been completed for all beneficiaries.

Uttar Pradesh

Application Process: Beneficiaries apply online either from home or through Common Service Centres (CSCs) and cyber cafés. Once the online application is submitted on the portal, verification is conducted in block level as well as village-level officials. Key documents such as income certificates, age proof, disability certificates, bank passbooks, and Aadhaar are verified during this stage. Gram Panchayats play a central role in identifying and selecting eligible persons, with ward members, panchayat assistants, and village development officers actively involved in recommending beneficiaries. Eligibility verification of online applications is carried out at the district level by the Tehsil/Block or District Social Welfare Officer, after which approval is granted. In addition to the regular application system, the state also provides pensions to eligible elderly persons under the National Old Age Pension Scheme through the "One Family One ID" Family ID system, which automatically identifies eligible beneficiaries. All payments are made through online transfer directly to the beneficiary's bank account.

Disbursement: Under NSAP, funds are transferred to beneficiaries' Aadhaar-linked bank accounts through the PFMS portal. Mobile numbers of beneficiaries are linked to their bank accounts. Pension amounts are disbursed quarterly, i.e., once every three months.

Chhattisgarh

Application Process: In Chhattisgarh, the pension process begins with identifying beneficiaries at the village level, where applications are reviewed and approved during Gram Sabha meetings. Self-help groups (SHGs), ward members, and panchayat representatives play an active role in the identification process. After the Gram Sabha recommends beneficiaries, the Gram Panchayat forwards applications to the Janpad Panchayat within 7 days, along with their recommendations. At the Janpad Panchayat

or municipality level, a committee reviews the applications and sanctions or rejects them within 60 days. Verification of applicants, particularly to confirm whether they belong to the BPL category is carried out by Panchayat Secretaries. Once approved, pensions are disbursed to the beneficiaries through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT).

Disbursement: The State Nodal Agency (Directorate of Social Welfare) draws the funds from the treasury and transfers them to the State Nodal Account (SNA) through PFMS. Pension amounts are disbursed monthly to beneficiaries via DBT from the SNA using the NSAP-PPS and PFMS platforms. Aadhaar-based payments are followed, and both Aadhaar seeding and mobile number linkage are completed for DBT.

Bihar

Application Process: In Bihar, beneficiaries apply for pensions through the RTPS counter, after which entries are made into the SSPMIS portal. Applications are processed at multiple levels starting from the block, where they are initially received, and moving upward for verification. The verification process involves the Social Welfare Area Supervisor, Village Development authorities, the Block Development Officer (BDO), the Sub-Divisional Officer (SDO), and the District Social Welfare Officer. The scheme requires detailed documentation, including a death certificate of spouse for widow pensions, income certificates from a competent authority, a ration card and age proof. Aadhaar, voter ID, BPL cards, photographs, and bank account details are used to verify the identity of applicants. Final approval is granted by a District-Level Committee, after which pensions are released at the district level and sent to the beneficiary's account through DBT.

Disbursement: Pensions are disbursed monthly through DBT. From the State, funds are disbursed through PFMS under the DBT system. Aadhaar seeding and authentication are completed for all beneficiaries. Field verification is carried out in cases of failed transactions.

Jammu & Kashmir

Application process: Beneficiaries are identified by the Department of Social Welfare through village Anganwadi workers, who conduct quarterly and annual surveys to collect accurate household information such as gender, age, caste, income, and other required details. Most beneficiaries submit their application forms either directly to the District Social Welfare Officer (DSWO) or through nearby CSC centres. All applications are processed through the Jansugam portal.

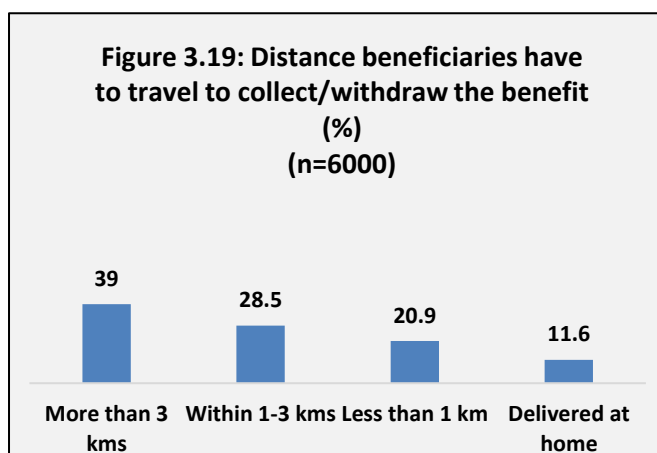
Disbursement: Pension payments are disbursed monthly through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) from the Director, Finance, Department of Social Welfare directly to the beneficiary's bank account

3.4.8 Last-mile Delivery

3.4.8.1 Challenges

The analysis revealed significant challenges in last-mile delivery of pension benefits across states. In most states, beneficiaries had to travel long distances to collect or withdraw their pension.

Out of the 6,000 beneficiaries surveyed, 39.1% reported having to travel more than 3 km to collect or withdraw their pension, while only 11.6% received the benefit at home. Andhra Pradesh stands out positively, with nearly 96% of beneficiaries receiving pensions at home, reflecting an effective last-mile delivery system. Telangana also performs well, with almost three-fourths of beneficiaries accessing benefits within 1 km. In contrast, Jammu &



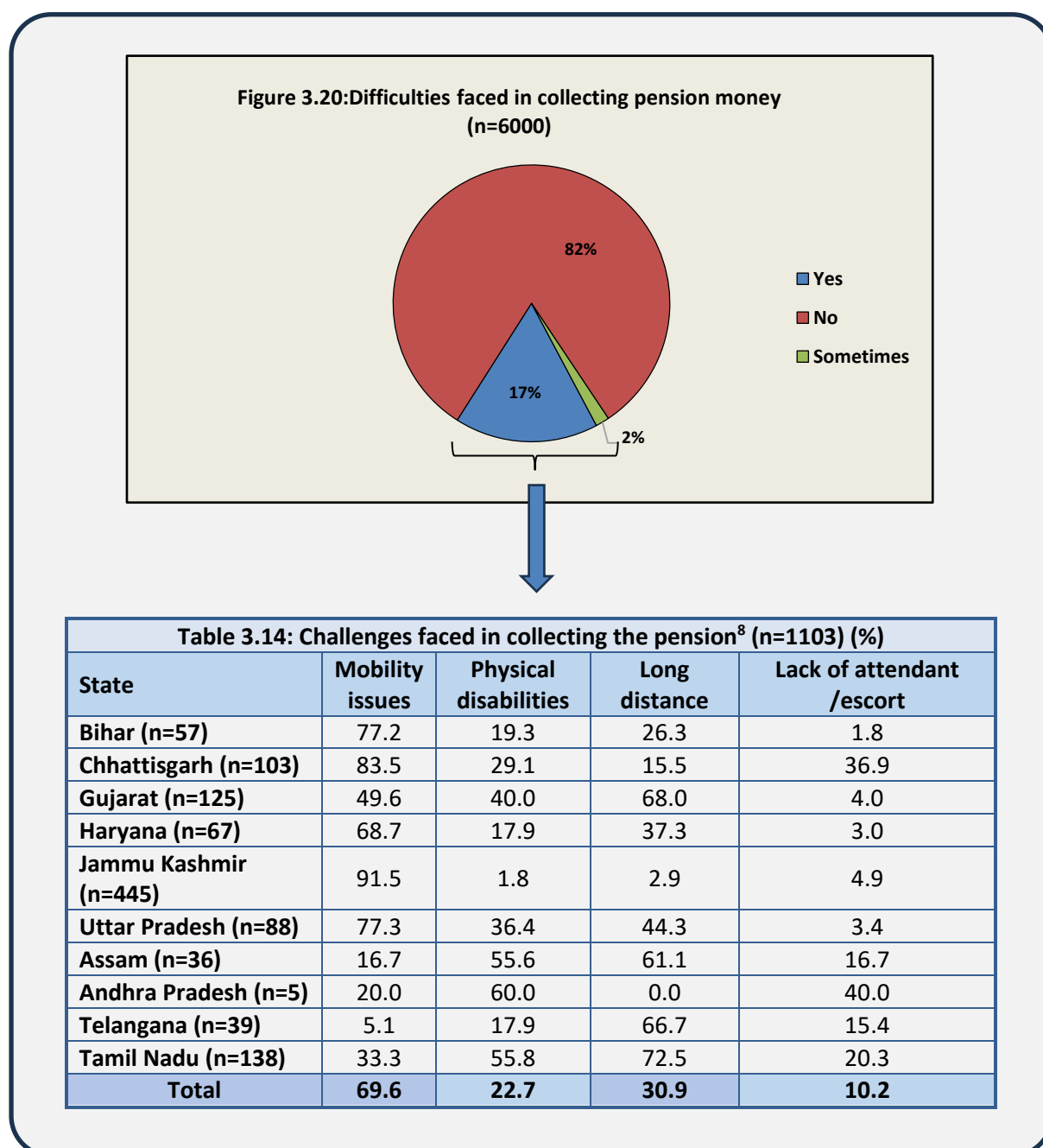
Kashmir faces the greatest access barriers, as 70.5% of beneficiaries reported traveling more than 3 km to collect their pension, likely due to the region's challenging geography.

Table 3.13: Distance beneficiaries have to travel to collect/withdraw the benefit (n=6000) (%)				
State	Delivered at home	Less than 1 km	Within 1-3 kms	More than 3 kms
Bihar (n=600)	0.0	6.8	45.2	48.0
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	0.0	24.7	26.2	49.2
Gujarat (n=600)	1.3	31.0	12.5	55.2
Haryana (n=600)	0.0	15.3	39.3	45.3
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.0	0.3	29.2	70.5
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	0.3	12.2	30.8	56.7
Assam (n=600)	0.5	17.3	48.0	34.2
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	95.8	2.7	0.0	1.5
Telangana (n=600)	4.7	74.7	18.7	2.0
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	13.0	24.0	34.8	28.2

A total of 1103 beneficiaries reported facing challenges or difficulties in collecting the pension money. Mobility issues were found to be the most common barrier, affecting nearly 70% of beneficiaries. Physical disabilities impact around 23%, with higher prevalence in states like Assam, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamil Nadu. Long-distance travel is a major challenge in Gujarat, Telangana, and Tamil Nadu, affecting over 60% of beneficiaries. The lack of an attendant or escort is less common overall but a significant challenge in Chhattisgarh (36.9%) and Andhra Pradesh (40%). Overall, the data highlights

that **mobility and distance are the primary barriers**, with state-specific variations emphasizing the need for tailored last-mile delivery solutions.

Among the beneficiaries who receive their pension through DBT, about 24% experienced Aadhaar-linking issues and 19% faced biometric authentication failures. Other challenges were less common, including spelling errors in names or addresses (5.5%) and mismatches between Aadhaar and DBT records (2.2%).



⁸ **Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%.

3.4.8.2 Special arrangements for effective last-mile delivery

To strengthen last-mile delivery of pensions, several states have adopted measures to ensure that beneficiaries receive support in a timely and accessible manner:

Andhra Pradesh:

Pensions are disbursed at centrally located and easily accessible points in the village between the 1st and 3rd of every month. For elderly or physically challenged beneficiaries who are unable to travel, designated officials from the Panchayat Bhawan Secretariat deliver the pension amount directly to their homes.

Haryana:

The Social Welfare Department has partnered with banks to provide doorstep services. If a beneficiary is unable to visit the bank due to health or mobility constraints, they can inform the bank, following which bank officials complete the required formalities and arrange for pension delivery at the beneficiary's residence.

Tamil Nadu:

Some beneficiaries receive pension through the post office system, with postmen providing doorstep delivery where needed. In certain areas, mobile ATM facilities are also available. Some NGOs support differently-abled beneficiaries, and banking correspondents also assist in delivering pensions. Postmen and BCs visit the homes of beneficiaries who are unable to travel.

Jammu & Kashmir:

In areas where bank branches are distant, Khidmat Centres are used for cash disbursement. In some other locations, elderly and disabled beneficiaries receive support through doorstep delivery facilitated by ASHA workers, Anganwadi staff, and SHG volunteers.

Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh:

No special arrangements for doorstep delivery have been instituted in these states. Beneficiaries who are unable to visit distant banks, particularly the very elderly or persons with disabilities often rely on Common Service Centres (CSCs). At CSCs, beneficiaries' identity is authenticated through Aadhaar after which they withdraw their pension, typically paying a nominal service charge of around ₹10.

3.4.9 Use of NSAP-PPS Portal

The NSAP-Pension Payment System (PPS) has been designed to ensure efficient, transparent, and time-bound management of pension delivery under the scheme. It serves as a digital mechanism for maintaining and monitoring beneficiary records at the grassroots level. Among the ten states covered in the present study, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, and Uttar

Pradesh continue to use their state-specific MIS platforms for pension disbursement and monitoring, while other states rely directly on the NSAP-MIS. Although state-developed systems allow customization to local administrative processes, full data integration with the NSAP-MIS remains essential for ensuring consistency, comparability, and transparency in reporting.

Analysis of survey data indicated that, on average, 68.6% of Gram Panchayat officials across the surveyed states reported using the MIS system to maintain records of beneficiaries. Usage was notably high in Telangana (86.5%), Uttar Pradesh (80.4%), and Bihar (75.6%), reflecting stronger integration of digital systems in pension management. In contrast, states such as Tamil Nadu (35.7%) and Gujarat (55.3%) reported relatively lower use of the system, suggesting continued reliance on manual or panchayat specific record-keeping mechanisms. A small but significant share of GPs (12.6%) reported that records of NSAP beneficiaries were not maintained at the GP level, particularly in Chhattisgarh (31.4%) and Gujarat (26.3%). This highlights the need for greater capacity-building and system standardization to ensure that data on beneficiary coverage, payments, and verification are uniformly captured across all administrative levels. Strengthening the use of the NSAP-PPS will not only enhance transparency and efficiency in pension disbursement but also facilitate better monitoring and policy planning through real-time, centralized data integration.

Table 3.15: Use of NSAP-PPS/MIS by GP to maintain records of NSAP beneficiaries (n=600) (%)			
State	Yes	No	Not maintained at GP level
Andhra Pradesh (n=60)	72.9	20.8	6.3
Assam (n=60)	62.0	26.0	12.0
Bihar (n=60)	75.6	14.6	9.8
Chhattisgarh (n=60)	60.0	8.6	31.4
Gujarat (n=60)	55.3	18.4	26.3
Haryana (n=60)	61.2	30.6	8.2
Tamil Nadu (n=60)	35.7	50.0	14.3
Telangana (n=60)	86.5	1.9	11.5
Uttar Pradesh (n=60)	80.4	17.4	2.2
Total	68.6	18.8	12.6

3.4.10 Social Audit

To promote transparency, accountability, and people's participation under NSAP, the scheme guidelines emphasize the conduct of social audits. The key objectives of the social audit include generating awareness among stakeholders, ensuring proactive disclosure of scheme-related information, verifying beneficiaries, identifying eligible and ineligible individuals, providing a platform for recording grievances, and identifying implementation-related issues faced by beneficiaries.

As per the guidelines, a Social Audit Unit (SAU) has been established in every state for MGNREGA, and these units are also responsible for conducting social audits of NSAP. However, discussions with state-level implementing officials indicate wide variation in the frequency and quality of NSAP-related audits across states. States such as Chhattisgarh and Bihar reported that the MGNREGA Social Audit Unit conducts social audits for NSAP once a year, while Haryana noted that no NSAP-specific social audit has been carried out so far. Officials from Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Gujarat stated that audits are being conducted regularly. In contrast, field interactions with beneficiaries across Haryana, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, and other study states revealed very low awareness about NSAP social audits, suggesting gaps in community-level dissemination and participation. Further discussions with Gram Panchayat officials provided insights into audit practices at the local level, highlighting the need for strengthening the visibility, inclusiveness, and feedback mechanisms of NSAP social audits to ensure greater transparency and accountability.

Overall, 53.5% of gram panchayat and ward officials confirmed that a social audit had been conducted, while 30.7% reported that it had not, and 15.8% were not aware of whether it had taken place. Across states, the **highest incidence of social audits was reported in Assam (86.7%), Uttar Pradesh (80%), and Andhra Pradesh (76.7%), indicating a relatively strong monitoring and transparency in these states.** In Jammu & Kashmir, none of the officials reported conducting a social audit for NSAP.

Table 3.16: Gram Sabha/Ward Committee that has conducted Social Audits for NSAP schemes (n=600) (%)			
State	Yes	No	Don't know
Andhra Pradesh (n=60)	76.7	18.3	5.0
Assam (n=60)	86.7	6.7	6.7
Bihar (n=60)	45.0	11.7	43.3
Chhattisgarh (n=60)	43.3	46.7	10.0
Gujarat (n=60)	33.3	18.3	48.3
Haryana (n=60)	66.7	13.3	20.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=60)	0.0	96.7	3.3
Tamil Nadu (n=60)	43.3	55.0	1.7
Telangana (n=60)	60.0	28.3	11.7
Uttar Pradesh (n=60)	80.0	11.7	8.3
Total	53.5	30.7	15.8

As depicted in **Figure 3.22**, out of the 321 gram panchayat and ward officials who reported of conducting social audits, 56.7% of officials reported that social audits are conducted annually, while 22% said they occur quarterly. Among the 184 GP and ward officials who reported not conducting social audits, the

most frequently cited reasons were lack of awareness (33.2%), lack of manpower or resources (25.5%), and lack of knowledge on how to conduct a social audit (30.4%). States such as Gujarat (72.7%), Chhattisgarh (53.6%), and Bihar (57.1%) had the highest share of respondents who said they did not know how to conduct a social audit. Meanwhile, Jammu & Kashmir (44.8%), Tamil Nadu (48.5%), and Uttar Pradesh (42.9%) showed a relatively higher lack of awareness about the need to conduct one. Overall, the findings highlighted that while social audits are being implemented in over half of the surveyed areas, there are significant capacity and awareness gaps across states.

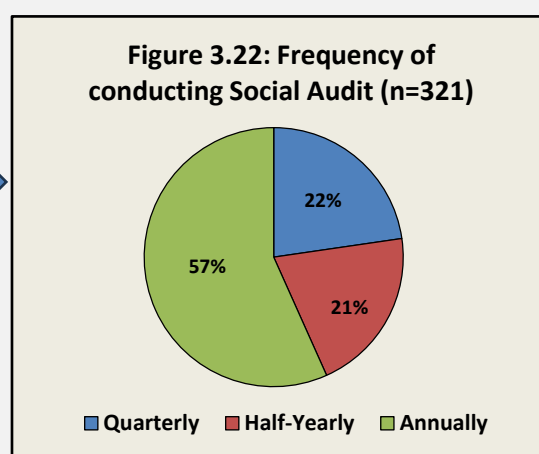
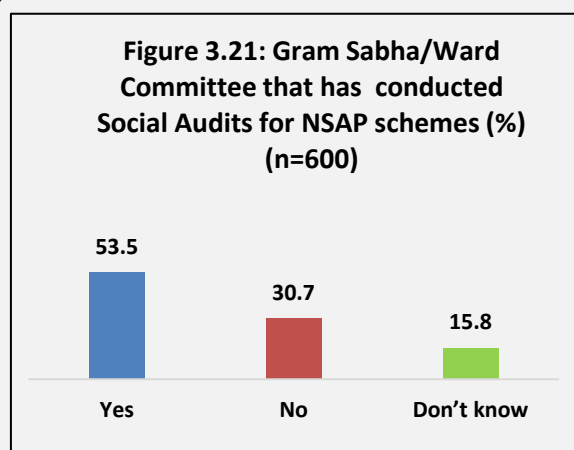


Table 3.17: Reasons for not conducting a social audit (n=184) (%)

State	We did not know that Social Audit needs to be conducted	Lack of manpower or resources	Lack of time	Do not know how to conduct a Social Audit	Others
Andhra Pradesh (n=11)	9.1	36.4	9.1	27.3	18.2
Assam (n=4)	25.0	50.0	25.0	0.0	0.0
Bihar (n=7)	28.6	0.0	0.0	57.1	14.3
Chhattisgarh (n=28)	10.7	10.7	17.9	53.6	7.1
Gujarat (n=11)	27.3	0.0	0.0	72.7	0.0
Haryana (n=8)	0.0	25.0	37.5	37.5	0.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=58)	44.8	34.5	0.0	20.7	0.0
Tamil Nadu (n=33)	48.5	24.2	3.0	18.2	6.1
Telangana (n=17)	35.3	35.3	0.0	17.6	11.8
Uttar Pradesh (n=7)	42.9	28.6	0.0	28.6	0.0
Total	33.2	25.5	6.0	30.4	4.9

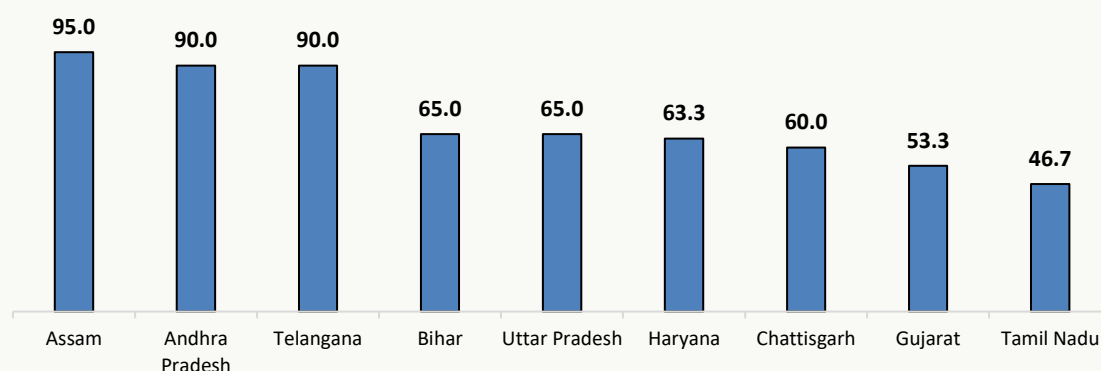
“The Social Audit Committee is formed with local SHG members and community representatives. We give them the list of pension beneficiaries and fund records before the audit. During the Gram Sabha, they present their findings in front of everyone. If ineligible names are found, we remove them and forward such connections to the block office. Normally, this happens once a year, but sometimes more often if directed by the district office.”

- PRI member, Pothugal GP, Telangana

3.4.11 Grievance Redressal

The gram Panchayat and ward officials were asked about the types of grievance redressal mechanisms available in their respective areas. Out of the 600 panchayat and ward surveyed, 377 said that they have a grievance redressal system in place. The highest presence of such mechanisms was reported in Assam (95%), followed by Andhra Pradesh (90%) and Telangana (90%). On the other hand, **Jammu & Kashmir (0%) and Tamil Nadu (46.7%) had the lowest presence of such mechanisms, indicating significant gaps in accountability and feedback channels in these states.**

Figure 3.23: State-wise presence of grievance redressal mechanisms in GP/Ward as reported by GP/Ward officials (%) (n=600)



Note: This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%.

Gram Sabha meetings were found to be the most common platform for raising complaints or grievances, with 80.1% of officials reporting their use. States such as Bihar and Tamil Nadu reported 100% reliance on Gram Sabha meetings, followed closely by Telangana (87%), Haryana (84.2%), and Chhattisgarh (83.3%). This suggests that **community-based forums remain the primary mode for grievance redressal** in most states. Use of toll-free numbers remains limited overall (24.9%), with the highest adoption in Andhra Pradesh (44.4%) and Haryana (36.8%). The findings underscore the **need to strengthen and expand remote grievance redressal mechanisms to make it easier for people, especially the elderly or those living in remote areas, to raise complaints without having to wait for Gram Sabha meetings or travel long distances.**

Figure 3.24: Presence of have a grievance redressal system in Panchayat/Ward? (n=600)

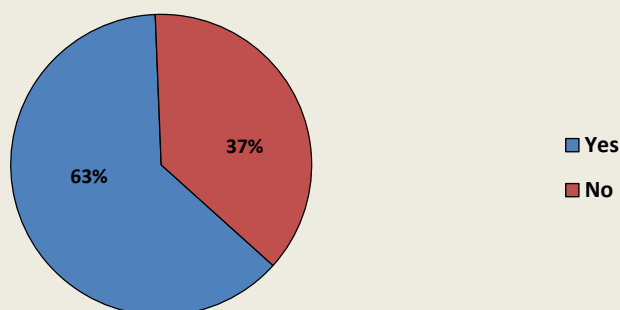


Table 3.18: Types of grievance redressal system in GP/Ward (n=377) (%)⁹

States	Panchayat Complaint Box (%)	Toll-free number (%)	Gram Sabha Meetings (%)	Others (%)
Andhra Pradesh(n=54)	72.2	44.4	66.7	0.0
Assam (n=57)	64.9	14.0	75.4	3.5
Bihar (n=39)	28.2	25.6	100.0	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=36)	61.1	13.9	83.3	0.0
Gujarat (n=32)	59.4	18.8	65.6	0.0
Haryana (n=38)	52.6	36.8	84.2	0.0
Tamil Nadu (n=28)	3.6	17.9	100.0	21.4
Telangana (n=54)	40.7	16.7	87.0	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=39)	35.9	33.3	66.7	0.0
Total	49.1	24.9	80.1	2.1

Among the 111 beneficiaries who reported grievances, **the most common grievance across states was delay in receiving pensions**, and was reported by the majority of respondents in Chhattisgarh (100%), Uttar Pradesh (90%), Assam (90.9%), and Haryana (83.3%). Other frequently reported problems include pensions being stopped without explanation which was found to be a serious concern in Uttar Pradesh

⁹ **Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%

(60%) and Assam (63.6%). Aadhaar-related challenges were also significant in states like Bihar (50%) and Jammu & Kashmir (36.4%). Instances of bribes or unofficial fees was reported only in Andhra Pradesh (9.1%). Telangana stands out as an exception, with no grievances reported, suggesting effective delivery of pension in the state.

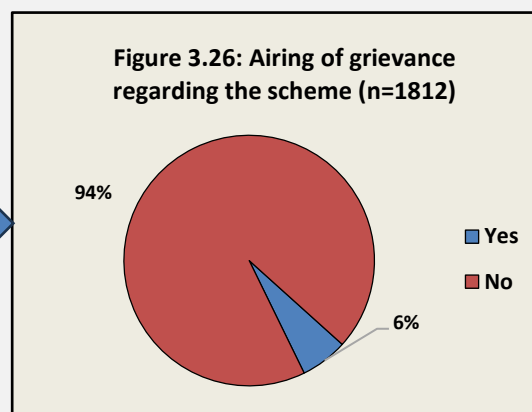
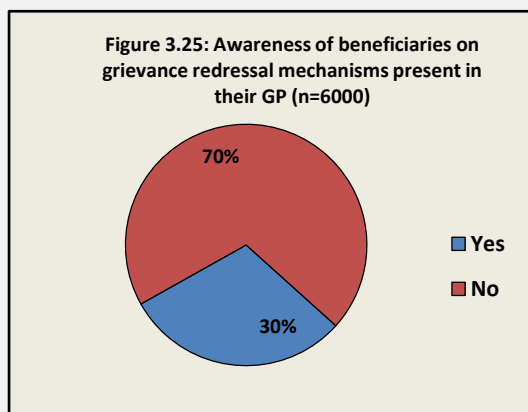


Table 3.19: Type of grievances the beneficiaries have raised (n=111) (%)¹⁰

State	Delay in receiving pension	Pension stopped without reason	Name or account details entered incorrectly	Difficulty in linking Aadhar	Asked to pay bribe or unofficial fees	Lack of help from officials
Bihar (n=2)	50.0	0.0	0.0	50.0	0.0	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=6)	100.0	16.7	0.0	0.0	0.0	16.7
Gujarat (n=27)	81.5	3.7	14.8	29.6	0.0	7.4
Haryana (n=12)	83.3	25.0	25.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=11)	63.6	45.5	0.0	36.4	0.0	9.1
Uttar Pradesh (n=20)	90.0	60.0	30.0	0.0	0.0	5.0
Assam(n=11)	90.9	63.6	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Andhra Pradesh (n=11)	36.4	18.2	18.2	36.4	9.1	18.2
Telangana (n=0)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Tamil Nadu(n=11)	63.6	18.2	0.0	27.3	0.0	0.0
Total	76.6	29.7	13.5	18.0	0.9	6.3

¹⁰ **Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%.

The majority (80.2%) of beneficiaries with grievances visited Municipality or Panchayat officials, establishing them as the primary point of contact for their problem resolution. This reliance is nearly universal in states like Bihar, Gujarat, Haryana, and Andhra Pradesh (100%). However, in Assam, beneficiaries used a more distributed network, contacting Anganwadi workers (63.6%), NGOs/SHGs (54.5%), and banks (27.3%) alongside Municipality/Panchayat officials.

Table 3.20: People visited for grievance redressal ¹¹ (n=111)					
State	Municipality /Panchayat Officials	Anganwadi/ Workers	NGO/SHG workers	Banks/Banking correspondents (e-mitra, etc.)/ Post office	Others (please specify)
Bihar (n=2)	100.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=6)	83.3	16.7	0.0	0.0	0.0
Gujarat (n=27)	100.0	11.1	0.0	7.4	0.0
Haryana (n=12)	100.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Jammu & Kashmir (n=11)	18.2	0.0	0.0	9.1	72.7
Uttar Pradesh (n=20)	95.0	5.0	5.0	10.0	5.0
Assam (n=11)	45.5	63.6	54.5	27.3	0.0
Andhra Pradesh (n=11)	100.0	9.1	0.0	0.0	0.0
Tamil Nadu (n=11)	54.5	0.0	0.0	9.1	36.4
Total	80.2	11.7	6.3	8.1	11.7

The respondents who registered grievances were further asked whether their concerns were suitably addressed. The findings show that grievance resolution has been largely effective across most states. All the respondents from Tamil Nadu and Chhattisgarh (100%) stated that their grievances were suitably addressed. High levels of satisfaction were also seen in Uttar Pradesh (90%), Assam (81.8%), Haryana (75%), and Jammu & Kashmir (72.7%), indicating that grievance mechanisms in these states are functioning fairly well. In contrast, Gujarat (66.7%) and Bihar (50%) reported relatively lower levels of resolution, suggesting that grievance management systems in these states require further strengthening.

“Whenever issues such as delays in pension disbursement or rejection of applications arose, we reached out to the Gram Panchayat. The Panchayat responded promptly and addressed these matters appropriately.”

- Focus group discussions with beneficiaries, Sarsai GP, Gujarat

¹¹ **Note:** This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%

3.4.12 Best Practices

- **Awareness Generation:** In Jammu and Kashmir, the Department of Social Welfare undertakes awareness activities through print and electronic media. Additionally, Anganwadi and ASHA workers play an active role in disseminating information about the scheme at the community level. This multi-channel approach ensures that every eligible person is informed and encouraged to apply for the benefits.
- **Eligibility Criteria:** Instead of using the traditional Below Poverty Line (BPL) criteria, Haryana follows a Family ID system. This ID is issued by the government after collecting essential details such as the applicant's name, Aadhaar number, mobile number, duration of residence in Haryana, and bank account details. In the event of a beneficiary's death, the death certificate is digitally linked to the Family ID, ensuring automatic updates. Beneficiaries are automatically identified through this system and subsequently called to the block office for verification and disbursement. Since the process functions without interference from Gram Panchayat or ward officials, it has significantly reduced the scope for corruption. Beneficiaries in Haryana reported being highly satisfied with this transparent and efficient system, which eliminates the need for repeated visits to Panchayat offices. This model can be replicated by other states to ensure fair and smooth implementation.
- **Disbursement of Money:** In Andhra Pradesh, an efficient process is followed for pension disbursement. Pensions are distributed at a centrally located, easily accessible point in the village between the 1st and 3rd of every month. For elderly and physically challenged beneficiaries who are unable to visit the site, designated officials from the Panchayat Bhawan Secretariat personally deliver the pension amount to their homes. Similarly, in Haryana, the Social Welfare Department has established a partnership with banks to ensure doorstep service. If a beneficiary is unable to visit the bank to receive the DBT (Direct Benefit Transfer) amount due to health or mobility issues, they can inform the bank. The bank then takes responsibility for completing necessary formalities and arranging for the delivery of the amount to the beneficiary.
- **Assistance with Application Process:** During the survey, several beneficiaries mentioned facing difficulties in completing the application process. In Assam, local officials at the Gram Panchayat and Block levels assist especially vulnerable individuals, such as the elderly or persons with disabilities, in filling out application forms and submitting the required documents. This practice of extending proactive support to vulnerable groups can be adopted in other states as well to enhance accessibility and inclusion.

Andhra Pradesh: A Case Study

Andhra Pradesh (AP) stands out as one of the leading states in India in implementing social security pensions, including the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP). The state has integrated NSAP within its broader NTR Bharosa Pension Scheme, ensuring seamless service delivery, strong monitoring, and significant coverage of vulnerable populations. The following highlights some of AP's best practices observed during the interviews with the state-level and district-level officials:

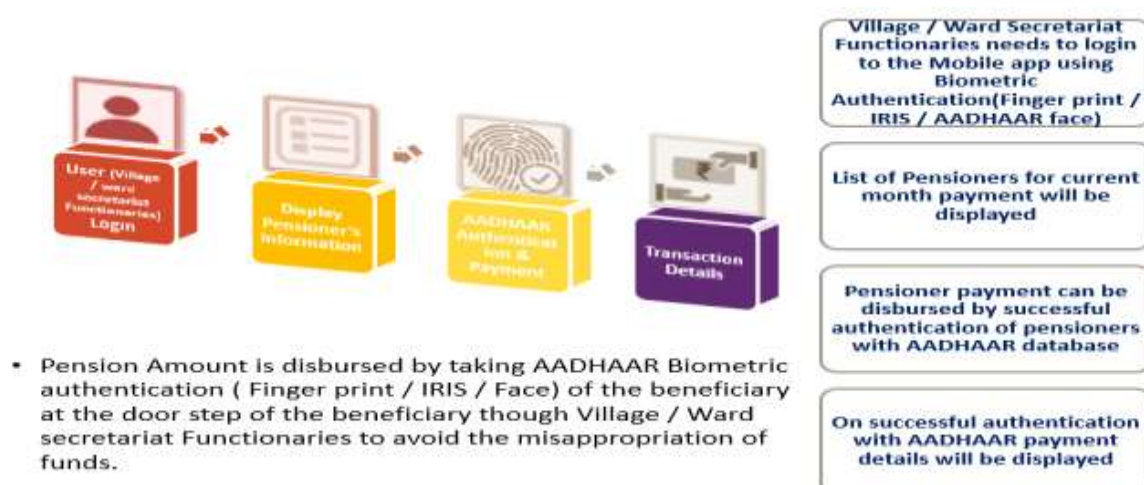
High State Top-Up: Andhra Pradesh provides substantially higher pension amounts as top-up over central share, thus ensuring stronger financial security for elderly, widowed, and disabled beneficiaries.

Strong Community Involvement: SHGs, Village Organizations, and Secretariat staff play an active role in awareness, identification, verification, and grievance support, strengthening transparency and accountability.

Support for Elderly and Disabled Beneficiaries and efficient last-mile delivery: Support is provided to elderly and disabled beneficiaries to ensure they can access their pension amounts without difficulty. Pension disbursement functionaries deliver pensions door-to-door, using biometric authentication to ensure accuracy and prevent fraud. Welfare Assistants and Panchayat staff also help beneficiaries complete any necessary documentation or verification, enabling the timely and hassle-free receipt of benefits.

Identification and Removal of Ghost Beneficiaries: Instances of bogus or ghost beneficiaries were rare but have been identified occasionally in Andhra Pradesh. These cases are detected through cross-verification of records, field visits, and reconciliation of beneficiary databases with Aadhaar, ration, and revenue data. Random audits and supervisory checks at both the Mandal and District levels further assist in identifying discrepancies. Once such cases are confirmed, the beneficiary entries are immediately removed, and recovery of any wrongly disbursed funds is initiated. Officials responsible for lapses are held accountable, with disciplinary action and retraining implemented to prevent recurrence.

Pension Disbursement: All Pensions including NSAP pensions are processed for payment by state own MIS system (APT Online) and disbursed through Village/Ward Secretariat functionaries.



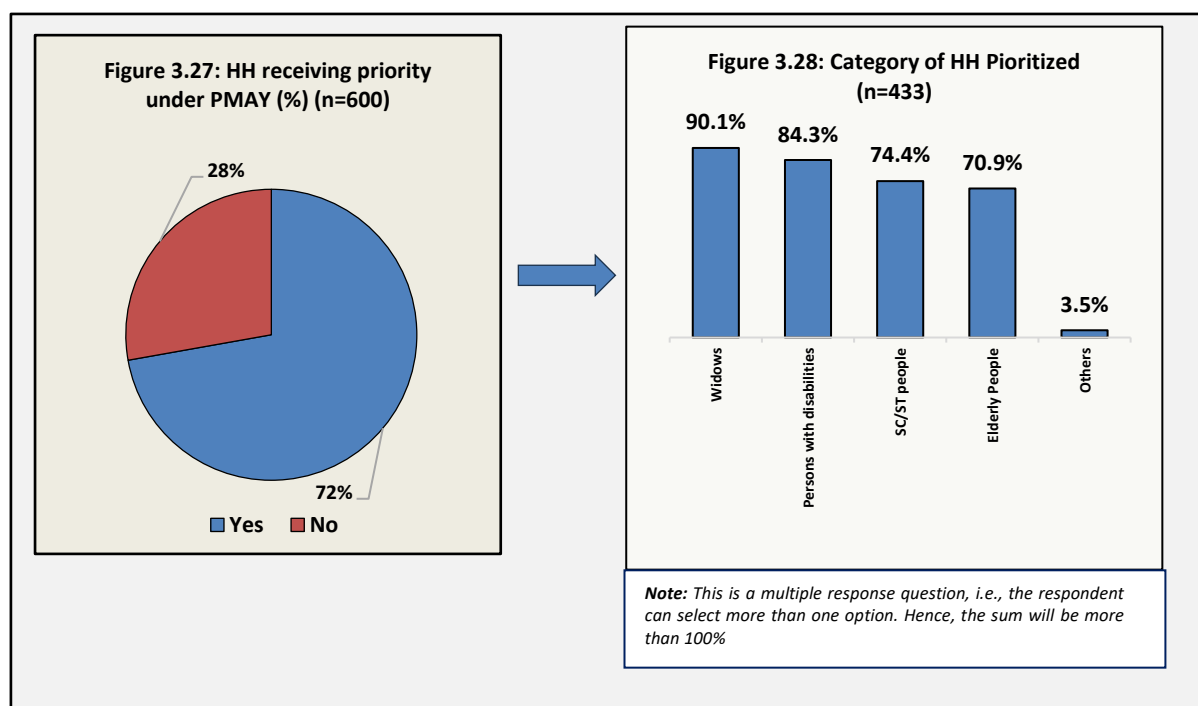
Social Audit: For all pension schemes of the government, including NSAP, social audit is conducted by Society for Social Audit Accountability and Transparency (APSSAAT). This is the same unit that conducts the social audit for MGNREGA.

Grievance Redressal Mechanisms: The state has established multiple grievance redressal mechanisms to ensure that NSAP beneficiaries can report issues and receive timely support. Mandal Parishad Development Officers (MPDOs) and Municipal Commissioners act as nodal officers for receiving and addressing complaints. Beneficiaries may submit grievances through helplines, secretariat contact points, written applications at panchayat/secretariat offices, or via phone communication. Weekly grievance redressal meetings are conducted at the Secretariat, Mandal/Municipality, and District levels to review and resolve pending issues. Each complaint is tracked until resolution, with corrective measures implemented to avoid repetition.

3.4.13 Convergence of NSAP with Other Schemes

Discussions with State Nodal Officials and implementing agencies indicate that the level of convergence between NSAP and other social protection schemes varies considerably across states. The strongest integration was observed in Bihar, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu, and Chhattisgarh, where beneficiaries are linked to multiple schemes such as PDS, PMAY-G/urban housing, employment under MGNREGA, and NRLM/NULM SHGs. Bihar and Jammu Kashmir demonstrates near-universal convergence with all the schemes, including coverage under the Aam Aadmi Bima Yojana (AABY) and priority access for beneficiaries or their children under the Aajeevika Skills Programme. In contrast, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh exhibit limited convergence, primarily with PDS and MGNREGA. Officials in these two states noted that responsibility for other schemes lies with other departments, leading to limited awareness of convergence with other schemes. Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana further strengthen convergence through robust integration with state health insurance schemes. **Overall, while food security and MGNREGA linkages remain consistently strong, convergence with insurance and skill development programmes is uneven and continues to depend on state-level coordination and data-sharing mechanisms.**

As outlined in the guidelines, special efforts are required to ensure that eligible NSAP beneficiaries receive housing support under Indira Awaas Yojana and related urban housing schemes. In this context, Gram Panchayats and ward officials were asked whether any households in their area had been given priority under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY). A significant 72% confirmed that such priority allotments had been made. Among the categories prioritized, widow-headed households received the highest preference (90.1%), followed by households with persons with disabilities (84.3%). However, households with elderly members were reported to be considerably less prioritized. These findings suggest that while PMAY is successfully targeting key vulnerable groups, additional efforts may be needed to ensure more equitable inclusion of elderly.



3.4.14 Other State-specific Pension Schemes

The impact of the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) needs to be viewed in the context of the wider social protection framework at the state level. In addition to the centrally sponsored NSAP, many states have implemented their own pension and welfare programmes targeting similar beneficiary groups like the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities. These state schemes operate independently of NSAP, though their objectives and design substantially overlap. For instance, Bihar implements the State Disability Pension scheme; Chhattisgarh runs the CM Pension Scheme; while Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have consolidated assistance under the NTR Bharosa and Asara programmes respectively. The coexistence of these programmes highlights the federal diversity in social protection delivery. While this demonstrates strong state commitment to supporting vulnerable populations, it also raises important considerations regarding duplication, targeting efficiency, and data integration between state and central schemes.

The table below provides an overview of some major state-specific social security schemes that complement NSAP:

State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
Uttar Pradesh	PM SYM (Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maan-Dhan Yojana)	18-40 years	Monthly Income up to Rs 15000/	For Un-organized Workers (UW)	₹3000/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
	Kust Awastha Pension	All ages	Disabled due to Leprosy (any % disability), Annual Income up to Rs 46,080 (rural) or Rs 56,460 (urban)	Persons affected by Leprosy	₹3000/month
Bihar	Mukhyamant ri Vridhjan Pension Yojana (MVPY)	60 years and above	No BPL restriction; Should not be retired govt. employee; Not receiving any other pension	All Senior Citizens (all castes, religions, communities) - NOT restricted to BPL	₹400/month for age group 60-79 years; ₹500/month for 80 years and above
	Laxmibai Social Security Pension Scheme	18 years and above	Must be widow, Annual family income below ₹60,000; NOT restricted to BPL	All Widows (not covered under IGNWPS)	₹300/month
	Bihar State Disability Pension Scheme	All ages	Minimum 40% disability; No upper income limit	Persons with Disabilities - 40% or more (not covered under IGNDPS)	₹400/month
Chhattisgarh	CM Pension Scheme	Senior Citizen: 60 years and above;	Should be a native of Chhattisgarh; senior citizen, widow, or abandoned woman (18 years and above); in urban areas, the name of the applicant should be listed in the survey list of Socio-Economic and Caste Census 2011; should not be receiving pension benefits from	Senior Citizens, Widows, Abandoned women	₹500/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
			any other central or state government pension scheme.		
	Mahtari Vandan Yojana	Women 21 years and above	Should be a resident of Chhattisgarh, married women, widows, divorced, abandoned women.	Women older than 21 years of age	₹1000/month
Haryana	Pension to Widows and Destitute Women	18 years and above	Permanent resident of Haryana; Widow/Woman without a husband, parents, or children/destitute woman due to desertion or the physical/mental incapacity of her husband (for married women) or parents (for other women); income from all sources should be less than ₹2,00,000.	Women	₹2500/month
	Financial Assistance to Destitute Children	Under 21 years of age	Domicile of Haryana; Income of parents/guardians should not exceed ₹2,00,000 per annum; Children have been deprived of parental support or care for the following reasons: • Reason of Death or; • Continued absence from home of his father for the last 2 years, or; • Father/Mother has been sentenced to imprisonment for a period not less than one year, or;	Children under 21 years of age	₹2100/month/child (Maximum of 2 children in one family)

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
			Physical/Mental incapacity of the Parent.		
	Ladli Social Security Allowance	Poor families	Biological single parent/parents of the family should be domiciled in Haryana or should be working for the Government of Haryana; family should have no son and one or more girl children; annual income should not exceed ₹2,00,000 per annum.	Families with girl children	₹2500/month for 15 years
Andhra Pradesh	NTR Bharosa Pension scheme: Old Age pension	60 years and above	Senior citizens who are permanent residents of AP and fall below specified income threshold	Senior citizens	₹4000/month
	NTR Bharosa Pension scheme: Widow Pension	18 years and above	Widows who are permanent residents of AP, BPL category	Women	₹4000/month
	NTR Bharosa Pension scheme: Single Women Pension	18 years and above	Unmarried/divorced/separated women, BPL category	Women	₹4000/month
	NTR Bharosa Pension scheme: Fully Disabled Persons Pension	All ages	Complete disability and BPL category	Persons with complete disability	₹10,000/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
	NTR Bharosa Pension scheme: Disabled Persons and Multiple Deformity Leprosy Persons Pension	All ages	Persons with minimum 40% disability certified by recognized authority, BPL category	PwDs	₹6000/month
Telangana	Aasara Pension Scheme (Old Age)	65 years and above	BPL family; Annual income < ₹1.5 lakh (rural) or ₹2 lakh (urban); Must be resident of Telangana	Senior Citizens living below poverty line	₹1000/month
	Aasara Pension Scheme (Widows)	18 years and above	BPL family; Husband's death certificate required; Annual income < ₹1.5 lakh (rural) or ₹2 lakh (urban); Only one pension per family	Widows	₹1000/month
	Aasara Pension Scheme (Differently-abled)	All ages	40% or higher disability; SADAREM certificate required; BPL family; Annual income < ₹1.5 lakh (rural) or ₹2 lakh (urban)	PwDs	₹1500/month
	Financial Assistance to Single Women	18 years and above	Married women who have been separated or deserted (with the separation period of over 1 year); Unmarried women above 30 years of age in rural areas and above 35 years of age in urban areas; BPL family; Unmarried affidavit required; Annual income	Unmarried Women	₹1000/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
			< ₹1.5 lakh (rural) or ₹2 lakh (urban); should not be covered under social security pension scheme.		
Tamil Nadu	Destitute Widow Pension Scheme (DWPS)	18-40 years	Fixed assets should not exceed ₹1,00,000; should be destitute; should be a widow.	Widows	₹1000/month
	Destitute/Deserted Wives Pension Scheme	30 years and above	Fixed assets should not exceed ₹1,00,000; must be legally divorced or separated for 5 years and above; deserted woman certificate.	Destitute Women	₹1000/month
	Pension to Unmarried Poor, Incapacitated Women of Age 50 years and above	50 years and above	Destitute unmarried women; fixed assets should not exceed ₹1,00,000.	Destitute women	₹1000/month
	Chief Minister's Uzhavar Pathukappu Thittam (CMUPT) Old Age Pension	60 years and above	Farmer or landless agricultural labour; fixed assets should not exceed ₹1,00,000.	Senior Citizens	₹1000/month
Jammu and Kashmir	Integrated Social Security Scheme (ISSS) - Old Age Pension	60 years and above (male) and 55 years and	Income should be less than ₹75,000 per annum or BPL category.	Senior Citizens	₹1000/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
		above (female)			
	Integrated Social Security Scheme (ISSS) - Physically Challenged/Disabled Persons Pension	18 years and above	Disability 40% or above; no source of income; income should not exceed ₹3,00,000 per annum.	PwDs	₹1000/month
	Integrated Social Security Scheme (ISSS) - Women in Distress Pension (WID)	40-79 years	Destitute/widow/divorced/deserted woman; income should be less than ₹75,000 per annum or BPL category.	Women	₹4000/month
Gujarat	Ganga Swaroopa Arthik Sahay Yojana	18 years and above	Must be a resident of Gujarat; widowed; annual income must not exceed ₹1,20,000/- in rural areas and ₹1,50,000/- in urban area.	Widowed Women	₹1250/month
	Sant Surdas Yojana	0-17 years	Native of Gujarat; 80% or more disability or those who cannot move even with help of artificial limbs independently; should be registered in the Below Poverty Line (BPL) list and BPL score is up to 20; should be possessing disability	PwDs	₹1000/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
			card issued by state government		
Assam	Swahid Kushal Konwar Sarbajanin Briddha Pension Asoni	60 years and above	Should not be a beneficiary of any existing government schemes, parents of children (where the latter is employed with the government); Any taxpayer who earns an income of above ₹ 2,50,000	Senior Citizens	₹250/month
	Deen Dayal Divyangjan Sahajya Asoni	All ages	Disability of 40% or more; must be a resident of Assam	PwDs	₹1000/month
	Assam Orunodoi Scheme		1. Widow, unmarried (above the age of 45 yrs) 2. Transgender 3. Person with disability, as defined in the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, irrespective of gender 4. Old/Infirm woman including those residing in Government registered old age home 5. Women of the Household, where earning members are either disabled or aged (more than sixty years of age) 6. Woman in household, where any member is suffering from HIV/ Thalassemia/ Haemophilia/ Cerebral Palsy/ Leprosy/ Autism	Women and PwDs	₹1250/month

Table 3.21: Other state-specific schemes of governments					
State	Name of the scheme	Age	Criteria	Beneficiary Group	Amount Allocation
			spectrum disorder 7. Woman in household without shelter 8. Destitute woman living on alms 9. Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) woman beneficiary 10. Women in the household, composite income of which is less than Rs.2 lacs per annum.		
	Aideu Handique Mahila Samman Asoni	40 years and above	Unmarried/divorced/separated/single women	Women	₹250/month

These state schemes supplement the NSAP and expand coverage to groups not eligible under central norms, thereby improving overall inclusion. However, the absence of a unified beneficiary database or proper eligibility criteria can lead to inconsistencies in benefit delivery and difficulty in monitoring cumulative social protection outcomes. **This reinforces the need for better convergence and coordination mechanisms between NSAP and similar state-level schemes to ensure that assistance reaches all intended beneficiaries efficiently, without duplication or exclusion.**

Effectiveness of the Scheme

4.1 Socio-Economic Aspects of the Scheme

4.1.1 Income and Source of Livelihood

The transition from joint to nuclear family structures has significant implications for old-age income security. Analysis of household size data indicates that in several **states such as Andhra Pradesh, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, and Telangana, the average family size is as low as two members**, suggesting a higher likelihood of elderly persons living alone or with only one other dependent. In contrast, **states such as Assam, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, and Uttar Pradesh show an average family size of around three members**, while Gujarat and Jammu & Kashmir report relatively larger households with an average size of four members. In states with smaller household sizes, the diminishing role of traditional family-based support systems increases the vulnerability of the elderly, underscoring the importance of social pensions as a critical and often primary source of income support.

The study findings (Table 4.1) reflect this trend in household livelihood patterns, wherein **social assistance and pensions constitute the primary source of income for nearly 24% of households**. Dependence on these transfers is substantially higher in states such as Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, where more than half of households report social assistance or pensions as their main source of income. In Chhattisgarh, 38.3% of households identify pensions or social assistance as a primary income source, underscoring their critical role in supporting vulnerable populations. At the same time, **a significant proportion of households continue to rely on wage labour and small-scale farming**.

Table 4.1: Primary source of livelihood for the household (n=6000) (%)

State	Farming on own land (%)	Farming on leased land (%)	Animal husbandry/livestock rearing (%)	Skilled wage labour (%)	Unskilled wage labour (%)	Small business/shop (%)	Salaried employment of other household member (Private) (%)	Salaried employment of other household member (Govt.) (%)	Pension/social assistance (%)
Bihar (n=600)	37.0	0.5	1.5	8.0	48.3	2.3	0.2	0.0	2.2
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	31.7	1.7	0.2	4.8	16.8	3.0	3.0	0.5	38.3
Gujarat (n=600)	21.8	1.8	4.3	22.0	13.0	2.7	2.8	0.0	31.5

Table 4.1: Primary source of livelihood for the household (n=6000) (%)									
State	Farming on own land (%)	Farming on leased land (%)	Animal husbandry/livestock rearing (%)	Skilled wage labour (%)	Unskilled wage labour (%)	Small business/shop (%)	Salaried employment of other household member (Private) (%)	Salaried employment of other household member (Govt.) (%)	Pension/social assistance (%)
Haryana (n=600)	42.3	0.8	3.7	6.8	34.5	4.3	1.3	0.0	6.2
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.7	0.0	0.0	17.7	34.8	18.0	23.5	4.7	0.7
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	57.7	2.2	1.2	2.7	26.7	2.7	1.0	0.2	5.8
Assam (n=600)	20.3	0.3	9.3	10.0	25.2	15.2	12.3	1.7	5.7
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	11.5	7.2	2.0	3.5	18.3	2.5	0.7	0.7	53.7
Telangana (n=600)	12.0	0.5	1.0	9.0	20.7	2.5	1.5	0.3	52.5
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	0.8	0.7	0.8	3.8	38.3	1.2	6.2	0.5	47.7
Total	23.6	1.6	2.4	8.8	27.7	5.4	5.3	0.9	24.3

In terms of income distribution, as presented in Table 4.2, majority of households across most states have low annual incomes, with 51% earning less than Rs. 50,000 and another 32.5% earning between Rs. 50,000-1,00,000.

States like Bihar (80.5%) and Uttar Pradesh (74.5%) have the highest proportion of very low-income households. A different trend is observed in Jammu & Kashmir, where over 92% of households earn between Rs. 1,00,000- 3,00,000. Overall, **these figures highlight substantial income disparities across states, indicating the critical role of social assistance for low-income households.** The state-wise income distribution of the households has been presented in Table 4.2.

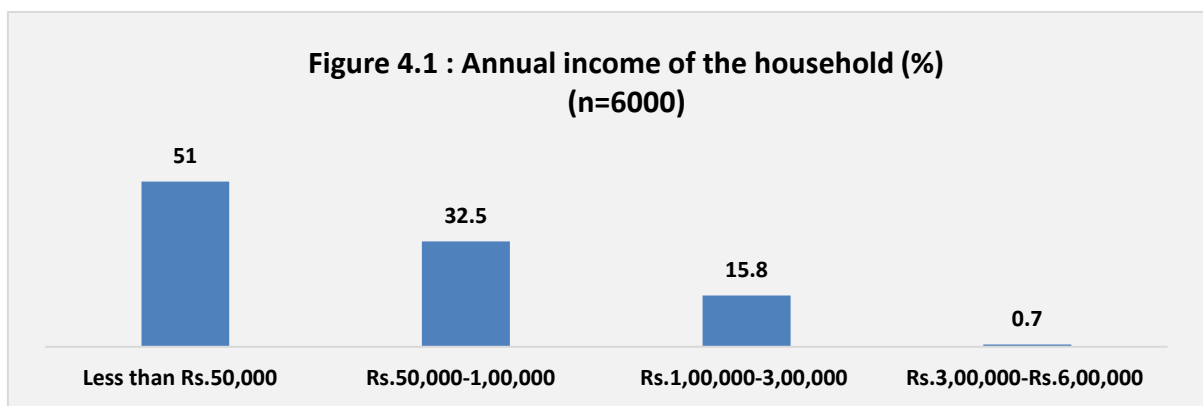


Table 4.2: Annual income of the household (%) (n=6000)				
State	Less than Rs.50,000	Rs.50,000-1,00,000	Rs.1,00,000-3,00,000	Rs.3,00,000-Rs.6,00,000
Bihar (n=600)	80.5	19.0	0.5	0.0
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	41.0	54.8	4.0	0.2
Gujarat (n=600)	67.7	25.0	7.0	0.3
Haryana (n=600)	53.5	45.7	0.8	0.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.0	3.0	92.3	4.7
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	74.5	25.2	0.3	0.0
Assam (n=600)	21.3	37.0	40.5	1.2
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	54.0	41.5	4.3	0.2
Telangana (n=600)	59.5	37.3	3.2	0.0
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	57.7	36.7	5.3	0.3

Further, region-wise analysis showed that while urban households have a slightly higher share in the ₹50,000-1,00,000 range, rural households show greater variation, possibly due to agricultural or informal sources of income. Scheme-wise, all the beneficiaries are concentrated in the lowest income categories, which aligns with their focus on economically weaker sections.

Table 4.3: Region-wise annual income of the household (In Rs.)					
		Less than Rs.50,000	Rs.50,000-1,00,000	Rs.1,00,000-3,00,000	Rs.3,00,000-Rs.6,00,000
Region	Urban	54	44	2	0
	Rural	51	31	17	1
Scheme	IGNOAPS	50	29	20	1
	IGNWPS	53	34	14	0
	IGNDPS	52	40	8	0
	NFBS	54	43	3	0

4.1.2 Spending and Savings

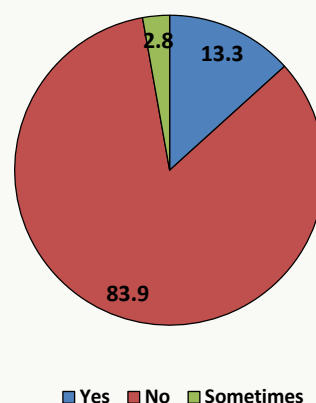
Across all NSAP schemes, the pension amount is mostly spent on essential needs such as food, medical care, and household expenses, though the proportions vary slightly by scheme. **Beneficiaries under IGNOAPS, IGNWPS, and IGNDPS spend primarily on food and medical care (81-85%),** underscoring the role of pensions in meeting basic survival and health needs. **Education-related spending is comparatively low for old age, widow and disability pensioners but significantly higher for NFBS beneficiaries, suggesting that households may use the lump-sum**

benefit to support children's schooling.

Expenditure on social occasions and loan repayments remains relatively low overall, though NFBS beneficiaries report slightly higher spending in these categories. This suggests that the **one-time assistance under NFBS helps families meet both immediate consumptions needs and broader household responsibilities, particularly for families with dependents.** Overall, the pattern shows that pensions are crucial for basic consumption, health, and household needs, with limited scope for discretionary spending or long-term investments. Further,

the gender-wise analysis revealed that spending patterns were largely similar for both men and women across categories such as food, education, and other household expenses. **The only significant variation was observed in medical care, where male beneficiaries reported higher spending than female beneficiaries.**

Figure 4.2 : Savings from the pension amount (%) (n=6000)



The data revealed that very few beneficiaries (969 out of 6000) were able to save from their pension amount. Overall, only 13.3% of beneficiaries reported being able to save any portion of their pension, while a vast majority (83.9%) said they could not. Savings were almost negligible in states like Bihar, Haryana, and Tamil Nadu, where 99% of respondents reported no savings. In contrast, beneficiaries were able to manage small savings in Gujarat (77%) and Andhra Pradesh (20%).

Table 4.4: Savings from the pension amount (n=6000) (%)

State	Yes	No	Sometimes
Bihar (n=600)	0.5	99.3	0.2
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	9.3	88.2	2.5
Gujarat (n=600)	77.0	11.3	11.7
Haryana (n=600)	0.3	99.5	0.2
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	3.3	96.7	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	3.2	96.7	0.2
Assam (n=600)	10.0	84.2	5.8
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	20.0	74.3	5.7
Telangana (n=600)	9.0	89.2	1.8
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	0.5	99.2	0.3

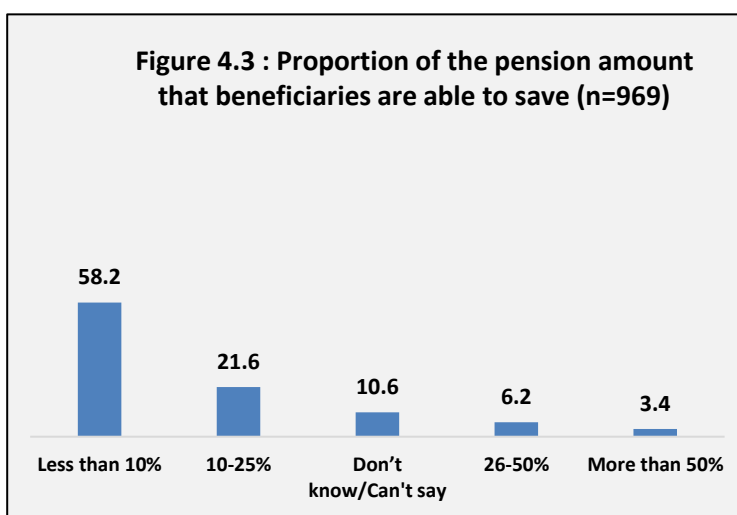
Region-wise analysis highlighted that rural beneficiaries (14%) were slightly more likely to save than urban ones (6%), possibly due to lower living expenses or a greater tendency to prioritize savings in rural settings. Among the schemes, the Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS) recorded the highest proportion of savers (15%), while the National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS), being a one-time assistance, showed the lowest (9%). This indicates that the benefit amounts are primarily used for meeting essential needs rather than generating savings.

Table 4.5: Region and scheme-wise savings from the scheme				
		Yes	No	Sometimes
Region	Urban	6	93	1
	Rural	14	83	3
Scheme	Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)	13	84	3
	Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS)	15	82	3
	Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS)	12	85	3
	National Family Benefit Scheme	9	89	2

Figure 4.3 further revealed that among those who save, 58.2% manage to save less than 10% of the pension amount, highlighting how limited the financial cushioning is for most beneficiaries. Only 3.4% of beneficiaries said that they could save more than 50%.

Overall, the data highlights the financial vulnerability of NSAP beneficiaries and explains the

limited capacity to save from the pension amount. The results underscore the need for enhancing pension amounts and introducing complementary livelihood or financial inclusion measures to strengthen the economic security and resilience of the target population.



4.1.3 Adequacy of the Pension Amount

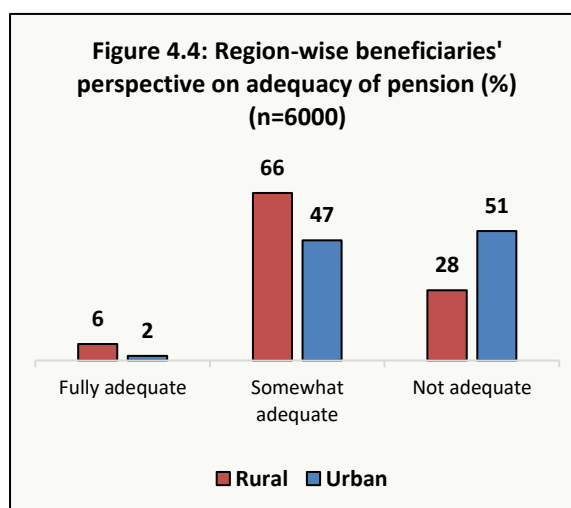
As presented in Table 4.7, the pension amount was largely seen as insufficient to meet beneficiaries' needs. Across all states, only 6.1% of respondents consider the pension fully adequate, while nearly

30% find it not adequate at all. Most beneficiaries (64.3%) feel it is only somewhat adequate, indicating that the assistance provides partial but not full support for daily expenses.

Tamil Nadu (67.5%) and Assam (41.2%) have the highest proportion of respondents who find the pension amount inadequate, likely due to the comparatively lower financial assistance provided in these states. In contrast, **Andhra Pradesh stands out positively, with 27.3% of beneficiaries reporting the pension amount as fully adequate. This can be attributed to the state's substantial top-up over the central share and its efficient last-mile cash disbursement system, which ensures timely and reliable delivery of benefits.**

Table 4.6: Adequacy of the pension amount to support the beneficiaries' needs (n=6000)			
State	Fully adequate	Somewhat adequate	Not adequate
Bihar (n=600)	2.7	74.0	23.3
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	7.3	62.2	30.5
Gujarat (n=600)	7.7	58.7	33.7
Haryana (n=600)	2.8	70.3	26.8
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.2	99.7	0.2
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	7.0	71.8	21.2
Assam (n=600)	1.8	57.0	41.2
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	27.3	59.0	13.7
Telangana (n=600)	2.3	59.3	38.3
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	1.3	31.2	67.5
Total	6.1	64.3	29.6

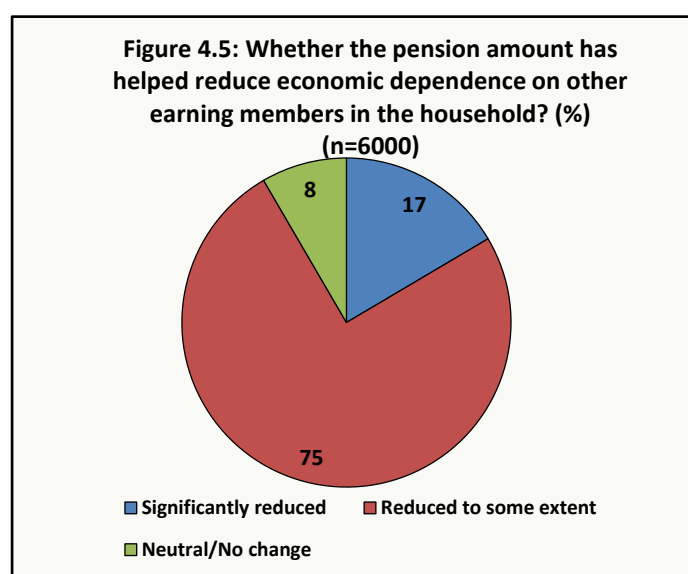
Perceptions regarding pension adequacy vary sharply between regions. In rural areas, 66 percent considered the pension somewhat adequate, and 6 percent found it fully adequate, indicating relatively higher satisfaction. Conversely, in urban areas, 51 percent found the pension not adequate, while only 2 percent considered it fully adequate. **This disparity reflects the influence of higher living costs in urban areas, making the fixed pension amount insufficient to meet basic expenses.** While pensions provide partial support, their real value and adequacy remain limited, especially in urban contexts.



Further, scheme-wise analysis revealed that across all NSAP components, a majority of beneficiaries consider the assistance only partially adequate, while a substantial proportion find it not adequate, indicating concerns regarding the sufficiency of current benefit levels. Under IGNOAPS, only 5.4% of beneficiaries find the pension fully adequate, reflecting the limitations of the existing pension amount in meeting elderly individuals' recurring needs. For IGNDPS, although 7.4% beneficiaries report full adequacy, the highest among the monthly pension schemes; 32.7% still find the support inadequate, indicating the heightened and recurring expenditure needs faced by persons with disabilities. In the case of NFBS, despite being a one-time lump-sum assistance, 37.5% of households consider the amount inadequate to cope with the financial shock of the breadwinner's death.

Table 4.6a: Scheme-wise adequacy from the scheme (n=6000) (%)				
		Fully adequate	Somewhat adequate	Not adequate
Scheme	Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)	5.4	66.2	28.4
	Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS)	6.4	64.0	29.6
	Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS)	7.4	60.0	32.7
	National Family Benefit Scheme	7.4	55.1	37.5

NSAP schemes has played an important role in reducing economic dependence among beneficiaries. About 75.1% of respondents reported that the pension has reduced their dependence on other earning members to some extent, while 16.5% said it has significantly reduced their dependence. The findings indicate that even modest financial support under NSAP contributes meaningfully to beneficiaries' financial autonomy and household stability.



4.2 Perceived Impact of the Scheme

4.2.1 Satisfaction with Overall Process

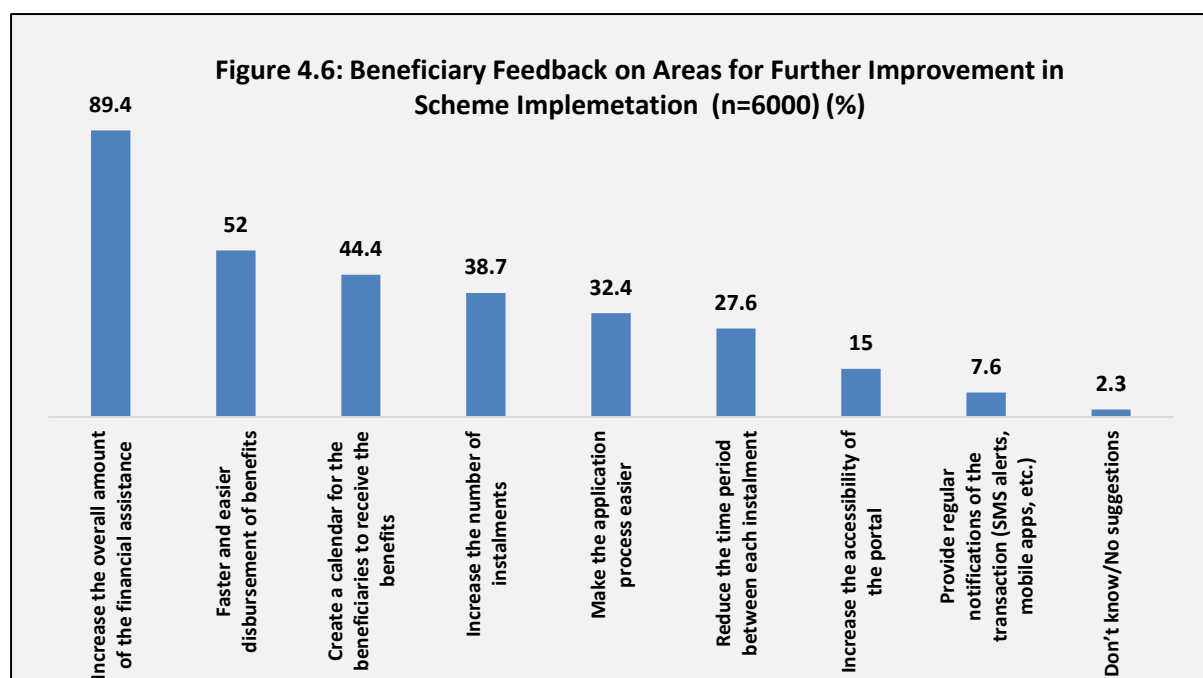
The majority of beneficiaries surveyed (73.2%) were satisfied with the overall process of the pension scheme.

Table 4.7: Satisfaction with the overall process (selection, sanction and disbursement) of the pension scheme (n=6000) (%)			
State	Satisfied	Neutral	Dissatisfied
Bihar (n=600)	97.0	2.8	0.2
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	66.8	20.3	12.8
Gujarat (n=600)	32.7	27.7	39.7
Haryana (n=600)	96.7	3.3	0.0
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	96.5	3.5	0.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	96.7	2.5	0.8
Assam (n=600)	13.3	72.2	14.5
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	83.8	15.3	0.8
Telangana (n=600)	90.3	9.0	0.7
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	57.8	39.2	3.0
Total	73.2	19.6	7.2

Across all four schemes, beneficiary feedback indicates high levels of satisfaction with the savings or financial relief that the assistance provides. Satisfaction is highest under the National Family Benefit Scheme (77.9%), suggesting that the one-time lump-sum assistance might offer immediate and substantial support during a period of distress, thereby leading to higher satisfaction. The Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (75.5%) also records strong satisfaction, reflecting the critical role of regular assistance for persons with disabilities. While the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (72.9%) and the Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (71.8%) show slightly lower levels of satisfaction, dissatisfaction remains low across all schemes. Overall, the data suggests that **despite modest benefit amounts, NSAP schemes continue to provide meaningful financial support to vulnerable households.**

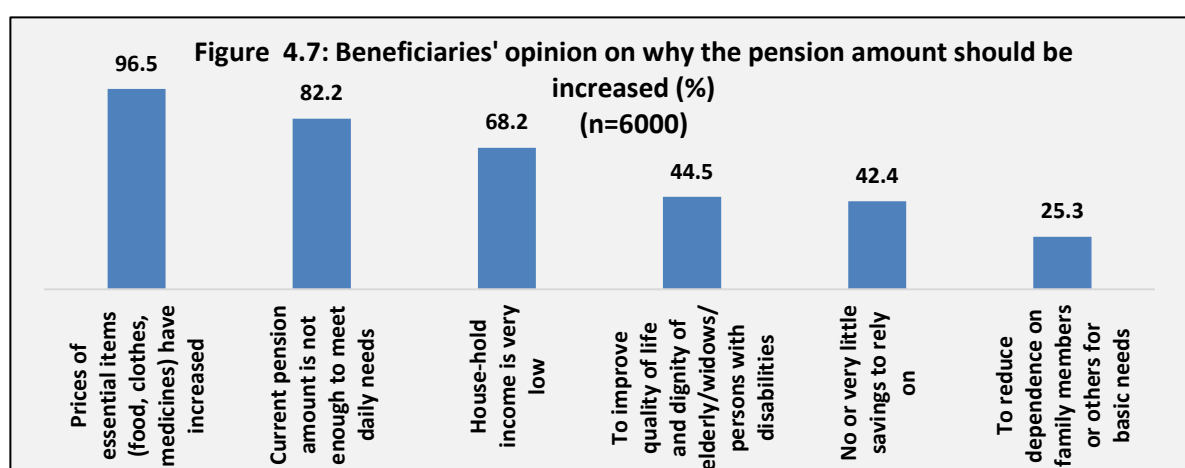
Table 4.7a: Scheme-wise satisfaction from the scheme (n=6000) (%)				
		Satisfied	Neutral	Dissatisfied
Scheme	Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)	72.9	19.0	8.1
	Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS)	71.8	22.3	5.9
	Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS)	75.5	18.0	6.5
	National Family Benefit Scheme	77.9	14.7	7.4

However, 89% of the beneficiaries believed that the government should contribute more funds to increase the pension amount and improve related services. Furthermore, to tackle delayed pension disbursement, 44.4% beneficiary respondents believed that there should be a calendar for them to receive the benefits. 52% were of the opinion that the pension disbursements should be faster and easier.



Note: This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%

Nearly all beneficiaries expressed that the pension amount should be increased. A vast majority (96.5%) highlighted rising prices of essential items, and 82.2% noted that the current pension is insufficient to meet daily needs. Many beneficiaries cited low household income (68.2%) and minimal or no savings (42.4%) as additional reasons. Around 44.5% believed higher pensions would improve their quality of life and dignity, while 25.3% felt it would reduce their dependence on others. Overall, beneficiaries emphasized that pension amounts should be adjusted in proportion to the inflation.



Note: This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%

Table 4.8: State-wise Beneficiaries' opinion on why the pension amount should be increased (n=6000) (%) ¹²						
State	Prices of essential items (food, clothes, medicines) have increased	Current pension amount is not enough to meet daily needs	Household income is very low	No or very little savings to rely on	To improve quality of life and dignity of elderly/widows /persons with disabilities	To reduce dependence on family members or others for basic needs
Bihar (n=600)	99.5	94.8	80.8	57.0	52.6	32.3
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	93.1	87.5	58.4	51.7	80.1	36.9
Gujarat (n=600)	91.2	80.5	85.2	53.7	41.8	8.5
Haryana (n=600)	99.8	94.6	80.4	54.1	49.7	32.3
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	97.7	69.1	43.5	6.1	8.3	7.4
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	97.2	82.7	74.4	35.6	37.7	17.6
Assam (n=600)	92.6	91.1	83.3	48.9	42.8	24.3
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	97.4	60.0	42.2	30.5	35.7	25.1
Telangana (n=600)	99.7	80.2	58.8	57.9	60.0	45.0
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	95.3	78.0	69.6	18.5	31.2	17.4

4.2.2 Changes or Improvement in Various Aspects

The study captured the beneficiaries' perceptions of how the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) has influenced various aspects of their daily lives including food intake, ability to purchase essential commodities, access to healthcare, mobility, and dependence on borrowing.

Majority of beneficiaries reported positive changes across most indicators. Specifically, 62.9% noted improvements in their intake of food (both quantity and quality), 67.7% observed an increase in their capacity to purchase personal commodities, and 65.2% reported better access to medical care.

However, improvement was relatively lower for mobility in terms of transportation cost (56.3%) and reduction in borrowing needs (51.9%), indicating that **while the pension helps with subsistence, it remains inadequate to significantly reduce financial vulnerability**. Jammu & Kashmir recorded an

¹² Note: This is a multiple response question, i.e., the respondent can select more than one option. Hence, the sum will be more than 100%

exceptionally high proportion of beneficiaries who reported improvement across most dimensions—nearly 99% noted better food intake, purchasing power, and access to medical care. The findings also indicated that **NSAP has improved basic welfare conditions for a majority of beneficiaries, especially in southern states.**

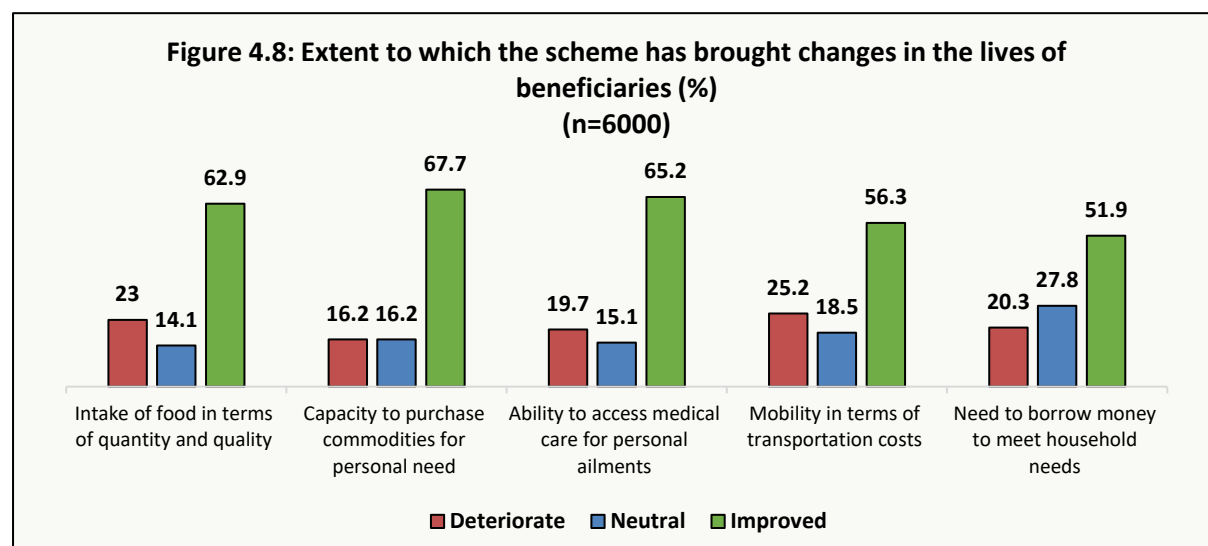


Table 4.9: State-wise extent to which the scheme has brought changes in the lives of the beneficiaries (n=6000)

State	Intake of food in terms of quantity and quality (%)			Capacity to purchase commodities for personal need (%)			Ability to access medical care for personal ailments (%)			Mobility in terms of transportation costs (%)			Need to borrow money to meet household needs (%)		
	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved
Bihar (n=600)	38.8	0.3	60.8	23.3	0.8	75.8	34.7	1	64.3	23.2	1.0	75.8	27.2	0.7	72.2
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	42.3	9.0	48.7	27.5	21.0	51.5	34.3	14.8	50.8	33.5	17.8	48.7	34.8	16.0	49.2
Gujarat (n=600)	19.8	34.2	46.0	14.2	21.5	64.3	15.2	28	56.8	14.3	25.3	60.3	13.8	26.0	60.2
Haryana (n=600)	44.2	0.8	55.0	30.8	2.7	66.5	37.7	1.7	60.7	29.2	1.2	69.7	30.0	1.3	68.7
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.5	0.2	99.3	0.5	0.0	99.5	0.3	0.3	99.3	90.2	0.7	9.2	1.2	94.3	4.5
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	60.3	1.3	38.3	43.2	2.8	54.0	47.7	1.7	50.7	44.2	3.5	52.3	45.2	2.7	52.2
Assam (n=600)	3.7	47.8	48.5	5.5	51.2	43.3	4	49.3	46.7	2.5	50.8	46.7	2.7	52.8	44.5

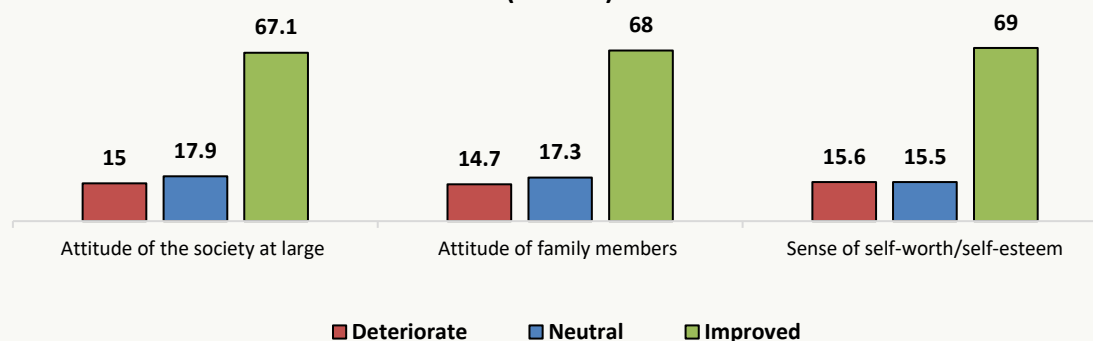
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	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved	Deteriorate	Neutral	Improved
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	8.3	19.2	72.5	5.7	27.5	66.8	4.2	22.3	73.5	6.0	25.7	68.3	28.0	24.2	47.8
Telangana (n=600)	10.0	9.0	81.0	9.5	13.5	77.0	14.5	8.8	76.7	7.7	15.2	77.2	13.5	19.0	67.5
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	2.2	19.0	78.8	1.7	20.7	77.7	4.8	22.8	72.3	1.0	43.8	55.2	6.3	41.0	52.7

The data further revealed that the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) has had a generally positive influence on beneficiaries' social perception and self-worth, with over two-thirds of respondents across states reporting a positive change in the attitude of society, family members, and in their own sense of self-esteem. Overall, about 67-69% of beneficiaries perceived improvement across all three dimensions, suggesting that NSAP not only supports financial stability but also enhances social dignity and self-respect among recipients. In Jammu & Kashmir and Telangana, almost all beneficiaries reported positive changes across all parameters, indicating strong social acceptance and empowerment. In contrast, Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, and Bihar show lower positive perception, reflecting weaker social recognition and lower pension adequacy.



Figure 4.9 : Extent to which the scheme has brought changes in attitude of self and others (%) (n=6000)



Overall, while NSAP appears to have contributed meaningfully to improving social inclusion and individual dignity, the degree of change depends on state-level implementation efficiency and societal attitudes toward beneficiaries.

Table 4.10: Extent to which the scheme has brought changes in attitude of self and others (n=6000)									
State	Attitude of the society at large (%)			Attitude of family members (%)			Sense of self-worth/self-esteem (%)		
	Deteriorate	Natural	Improved	Deteriorate	Natural	Improved	Deteriorate	Natural	Improved
Bihar (n=600)	24.5	2.2	73.3	22.8	1.2	76.0	24.7	0.5	74.8
Chhattisgarh (n=600)	26.0	20.7	53.3	31.8	18.7	49.5	32.2	17.7	50.2
Gujarat (n=600)	12.2	29.5	58.3	11.7	29.3	59.0	11.8	26.3	61.8
Haryana (n=600)	33.5	3.3	63.2	28.3	3.0	68.7	34.0	1.8	64.2
Jammu Kashmir (n=600)	0.0	0.2	99.8	0.0	0.0	100.0	0.0	0.0	100.0
Uttar Pradesh (n=600)	44.8	1.5	53.7	43.8	2.2	54.0	46.2	1.2	52.7
Assam (n=600)	2.5	50.7	46.8	3.0	53.0	44.0	3.5	54.3	42.2
Andhra Pradesh (n=600)	2.5	21.2	76.3	2.2	19.7	78.2	1.2	18.7	80.2
Telangana (n=600)	3.7	11.0	85.3	2.5	11.3	86.2	1.8	10.5	87.7
Tamil Nadu (n=600)	0.3	38.7	61.0	0.8	34.7	64.5	0.7	23.5	75.8

ASSESSMENT OF NSAP THROUGH REESI FRAMEWORK

5.1 Analysis through REESI Frameworks

The preceding chapters examined awareness levels, implementation efficiency, and the socio-economic impact of the NSAP. In the present chapter, an attempt has been made to analyze these findings through the OECD's REESI framework, covering relevance, efficiency, effectiveness, sustainability, and impact. The objective is to assess the extent to which NSAP's design and delivery align with its stated goals and the broader welfare mandate. To avoid duplication, the discussion summarizes key evidence under each dimension in a matrix format.

REESI dimensions	Discussion points	Summary
Relevance	Alignment of NSAP objectives with the constitutional vision of social justice and beneficiary needs; appropriateness of programme design and targeting	The NSAP objectives align with Article 41 (Directive Principles) and the central objective of social protection for the elderly, widows and persons with disabilities. Field evidence showed that NSAP remains relevant to beneficiary needs-pensions act as a primary income source for a substantial share of households in several states (e.g., Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana) and are crucial for livelihood support. Despite its continued relevance, differential state top-ups, variable eligibility criteria and reliance on BPL lists lead to exclusion errors and uneven coverage. States such as Chhattisgarh, Assam, and Bihar reported that beneficiaries not listed in BPL are unable to receive pensions even when meeting eligibility criteria.
Efficiency	Efficiency of delivery mechanisms including fund flow, DBT, and targeting.	The efficiency of NSAP delivery mechanisms varied across states, reflecting differences in institutional capacity and digital infrastructure. The transition to Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) and use of NSAP-PPS has substantially improved fund flow efficiency and transparency, minimizing leakages and ensuring traceable transactions. Almost all the beneficiaries (except in Andhra Pradesh) reported receiving pensions

REESI dimensions	Discussion points	Summary
		directly in their bank or post office accounts, demonstrating high DBT coverage across the programme. However, efficiency gaps persist due to delays in Aadhaar seeding, incomplete KYC, biometric failures and long travel distances to access financial institutions, particularly in states such as Jammu & Kashmir and Gujarat. The indirect costs are borne by beneficiaries in terms of time, travel, and dependence on intermediaries. States that have adopted door-to-door disbursement models through postmen or business correspondents show better last-mile delivery efficiency and inclusion outcomes. Overall, about 73% of beneficiaries expressed satisfaction with the processes related to selection, sanction, and disbursement, suggesting that while the system functions efficiently in most areas, targeted improvements in last-mile accessibility and digital inclusion are essential to enhance overall delivery effectiveness.
Effectiveness	Extent to which DBT, grievance redressal, social audit, and Gram Sabha strengthen service delivery	Program elements such as Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), grievance redressal, and social audit mechanisms demonstrate mixed levels of effectiveness across states. The introduction of DBT has significantly reduced leakages and improved payment timeliness in areas with robust Aadhaar seeding and bank linkages. However, biometric authentication failures, particularly among the elderly and persons with disabilities, and informal commissions by intermediaries, in states like Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, continue to undermine the integrity and effectiveness of implementation mechanisms. Grievance redressal and social audit systems, though institutionally present, show variation in coverage, periodicity, and enforcement. Where implemented effectively, they have strengthened transparency and accountability as evidenced by the high incidence of social audits in Assam (86.7%) and Uttar Pradesh (80%). Across states, Gram Sabha meetings remain the primary forum for community-level grievance redressal, reflecting a degree of participatory oversight in service delivery.

REESI dimensions	Discussion points	Summary
		Overall, the scheme has been effective in providing a basic social safety net to vulnerable populations. Over 60% beneficiaries indicated improvements in their food intake, access to medical care, and financial security.
Sustainability	Long-term viability of programme outcomes considering pension adequacy and fiscal commitment	The long-term sustainability of NSAP outcomes is influenced by both fiscal and operational factors. The central pension contribution has remained stagnant for over a decade, resulting in increasing dependence on state-funded top-ups to maintain adequacy. States such as Andhra Pradesh and Haryana contribute significantly above the central component, while low-income states like Bihar and Assam have limited fiscal capacity to provide similar support. This has created inter-state disparities in pension adequacy and increased fiscal pressure on state budgets. The present study highlights that pensions serve as the primary source of income for 23% of beneficiary households, yet only 13.3% reported being able to save a portion of their pension, underscoring limited long-term financial resilience. Inadequate pension amounts constrain the potential for sustained welfare improvement. Ensuring sustainability will require periodic upward revision of pension amounts, greater shared fiscal commitment between Centre and States, and integration with broader social protection frameworks to balance adequacy with affordability. In this context, it is worth highlighting that the NSAP Task Force constituted by MoRD in 2012 recommended that “An advisory should be issued to the states to ensure that eligible beneficiaries are covered under NSAP with due augmentation of at least an equivalent amount from states.” (p. 13)¹³ This indicates the recognition that long-term sustainability requires a more balanced fiscal partnership between the Centre and the states, rather than uneven state-driven top-ups. A predictable co-financing framework would reduce inter-state disparities, strengthen adequacy, and support the constitutional intent of providing meaningful public assistance to the vulnerable.

¹³ MoRD. (2013). *Proposal for comprehensive national social assistance programme: Report of the task force*. https://nsap.nic.in/nsap/Report_Task_Force_Comprehensive_NSAP.pdf

REESI dimensions	Discussion points	Summary
Impact	Changes in livelihood, spending, satisfaction, and perceived well-being among beneficiaries.	The impact assessment study indicates that NSAP has been instrumental in enhancing social inclusion, dignity, and basic income security among vulnerable households. The pension serves as the primary source of income for a significant proportion of beneficiaries, particularly in Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana, where state top-ups are higher. More than 80% of beneficiaries reported spending their pension on food and medical care, demonstrating the programme's role in supporting essential consumption and health needs. Overall, the scheme has led to improved well-being and satisfaction among recipients. Over 60% reported an improved quality of life, and 67% acknowledged greater respect and recognition within their families and communities after receiving pensions. However, the limited pension amount constrains broader outcomes on poverty reduction or long-term livelihood improvement. The scheme's impact is positive but also protective rather than transformative. It offers essential support but not sustained income security.

5.2 Gaps in Achievement of Outcomes

While the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) continues to play a crucial role in providing basic social security, several gaps remain in achieving its intended outcomes of ensuring income security, dignity, and inclusion for the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities.

- **Inadequate Pension Amounts:**

The outcome of improved livelihood security has been only partially achieved due to the low central pension contribution (Rs.200-Rs.500 per month), which has not been revised since 2012. Beneficiary surveys revealed that only 6% of respondents considered the pension amount fully adequate, while the majority found it insufficient to meet essential needs such as food and medical expenses. Nearly 90% of beneficiaries expressed that the financial assistance should be increased. Several respondents expressed a demand for an increase in the monthly assistance to at least Rs.3,000 to maintain a minimum standard of living.

- **Exclusion Errors in Beneficiary Identification:**

The continued reliance on outdated BPL lists has resulted in the exclusion of many deserving elderly persons, widows, and persons with disabilities, particularly in Chhattisgarh, Assam, and Bihar. Field

findings also indicated that households without BPL cards or Aadhaar-linked bank accounts are often left out of the scheme, thereby undermining its inclusiveness and intended coverage.

- **Irregular Payments and Accessibility Challenges:**

Although the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system has improved the timeliness and transparency of pension disbursements in several states, operational challenges persist due to delays in KYC completion, biometric authentication failures, and poor connectivity in certain areas. As a result, many elderly and differently-abled beneficiaries are compelled to spend long hours at banks or post offices, or to depend on intermediaries for withdrawing their pension amounts, increasing both inconvenience and transaction costs.

- **Weak Grievance Redressal and Social Audit Mechanisms:**

Grievance redressal mechanisms under NSAP are not uniformly operational across states. In several states, beneficiaries were unaware of any formal platform to report issues such as non-receipt or underpayment of pensions. Although social audits are mandated in the guidelines, they were found to be infrequent and irregular in practice.

Overall, while NSAP has achieved near-universal Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) coverage and broad awareness, its intended outcomes of sustained income and social security remain limited due to low pension adequacy, coverage gaps, and inconsistencies in last-mile service delivery.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

6.1 CONCLUSION

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) is a key social welfare scheme of the Government of India that provides basic financial support to vulnerable groups such as the elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities. The evaluation study conducted across the ten states of Assam, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Haryana, Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, Tamil Nadu, and Chhattisgarh revealed that the scheme has made significant progress in ensuring social inclusion and promoting a sense of dignity among its beneficiaries.

The Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) mechanism of disbursement of pension has enhanced transparency, minimized leakages, and improved accountability in fund flow. In several states, the system functions smoothly, with timely crediting of pension amounts and high levels of satisfaction among beneficiaries. However, the study also highlighted persistent gaps in awareness, coverage, and efficiency. Beneficiary awareness of scheme provisions, eligibility criteria, and responsible departments remains uneven across states. In many cases, beneficiaries are unaware of whether the funds are contributed by the central or state government. The identification process also varies across states. While some states adopt community-driven approaches of identification through Gram Sabha or panchayat officials, others apply themselves or rely on official verification, sometimes leading to inconsistencies in beneficiary inclusion and exclusion.

The evaluation study revealed variations in the ease of accessing benefits. While DBT has been widely implemented, a substantial proportion of beneficiaries, particularly in remote, or inaccessible areas, still face challenges such as long travel distances to banks, biometric failures, and delayed credits. States like Andhra Pradesh, which have adopted door-to-door or village-level disbursement systems, demonstrate better accessibility and beneficiary satisfaction. The adequacy of financial assistance under NSAP is another concern raised consistently during field interactions. Although the pension provides critical support, the current amount is insufficient to meet even the basic needs of beneficiaries, especially considering inflation and rising healthcare costs. Several states provide a top up over the central share with their own funds, but the level of enhancement differs widely, leading to disparities in the level of support provided across states.

The study also found that social audits and grievance redressal mechanisms, though present in the guidelines, are inconsistently implemented. Many local officials either lack awareness of the process or the capacity to conduct regular audits. Despite these challenges, NSAP has contributed meaningfully to the social and economic stability of vulnerable households. Beneficiaries reported that pensions help them manage essential household expenses, purchase medicines, and reduce dependence on others, thereby improving their sense of dignity and autonomy. The scheme, therefore, continues to play a crucial role in reducing vulnerability to income and health shocks, especially for the elderly, widowed, and disabled populations.

6.2 CHALLENGES

While the scheme has provided critical support to vulnerable populations, systemic and operational issues persist at various stages from beneficiary identification to disbursement and grievance resolution. Some of the key challenges identified during the survey have been presented below:

1. Identification and Exclusion Errors

The requirement of being listed in the Below Poverty Line (BPL) database for eligibility continues to exclude many deserving individuals. In Chhattisgarh, Assam, and Bihar, respondents mentioned that several elderly, widowed, or disabled persons were denied pensions because their names were missing from the outdated BPL lists or due to lack of required documentation such as Aadhaar, caste, or medical certificates. In Uttar Pradesh, field observations indicated irregularities at the beneficiary identification level, where Gram Panchayats play a key role in issuing income certificates. Instances of inclusion of ineligible beneficiaries and exclusion of deserving ones were reported, pointing to the need for stronger oversight and data verification mechanisms.

2. Documentation and Administrative Delays

In Jammu & Kashmir and Bihar, the process of submitting and verifying supporting documents (e.g., Date of Birth, Disability Certificates, and Income Certificates) often leads to long delays. Frequent internet disruptions and limited digital capacity at local offices further slowdown application updates on the online portal. Beneficiaries are required to make repeated visits to government offices, incurring travel costs and time.

3. Bank and Disbursement-Related Challenges

In several states, KYC related issues have caused interruptions in pension payments. In Gujarat and Chhattisgarh, beneficiaries reported that pension disbursements were stopped if their bank KYC was incomplete, and they were not adequately informed about the process or timeline for rectification. In rural and hilly areas of Chhattisgarh and Jammu & Kashmir, the distance to the nearest bank branch was cited as a significant hardship, especially for elderly women who had to pay for transportation or rely on others to collect the pension. In Assam and Telangana, disbursement delays were reported due to irregular fund flow and technical issues in Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) systems, including Aadhaar-

linking errors, inactive bank accounts, and poor internet connectivity in remote areas.

4. Challenges in Biometric Authentication and Disbursement Agents

In Tamil Nadu, beneficiaries particularly the elderly and persons with disabilities face difficulties during biometric authentication due to worn fingerprints or health conditions. Many spend several hours at banks, post offices, or Customer Service Centres (CSCs) to successfully withdraw their pension. Reports also indicate that in some cases, disbursing agents such as postmen or CSC operators deduct small commissions or service charges (ranging from ₹10 to ₹30 per transaction), and in few instances, partial or full withdrawal of pension without beneficiary consent was reported.

5. Lack of Awareness and Information Gaps

In Assam and Bihar, awareness about eligibility criteria, documentation requirements, and scheme procedures remains limited. Beneficiaries often rely on informal information channels and are unaware of grievance redressal mechanisms. This lack of formal awareness and outreach has resulted in low participation among the most vulnerable sections of the population.

6.3 LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

Certain limitations were encountered while conducting the study:

➤ **Difficulty in Collecting Responses from Very Elderly Beneficiaries:**

It was challenging to collect detailed responses from beneficiaries aged 80 years and above, particularly under the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS). Many respondents had difficulty recalling specific details related to scheme implementation, payment frequency, or grievance redressal. To ensure accuracy, assistance from family members or caregivers was sought during interviews.

➤ **Caste Representation and Sampling Gaps:**

Although efforts were made to maintain the caste-wise quota as per the planned sample, achieving the desired distribution was difficult. In several Gram Panchayats, one or more caste categories were entirely absent, especially in smaller or homogeneous villages. The team attempted to compensate for these gaps by covering the missing caste groups at the district or state level, but it was not always possible to meet the pre-decided quota exactly as designed.

➤ **Limited Awareness and Identification of NFBS Beneficiaries:**

Identifying beneficiaries under the National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS) proved particularly difficult due to low awareness and limited record maintenance at the local level. In many cases, Gram Panchayat and ward officials were consulted to help locate NFBS households; however, even local authorities were sometimes unaware of existing beneficiaries. This

indicates a broader issue of low visibility and awareness of the NFBS component among both communities and local functionaries.

➤ **Reliance on Local Officials and Family Assistance:**

In certain cases, field investigators had to depend on support from Panchayat representatives or family members to locate and verify beneficiaries, especially in remote or scattered habitations.

6.4 RECOMMENDATIONS

Presented hereunder are some recommendations which can help eliminate systemic barriers and further strengthen the scheme implementation process:

6.4.1 Justification and Recommendation for Continuation of the Scheme

Introducing a Minimum Floor-level Pension

The Government of India introduced NSAP in 1995. In 2012, the monthly pension amount was revised to Rs. 200 for old age people between 60 and 79 years of age, to Rs. 300 for widows (40-79 years) and persons with disability (18-79 years), and Rs. 500 for beneficiaries of 80 years of age and above. Since then, there has been no upward revision in this amount although consumption expenditure has grown substantially over the years and in the context of India making rapid strides on economic front and recently becoming the 4th largest economy of the world. In this background, an attempt has been made in the present section to develop an argument for revising the floor level of social assistant benefits under NSAP to restore their adequacy, coverage and constitutional relevance.

It is therefore recommended to **introduce a National Floor Pension (NFP)** amount, similar to the National Floor Level Minimum Wage set by the Ministry of Labour and Employment. This would ensure a minimum level of financial assistance uniformly across all states. The **NFP should be linked to the Consumer Price Index (CPI) to automatically adjust with inflation**, with annual revisions based on the cost of living. Additionally, states should be encouraged to provide top-ups to the central share in a uniform and transparent manner to reduce regional disparities in benefit levels.

6.4.2 Rationale for Increasing the Floor Price of NSAP

1. Inflation and adequacy

Considering 2012 as the base with Consumer Price Index (CPI) at 100, it rose to 191 in 2024, reflecting a 91% cumulative increase (Table 1). Based on this increase the pension amount should have proportionately raised from Rs. 200 and Rs. 500 to Rs. 382 and Rs. 955 respectively. Similarly based on CPI, for the NFBS component under NSAP, the assistance amount of ₹20,000 should have increased to Rs. 38,200, which, if rounded, would approximate Rs. 40,000.

Further, average inflation of about 5% annually (2010-2024) has significantly eroded the real value of fixed cash transfers. The central pension component of ₹200-₹500 per month has remained unchanged since 2012. Adjusted with the current CPI, the value of ₹200 would now need to be ₹353 merely to preserve its earlier purchasing power. Thus, in effect, the real benefit has fallen by nearly 45%. In this context, the NSAP Task Force, constituted by the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD), Government of India, in 2013 argued that “Rates of assistance should be indexed to inflation annually using the criteria adopted for payment of Dearness Allowance to Central Government employees”. (p. 8)¹⁴

Year	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	Annual Average
2013	104.6	105.3	105.5	106.1	106.9	109.3	111	112.4	113.7	114.8	116.3	114.5	110
2014	113.6	113.6	114.2	115.1	115.8	116.7	119.2	120.3	120.1	120.1	120.1	119.4	117
2015	119.5	119.7	120.2	120.7	121.6	123	123.6	124.8	125.4	126.1	126.6	126.1	123
2016	126	126	126	127.3	128.5	130.1	131.1	131.1	131.4	131.2	132.1	130.4	129
2017	130.3	130.9	130.9	131.1	131.4	132	134.2	135.4	135.2	136.1	137.1	137.2	133
2018	136.9	136.4	136.5	137.1	137.8	138.5	139.8	140.4	140.2	140.7	140.7	140.1	139
2019	139.6	139.9	140.4	141.2	142	142.9	144.2	145	145	147.2	148.6	150.4	144
2020	150.2	149.1	148.6	151.4	150.9	151.8	153.9	154.7	156.4	158.4	158.9	157.3	153
2021	156.3	156.6	156.8	157.8	160.4	161.3	162.5	162.9	162.9	165.5	166.7	166.7	161
2022	165.7	166.1	167.7	170.1	171.7	172.6	173.4	174.3	175.3	176.7	176.5	175.7	172
2023	176.5	176.8	177.2	178.1	179.1	181	186.3	182.6	184.1	185.3	186.3	186.3	182
2024	185.5	185.8	185.8	186.7	187.7	190.2	193	193	194.2	196.8	196.5	195.4	191

Source: https://www.mospi.gov.in/sites/default/files/press_release/CPI_PR_13Jan25.pdf

2. Adequacy benchmarking using MPCE and poverty level

As per the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES), 2023-24¹⁵ without considering the values of items received free of cost by households through various social welfare programmes the average monthly per capita consumption expenditure (MPCE) for rural India is Rs. 4122 and Rs. 6996 for urban India. Excluding the share of non-food items (rural India – 53% and urban India -60%) the monthly per capita food expenditure will be approximately Rs. 1900 for rural India and Rs. 2800 for urban India. Thus, considering the MCPE calculation for only food items the floor price of Rs. 2000 for pensioners will be just.

This estimate is also consistent with adequacy benchmarks derived from the Tendulkar Committee poverty line. While examining pension adequacy in 2013, the NSAP Task Force argued that a minimum level of purchasing power was essential for elderly persons and based on the Tendulkar Committee

¹⁴ MoRD. (2013). *Proposal for comprehensive national social assistance programme: Report of the task force.*

https://nsap.nic.in/nsap/Report_Task_Force_Comprehensive_NSAP.pdf

¹⁵ <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2088390&utm>

poverty line recommendations, recommended a monthly pension of Rs. 950 for the aged poor.¹⁶ When adjusted for inflation using CPI, this amount would translate to approximately Rs. 1650 per capita per month in current prices¹⁷, reinforcing the case for a substantially higher pension floor than presently available under NSAP.

In this context, the present NSAP pension levels no longer meet even minimal consumption needs. The elderly, widowed, and disabled, who face high dependency ratios and healthcare costs, remain vulnerable to destitution. Therefore, maintaining current benefit levels amounts to symbolic assistance rather than real social protection.

3. Bringing a parity with minimum wage

The NSAP Task Force, in its detailed recommendations, observed that “It is a national obligation to provide social security to the poor” and emphasized that the pension amount should be “based on a norm which has to be linked to the minimum wage...” (p. 12)¹⁸ This reflects an institutional acknowledgement that pension adequacy must correspond to broader labour market benchmarks rather than remain a nominal transfer.

This perspective aligns with wider policy thinking outside government as well. The Pension Parishad, a network of civil society organizations, has been advocating for an adequate universal rights-based pension to the tune of half the minimum wage. In 2012 this demand was translated to a minimum monthly pension of Rs. 2000 and considering the price rise since then in 2018 it translated into Rs. 3000.¹⁹

Taken together, both the official Task Force view and civil society advocacy point to a shared recognition that a meaningful pension floor should bear a clear relationship to minimum wage standards to ensure dignity and subsistence for elderly and other vulnerable populations.

4. Bringing a parity among states

Currently, the pension amount varies widely among states. The stagnation of central share has forced states to top-up substantially, resulting in wide inter-state disparities (Rs. 200-300 in some low-income states vs. Rs. 2,000-Rs. 3,000 in fiscally stronger ones, as observed from state per capita GSDP levels). To reduce this disparity, raising the floor price to Rs.2,000 following MPCE calculation may be considered.

¹⁶ MoRD. (2013). *Proposal for comprehensive national social assistance programme: Report of the task force.* https://nsap.nic.in/nsap/Report_Task_Force_Comprehensive_NSAP.pdf

¹⁷ Considering that the NSAP Task Force recommended a pension amount of Rs. 950 in 2013, and that the CPI increased from 110 in 2013 to 191 in 2024, the inflation-adjusted equivalent of Rs. 950 would be approximately Rs. 1650 in 2024 prices.

¹⁸ MoRD. (2013). *Proposal for comprehensive national social assistance programme: Report of the task force.* https://nsap.nic.in/nsap/Report_Task_Force_Comprehensive_NSAP.pdf

¹⁹ Patnaik, P. (2018). The great pension scandal: A laughable pittance of Rs. 200 a month!. *News click*. Accessed at <https://www.newsclick.in/great-pension-scandal-laughable-pittance-rs-200-month>

5. International comparison

A cross-country comparison of old-age social assistance programmes across continents (Table 2) reveals that India's old-age social pension is among the least adequate relative to national income. While India's combined central and state pension averages around ₹1,000 per month, this represents only 11% of GNI per capita, which is quite low among comparable economies. In contrast, Nepal (28.2%), despite having lower income levels, provide higher relative benefits, reflecting stronger policy commitment to social protection. Countries with better-developed social security systems such as Brazil (30.2%), South Africa (18.3%) and Mexico (15.9%) offer higher, inflation-indexed benefits that ensure income security and dignity in old age.

Aligning India's pension with GNI per capita would bring it closer to global norms and ensure meaningful income support for the elderly.

Country	Type of pension	Local benefit (approx.)	Rupee equivalent (approx)	Age/eligibility	Gni per capita (2023)	Pension as % of gni per capita
BANGLADESH	Means-tested old-age allowance	500 Taka/month	INR 370	► Men: 65 yrs and above ► Women: 62 yrs and above ► Income ≤ 10,000 Taka/year	\$ 2,860	21.7
NEPAL	Universal old-age allowance	4,000 NPR/month	INR 2,496	► Men and Married Women: 68 ys and above ► Unmarried/Widowed Women: 60 yrs and above	\$ 1,400	28.2
VIETNAM	Social pension (assistance)	500,000 Dong/month	INR 1,700	► 60 yrs and above and living alone ► 75 yrs and above	\$ 4,180	5.7
INDIA	Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)	Rs. 200–500/month (Central) + State top-ups	INR 1,200 (Central+ State top-ups)	► 60 yrs and above (BPL households)	\$ 2,540	11.1
SOUTH AFRICA	Older Person's Grant	ZAR 1,990–2,010/month	INR 9,000	► 60 yrs and above	\$ 6,960	18.3
MEXICO	Universal pension	MXN 2,400/month	INR 12,700	► 65 yrs and above	\$ 11,250	15.9

Source: <https://www.issa.int/databases/country-profiles>
World Bank (GNI Per capita); PIB Press notes

6. Findings from the Study

The impact assessment study conducted across the ten states clearly indicated the need to increase the pension amount under NSAP so that it remains adequate and relevant in the current cost-of-living conditions. Most beneficiaries reported that the present amount is insufficient to meet basic needs such as food, healthcare, and daily expenses, leaving them with little financial security. States providing higher top-ups, such as Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Haryana, showed better outcomes in income stability and well-being. Revising the pension amount would therefore help ensure that NSAP continues to uphold its objective of providing dignity, security, and meaningful support to vulnerable citizens.

7. Funding the increase in floor price for social assistance programmes

Figure 6.1 shows budgetary allocation to NSAP has declined from 0.58% of the Union Budget in FY 2014–15 to 0.19% in FY 2025–26, and in nominal terms from Rs. 10,547 crore to Rs. 9,652 crore. Over the same period, India's GDP grew 2.5-fold, from roughly Rs. 97 lakh crore to Rs. 240 lakh crore.

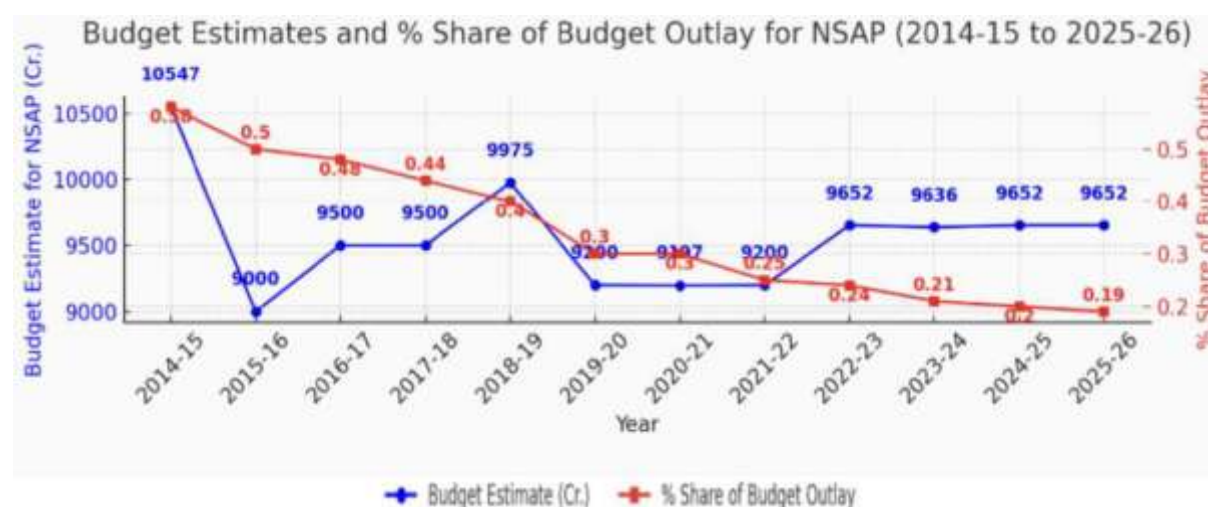


Figure 6.1: Budget Estimates and % Share of Budget Outlay for NSAP (2014-15 TO 2025-26)

Source: Sharma, A. & Pathak, N. (2025). Budget for National Social Assistance Programme remains stagnant yet again. *The Wire*. Accessed at <https://thewire.in/news/budget-for-national-social-assistance-programme-remains-stagnant-yet-again>

Restoring NSAP to its 2014–15 budget share would require Rs. 30,000–Rs. 35,000 crore annually, ample to finance a substantial increase in pension amounts. Even allocating an additional 0.1% of GDP (~Rs. 24,000 crore) would double the current central pension floor without threatening macro-fiscal stability.

To conclude, the universalization of pensions along with an enhanced floor price is both appropriate and necessary. In this context, Patnaik (2018) asserts that “State-funded pension must be a right for every person, and it must be financed by budgetary sources, unrelated to any contribution from the beneficiary”.²⁰

²⁰ Patnaik, P. (2018). The great pension scandal: A laughable pittance of Rs. 200 a month!. *Newsclick*. Accessed at <https://www.newsclick.in/great-pension-scandal-laughable-pittance-rs-200-month>

6.4.3 Recommendation on Reforming NSAP Disability Pension Eligibility

The **Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016** defines a “*person with benchmark disability*” as someone with **not less than 40% disability** certified by a competent authority. This definition applies across legal entitlements, including reservations, concessions, and welfare benefits. Under current guidelines, only individuals with 80% or more disability qualify for the IGNDPS pension. This creates a misalignment between the pension eligibility criteria and the statutory definition of disability in the RPwD Act. The existing 80% threshold inherently excludes many people who face significant functional limitations, economic hardship, and social barriers but have disability percentages between 40% and 79%. Research indicates that this criterion contributes to systematic exclusion of a large portion of the disabled population that otherwise meet legal thresholds for disability recognition.²¹ Recent judicial interventions have criticized arbitrary disability thresholds in policy contexts when they depart from the statutory benchmark of 40%. For example, the Punjab and Haryana High Court held that state policies privileging only higher disability percentages are inconsistent with the RPwD Act’s benchmark definition and discriminatory.²²

Thus, amending the NSAP to align the IGNDPS eligibility with the 40% benchmark disability threshold will reduce exclusion, enhance equity, improve administrative coherence, and uphold legal standards established by the RPwD Act, 2016.

6.4.4 Recommendations on Revision of Beneficiary Cap

The current central beneficiary caps under the National Social Assistance Programme are largely based on population estimates from the early 2010s and do not adequately reflect recent demographic changes, particularly population ageing, increased widowhood, and rising longevity among persons with disabilities. Since the fixation of these caps, India has experienced substantial demographic changes which have direct implications for the potential beneficiary base of NSAP Pension schemes. Sharma and Pathak²³ cite the Economic Survey of India 2024-25 data and argue that there is “gross underestimation of beneficiaries” under NSAP whereby “nearly 6 crore eligible individuals are excluded from the central support”. Static caps undermine the objectives of NSAP as a social protection floor, leading to uneven coverage across states and beneficiary categories. It is worthwhile mentioning here that the NSAP Task Force, constituted by the MoRD in 2013 recommended expansion of beneficiary coverage in a phased manner.²⁴

In this background, an attempt has been made here in the study to project the number of potential beneficiaries under each of the NSAP categories for 2025 and 2030. Applying assumptions regarding economic vulnerability and a 20 per cent poverty rate, the analysis indicates that the number of eligible beneficiaries exceeds the existing central caps by a considerable margin (Table 6.3)-

²¹ Amending NSAP/IGNDPS to align its disability eligibility with the 40% benchmark disability threshold will reduce exclusion, enhance equity, improve administrative coherence, and uphold legal standards established by the RPwD Act, 2016

²² Times of India. (2025, November 16). Haryana retirement age policy for disabled employees arbitrary: HC. <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/gurgaon/haryana-retirement-age-policy-for-disabled-employees-arbitrary-hc/articleshow/125355063.cms>

²³ Sharma, A. & Pathak, N. (2025, February 4). Budget for national social assistance programme remains stagnant yet again. *The Wire*. <https://thewire.in/news/budget-for-national-social-assistance-programme-remains-stagnant-yet-again>

²⁴ MoRD. (2013). *Proposal for comprehensive national social assistance programme: Report of the task force*. https://nsap.nic.in/nsap/Report_Task_Force_Comprehensive_NSAP.pdf

Table 6.3: Estimated beneficiary coverage by 2030					
Scheme	Existing Coverage	2011	2025	2030	Estimated Coverage Expected by 2030 @ 20% Poverty Rate
IGNOAPS	2,21,30,687	10.52 Crore	16.68 Crore (+58.6%)	20.23 Crore (+92.3%)	4.05 Crore
IGNWPS	67,83,469	4.69 Crore	5.17 Crore (+16.5%)	5.43 Crores (+23.1%)	1.09 Crore
IGNDPS	8,33,751	2.76 Crore	3.19 Crores (+15.6%)	3.37 Crores (+22%)	0.67 Crore

In view of the projected increase in vulnerable populations by 2030 and the estimated coverage requirements based on a 20 per cent poverty rate, the continuation of static central beneficiary caps risks diluting the effectiveness of NSAP. It is therefore recommended that the central beneficiary **caps under the Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS) and the Indira Gandhi National Disability Pension Scheme (IGNDPS) be revised upward by at least 15-20 per cent**, in line with the projected growth in the respective target populations. Further, given the substantially higher increase in the elderly population, the central beneficiary **cap under the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS) may be increased by at least 25 per cent**, to ensure alignment with the estimated coverage requirement by 2030. Further, the beneficiary caps under NSAP may be indexed to demographic projections and revised once every five years, based on Census data or official population projections by the Registrar General of India, and growth trends in elderly, widow, and disability populations.

A timely upward revision of caps, along with an institutional mechanism for periodic updates, is essential to ensure that NSAP continues to provide minimum income security, dignity, and social protection to the most vulnerable sections of the population.

The detailed methodology adopted for estimating the population has been provided below:

Methodology for Population Projection and Disability Population Estimation

Step 1: Base Data Sources

The estimation of total and disabled population is based on the following secondary data sources:

- **Total Population:**

State-wise population figures from Census of India, 2011, used as the base year for projections.

- **Disability Population and Age Structure:**

- Census of India, 2011
- National Sample Survey (NSS) 76th Round – Disability in India, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), Government of India

Step 2: Population Projection Method (2018, 2025, 2030, 2035)

State-wise population projections are carried out using the Compound Annual Growth Rate (CAGR) method, with Census 2011 as the base year.

CAGR Formula

$$\text{CAGR} = \left(\frac{P_t}{P_0} \right)^{\frac{1}{n}} - 1$$

Where:

- P_0 = Population in the base year (2011)
- P_t = Population in the reference year
- n = Number of years between base and reference year

Population Projection Formula

$$P_y = P_{2011} \times (1 + \text{CAGR})^{(y-2011)}$$

Where:

- P_y = Projected population for year y
- y = 2018, 2025, 2030

This method is applied **state-wise** to ensure internal consistency and comparability across states.

Step 3: State-wise Disability Distribution

State-wise disability proportions are derived from:

NSS 76th Round – Disability in India

These proportions are assumed to remain stable over the projection period and are applied to the projected population to estimate future disability population.

Step 4: Census-based Age Group Ratio Calculation

To derive age-group-specific population ratios, Census 2011 age-wise population data is used.

The population aged 18–19 years is calculated by:

- Taking the total population in the 15–19 years age group, and
- Subtracting the population of 18–19 years

Subsequently:

- The percentage share of each age group from 18 to 79 years is calculated with respect to the total population.
- These percentages are summed to obtain the cumulative proportion of population aged 18–79 years.
- The remaining population is categorized under the 80+ age group.

Step 5: Distribution of Disabled Population by Age Group

The total projected disabled population is distributed into the following age groups:

- 18–79 years
- 80 years and above

This distribution is carried out using age-group percentage ratios derived from Census 2011, ensuring consistency between population structure and disability estimates.

6.4.5 Recommendations on Improving Scheme Implementation

Beneficiary Identification

Evidence from the field indicates that many eligible elderly persons, widows, and persons with disabilities were excluded from the scheme because the targeting process relied heavily on outdated BPL lists. To address this, **a robust verification system for beneficiary identification** should be established. The existing BPL list may be retained as a preliminary reference but should be supplemented with a **simple vulnerability assessment form** at the Gram Panchayat level. This form should capture key socio-economic details such as caste, income, household dependents, land ownership, widowhood, and disability status. The collected data can then be **validated using Social Registries or other integrated beneficiary databases (such as Family ID databases)**, where available, to accurately ascertain applicants' eligibility for the scheme.

Gram Panchayats may conduct **annual verification drives** during Gram Sabha meetings, displaying updated lists publicly for community validation. **States such as Haryana, which effectively uses its**

Family ID system, can serve as reference models. State governments should be entrusted with the responsibility to define its own inclusion criteria based on local characteristics and administrative capacity, while ensuring transparency and accountability. The Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) may provide a standard verification framework and inclusion template for reference, allowing states the flexibility to customize it for their implementation context.

Streamlining Application, Verification, and Appeal Process

The study observed significant variation across states in how applications are received, verified, and sanctioned. To bring consistency and accountability, **uniform Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) should be developed by MoRD and adopted by all states.** The SOPs should clearly define timelines and responsibilities for:

- Application receipt (both online and offline, in local language)
- Document verification
- Sanction or rejection
- Appeal and review mechanism
- Annual re-verification of beneficiaries

These **SOPs should be translated into regional languages, disseminated to all Gram Panchayats, and integrated with NSAP-PPS for time-stamped tracking of each stage.** Training modules for Panchayat Secretaries and SHG representatives can be developed to ensure effective implementation.

Ensuring Timely and Accessible Pension Payments

Although Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) has improved pension delivery, delays and biometric authentication failures still hinder timely payments, especially in rural and hilly regions such as Jammu and Kashmir. Beneficiaries, particularly the elderly and persons with disabilities often face difficulties traveling to banks or Common Service Centres (CSCs) for withdrawals. To address these challenges:

- **Alternative authentication methods such as OTP or PIN-based verification** should be enabled in case of biometric or connectivity issues.
- **For beneficiaries above 80 years of age or with severe disabilities, states should institutionalize doorstep pension delivery models,** drawing on best practices from Haryana (bank tie-ups for home visits) and Andhra Pradesh (village-level pension disbursement day).
- Any delay beyond the fixed disbursement date should trigger **an automatic alert** to the Block Nodal Officer, who must ensure resolution within 15 days.

MoRD may issue an advisory directing banks and state nodal agencies **to certify Business Correspondents (BCs) for home delivery in such cases.**

Strengthening the Social Audit Process

Despite being mandated, social audits under NSAP are not regularly conducted in most Gram Panchayats. To enhance transparency and community oversight, states should **institutionalize the annual social audits for NSAP at the Gram Panchayat level with participation from community members, SHGs, and ward representatives.**

A **digital audit checklist** may be used to simplify the process and standardize reporting. An Action Taken Report (ATR) must be prepared and publicly displayed within 30 days of each audit. **MoRD may develop a mobile-based data entry form for uploading audit findings to NSAP-PPS.**

Revamping the Grievance Redressal Mechanism

Grievance redressal systems vary widely across states and are often poorly documented. Many beneficiaries are still unaware of where or how to lodge complaints, and there is limited monitoring of resolution timelines.

To improve accountability, a **three-tier Grievance Redressal Mechanism** should be established at the Gram Panchayat, District, and State levels, fully integrated with NSAP-PPS. Beneficiaries **should be able to submit complaints through multiple channels like Gram Sabha register, toll-free helpline, SMS, or WhatsApp** and receive an auto-generated acknowledgment number along with periodic status updates.

Unresolved cases at the Panchayat level should automatically escalate to the district office within 15 days and to the state social welfare department after 30 days. **Quarterly analysis of grievance trends should be conducted to identify recurring issues** such as payment delays or bank-related problems and take corrective actions accordingly.

Monitoring and Evaluation

Although NSAP-PPS provides comprehensive data, it remains underutilized for real-time decision-making or policy feedback. There is a need to **shift from administrative reporting to data-driven monitoring and evidence-based evaluation.** A **dashboard-based monitoring** system should be institutionalized at the state and district levels to track coverage, payment timeliness, grievance resolution, and audit completion rates. Existing MIS platforms can be enhanced or integrated with NSAP-PPS to ensure efficiency. Additionally, **independent third-party evaluations should be conducted** every three years to assess scheme performance, inclusion, and beneficiary satisfaction. Performance indicators should be linked to annual state-level review meetings to promote accountability and continuous improvement.

6.4.6 Other Recommendations

Local Monitoring

At the District and Gram Panchayat level, strong local monitoring and facilitation mechanisms should be devised for ensuring transparency, accuracy, and last-mile efficiency in NSAP implementation. Each GP should maintain an **updated live register of beneficiaries**, to ensure real-time tracking of active beneficiaries and easy public access. To maintain the integrity of beneficiary data, **annual verification and enrolment camps** should be organized for inclusion of newly eligible individuals and removal of ineligible or deceased beneficiaries. Transparency can be further enhanced by **publicly displaying fund release and disbursement details** on GP notice boards and discussing them during Panchayat meetings.

Strengthening last-mile delivery

To further strengthen last-mile support, **beneficiary facilitation centres at the village or ward level could be established** which would serve as a single-point interface between beneficiaries and social security service providers. These centres can assist with registration, application form filling, verification of applications, appeal, grievance resolution, and regular updates on scheme entitlements. **Local volunteers or members of SHGs, ASHA, or elected PRI representatives could be engaged** to assist the elderly, widowed, and disabled beneficiaries navigate documentation and banking processes. Periodic capacity-building of these volunteers by district officials should be conducted to increase their effectiveness.

In Haryana, the Social Welfare Department has established a successful system in collaboration with banks, wherein if a beneficiary is too old, disabled or suffering from medical issues, they can inform the bank, which then completes the necessary formalities and sends a representative to disburse the pension amount at the beneficiary's residence. This initiative ensures that the most vulnerable recipients receive their benefits without any hardship or dependence on others. **Similar mechanisms for doorstep or assisted benefit delivery can be adopted by other states to strengthen last-mile access, particularly for elderly and differently-abled beneficiaries who face challenges in visiting banks or payment centres.**

Convergence with other schemes

Establishing **convergence with other welfare schemes** can improve the procedural efficiencies at state level. Many states run parallel welfare programs for elderly, widow and disabled. Establishing data-sharing or referral mechanisms among the divisions catering to similar target groups may help expand the outreach of the programmes among eligible beneficiaries. Also, a mechanism may be put in place where non-eligible people would be directed to other appropriate state scheme (like Cheyutha Pension Scheme in Telangana or Laxmibai Samajik Suraksha Pension Yojana in Bihar). The beneficiaries can also be linked with other complementary schemes such as PM Awas Yojana, NFSA, Health Insurance schemes and other livelihood initiatives to enhance social and economic resilience.

Such convergence may help prevent overlaps and leverage existing outreach networks. At the State level, a Convergence Committee could be set up consisting of Heads of various departments such as Health, Social Justice, Social Welfare, Rural Development etc. in order to devise unique ways of convergence.

Annexure:

Photos Captured from Field



State-level in-depth interview (IDI) with Deputy Director, Social Security Department, Patna, Bihar



In-depth Interview (IDI) with Gram panchayat members in village Mohtara, Bemetara, Chhattisgarh



Focus Group Discussion with beneficiaries in Pandaravada Perumandi GP, Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu



Beneficiary interview, Vemulapalli village, Bhupalapalli District, Telangana



Beneficiary interview, Jammu and Kashmir



Beneficiary interview, Bihar